Challenging the Boundaries

EDITED BY

IŞIL BAŞ AND DONALD C. FREEMAN

Challenging the Boundaries

PALA

POETICS AND LINGUISTICS ASSOCIATION

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Işıl Baş and Donald C. Freeman

for the

Poetics and Linguistics Association

Rodopi

Amsterdam - New York, NY 2007

Cover design: Aart Jan Bergshoeff

The paper on which this book is printed meets the requirements of
"ISO 9706: 1994, Information and documentation - Paper for documents -
Requirements for permanence".

ISBN: 978-90-420-2242-3
Editions Rodopi B.V., Amsterdam - New York, NY 2007
Printed in The Netherlands

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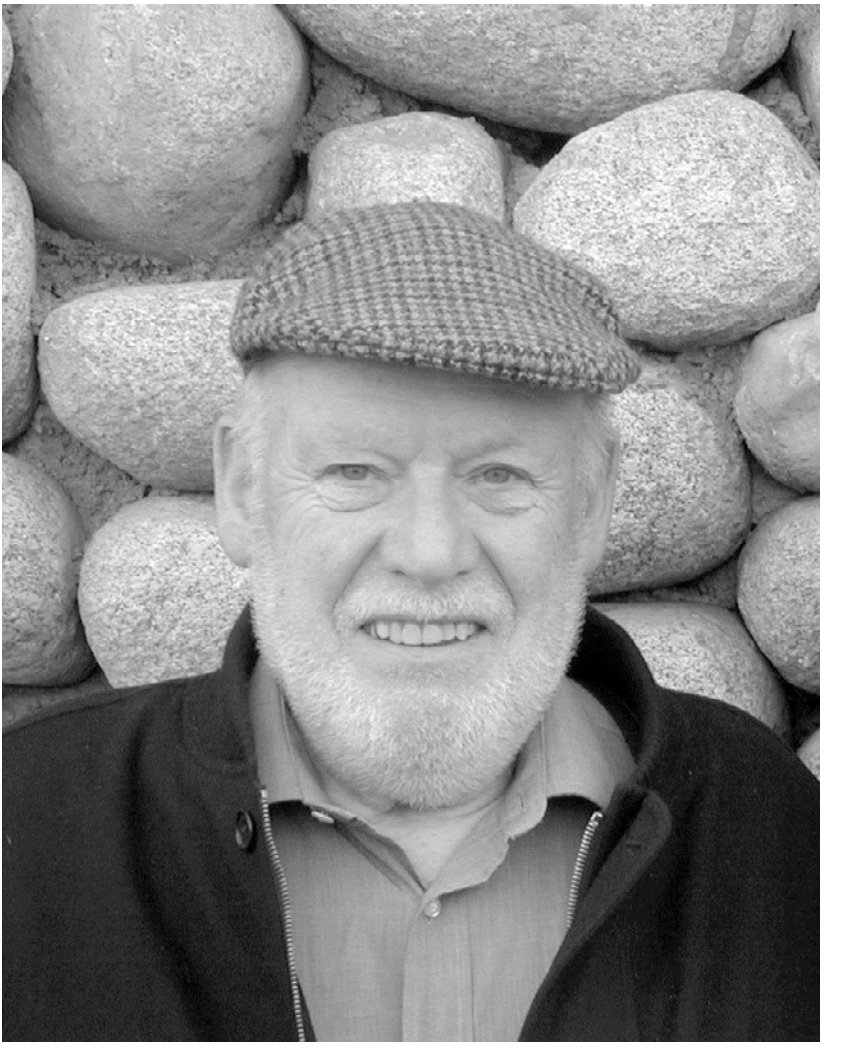

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Professor John McHardy Sinclair
1933-2007

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At present she is working on another monograph focused on metatropes as large figures of human thought and language. An active member of IALS (International Association of Literary Semantics), she is currently serving on the editorial board of *Journal of Literary Semantics*.

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Henrik Schärfe is Assistant Professor of Communication, Aalborg University, Denmark. He researches narrative theory and has a special

interest in epistemic narratology in various forms, including both cognitive and cultural prerequisites for narrative phenomena. His doctoral work (completed in 2004) focused on charting the foundations for a theory of narrativity and, within this epistemological framework, addressed various computational aspects of narrative. His publications include work on narrative aspects on artificial intelligence, temporal logic, and formal ontology. He also serves as editor of a section on narrative theory in the forthcoming *Danish Encyclopædia of Media and Communication Theory*.

The late **John Sinclair** was Professor Emeritus of Modern English Language at the University of Birmingham, where he spent most of his career. His education and early work was at the University of Edinburgh, where he began his interest in corpus linguistics, stylistics, grammar and discourse analysis. He was president of The Tuscan Word Centre in Italy. Professor Sinclair held an honorary doctorate in philosophy from the University of Gothenburg, and an honorary professorship in the Universities of Jiao Tong, Shanghai and Glasgow. He was an honorary life member of the Linguistics Association of Great Britain, a member of the Academia Europæa, and founding editor-in-chief of the Cobuild series of language reference materials.

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Introduction*

Işıl Baş
Donald C. Freeman

Like desire, language disrupts, refuses to be contained within boundaries.
—bell hooks, 1994

A book on challenging boundaries presents its editors with two basic difficulties. The first is trying to pin down a concept referring to phenomena that are diverse and rapidly shifting. After all, in a world where bodies, goods and information are constantly moving across social, spatial and virtual worlds, what are boundaries other than anachronistic constructs belonging to a bygone era that genuinely believed in clear lines of separation guaranteeing order and stability? In the words of Bauman (1998: 75), 'One cannot "stay put" in moving sands'. While the study of boundaries, with its emphasis on the constructed nature and changing functions of boundaries, is a recent field in the humanities, as early as 1911 Ellen Churchill Semple remarked that 'nature abhors fixed boundaries' (216). Hence writing about challenging boundaries is perhaps an impossible task, as once ideas are written down they inevitably collapse into fixity and stasis. However, at the start of the 21st century, just as we have started to free ourselves from the 'boundedness' of traditional boundaries we are once again confronted with new distinctions that result from recent political events and tensions. In the wake of new categorisations we felt that it would be significant to explore both the old and the new boundaries in language and literature from an interdisciplinary, multifaceted, and challenging perspective.

**Editors' Note*: In this volume we have sought to observe the typographical conventions in the Roman alphabet of the diverse linguistic backgrounds of our contributors.

This volume comprises the edited collection of selected essays from PALA's 23rd annual conference, held in Istanbul, an ancient, symbolic city that some associate with 'hybridity' and others with 'boundary'. All of these contributions in their different ways address, describe, analyse, define, extend, imagine, apply, reveal, problematise, and even reassert or invent textual, disciplinary, ideological, and educational boundaries. It is this diversity that poses the second challenge to our volume. Any attempt to follow a methodological and thematic framework would have been paradoxical.

While acknowledging the fact that our volume might be organised in many different ways, we decided to open with an article by **John Sinclair**, who as one of the founders of stylistics in Britain in the 1960s historicises and explores the current decline of this field of analysis that 'bridges' the gap between linguistics and literary study. In his keynote address, 'The Exploitation of Meaning: Literary Text and Local Grammars', Sinclair proposes that one reason for the limited success of contemporary, linguistically orientated stylistics is the unsuitability of conventional accounts of grammar and vocabulary for the description of literary texts and effects. Instead, Sinclair argues, we should be moving toward recognising a plurality of meaning sources that gives rise to local grammars accounting for multivalent relations between structure and meaning.

Willie van Peer gave his valedictory chair's address at the Istanbul conference, an edited version of which, '"The not-me in thee": Crossing Boundaries Through Literature', is presented here. In this essay, van Peer starts by investigating the ways in which identities are formed by creating 'boundaries' between the individual self and the other and argues that literature serves as a corrective to this 'freezing' of identification of others that is part of human spiritual ontogeny. That it does so, he asserts, arises from the tendency of literary fictions to undermine entrenched views and ideological positions, an important reason why totalitarian regimes of all kinds fear and try to inhibit literary creativity. Literature, on this argument, is thus the ultimate challenge to every human boundary.

It is true that there is nothing in human reality that is not marked by a boundary. From the natural sciences to the humanities, from our everyday lives to our subconscious, boundaries have the most

persistent ontological status. As commonly defined, a boundary is something that indicates or fixes a limit. To Immanuel Kant, however, boundary and limit were not to be used interchangeably. In his famous conclusion to his *Prolegomena to any Future Metaphysics*, Kant, with his ontological commitment to an already constituted and permanent reality and unknowable outside makes a distinction between *Grenzen* and *Schranken*, the former meaning 'bounds' – natural scientists confronting or contacting a stopping point in their attempt at exploring the 'given' – while the latter, translated as 'limit', indicates incompleteness, in reference to the impossibility of knowing about the 'outside'.

Daniel Defert, on the other hand, in his keynote address approaches the concept of the 'limit' from the perspective of Foucault, who, while acknowledging Kant's innovative search for the limits and structures of truth, is also known to have criticised him for closing the space he himself opened. As a sociologist himself and one of the closest persons to Foucault, Defert, in 'Foucault: Explorer of the Limitless Reign of the Limits', sheds light on how Foucault viewed madness, sexuality, and literature as sites for the transgression of limits – sites that are themselves viewed in terms of Western interiority or subjectivity.

In her multidisciplinary essay, 'Vatic Craft: The Science and Poetics of Perception', winner of the 2003 PALA Prize for the best paper presented at the conference, **Sharon Lattig** seeks to reconcile through neurobiology the traditionally conflicting views of the poet as *vates*, as prophet, and the poet as maker. Drawing on contemporary research in neurodynamics, she argues that *poeisis*, poetic making, is a product of memory, whereas the prophetic or vatic source is to be found in sense data. Both of these poetic impulses are rendered mutually constructive and simultaneous through recursivity.

Henrik Schärfe posits Succession, Transformation, and Mediation as the three 'Grand Principles of Narratology' specified in his essay's title. Succession, for Schärfe, corresponds to narrative syntax, a function creating narrative coherence. Transformation corresponds to narrative semantics, assigning a significance to correlating properties of textual elements as these are distributed throughout a narrative. Mediation, Schärfe argues, corresponds to narrative pragmatics, focusing on issues of intentionality and relevance. The combination of

these principles and their semiotic dimension yields an explanatory Narrative Matrix according to which different narratologies can be comparatively evaluated.

In his pioneering work *Orientalism* (1978), Edward Said examined the way boundaries separating the West from the East were constructed and represented. According to Said colonial discourse actively seeks the Other/Orient by inventing binaries of absolute difference, especially in literary texts used as sites for cultural hegemony. In 'The Ottoman Phenomenon and Edward Said's Monolithic Discourse on the Orient', **Esin Akalın** challenges Said's model of 'fixity' in ideological constructions, an issue which other postcolonial critics like Homi Bhabha and Robert Young also problematised by pointing out the cross-fertilisation of linguistic, political, and cultural forms and practices in the colonising and the colonised countries. Considering a range of plays written about the Ottomans in the 16th, 17th, and 18th centuries in England and France, Akalın explores the relationship between 'the Turk' as constructed in these plays and the real, material Ottoman Empire as a complex historical phenomenon, one that Said's work largely ignores.

Mikhail Bakhtin was not directly involved in the post-colonialist agenda. His approach involved the richness of meaning attained as a result of mixture of languages within a text rather than cultural mixings. Nevertheless, Bakhtin's emphasis on hybrid texts containing 'doubleness' of voices that are composed through a series of dialogical counterpoints, each set against the other, can effectively be used to trace aesthetic challenges to hegemonic discourses. In a similar vein, **Dilek Kantar** examines stylistic hybrids in *The White Castle*, by the Turkish novelist Orhan Pamuk, using Bakhtin's concept of 'dialogic heteroglossia'. The novel's main characters, the Ottoman 'master' and the Italian 'slave', personify Eastern and Western modes of thinking, respectively; the stylistic hybrids effectuate a coalescence of the speech patterns implicating these opposing ideologies. Kantar shows how these hybrids interact with various narrative elements in the novel.

Elżbieta Chrzanowska-Kluczewska argues, in 'Logical/Textual Space vs. Physical Space: Same or Different?', that a link, the notion of textual space and the theory of possible worlds, exists between the logical and textual space of literary artworks and the physical space of

architecture and other visual arts. Although the two fields rely on similar interpretive techniques like gap-filling, Chrzanowska-Kluczewska's analysis shows, logical/textual space is the more capacious of the two. She concludes that while physical space is finite, imaginary and hypothetical space is never bounded.

In 'Winding Through Lynchville Highway: Challenging the Curves of David Lynch's *Mulholland Drive*', **Ayşegül Gündoğdu** uses the abjection theory of the French linguist and philosopher Julia Kristeva to analyse David Lynch's landmark film *Mulholland Drive*. The Kristevan notion of primal loss and the resulting ambiguity that she claims is at the very core of all human existence defy all traditional understandings of identity as a unitary and stable form. To Kristeva one can never clearly define or differentiate his/her borders because of this horrifying ambiguity that always resists all systematisations and categorisations. Hence any attempt to fix a unified sense of ourselves or of our world is inevitably doomed. Gündoğdu shows that Lynch's film with its fractured structure and dark, hazy atmosphere is a good example of what Kristeva means by 'abject horror' threatening our ways of seeing and making meaning that are traditionally taken for granted. To Gündoğdu, the whole film is like 'an empty stage' displaying 'the splits of one's discourse as well as of one's attempts to cover them up'.

Nil Korkut's starting point is John Gerlach's (1989) observation on the fluid boundaries between modes of narrative and genres as she analyses the lyrical short story 'The Mark on the Wall', by Virginia Woolf. Korkut treats this highly personal contemplative story as an instance of the boundary between the narrative and lyric modes in terms of Woolf's use of plot, time and the role of the narrator. Furthermore she concludes that this 'hybrid' approach of both employing and resisting the narrative mode at one and the same time is not just a modernist method but also a strategy with which Woolf expected women writers to create their own style. This purpose is well served by including the lyric within the narrative, Korkut argues; at the same time, this inclusion opens up space for a feminine style of writing that exposes the inadequacy of narrative as the sole dominant mode in fiction.

The issue of finding a voice is of primary concern not just for women but for all those who are marginalised, subordinated and labeled as the

negative 'other' by dominant ideologies that work in fundamental complicity with Cartesian dualistic metaphysics. Hence what is considered disruptive or transgressive of boundaries is also hailed as liberating for unheard voices that struggle to suspend social binaries grounding power relations. In 'Engaging the Other in the Self: The Bodily Experience of Virtual Imagery', **Binnie Brook Martin** analyses *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil*, a film by the Senegalese director Djibril Diop Mambéty, as an example of how the young Senegalese voices in the film, normally missing inside the normative power structures, are invoked by a set of alternative filmic techniques upsetting the traditional viewer-subject relationship. Mambéty's shot compositions that create a coalescence of accessible, assimilated images of the actual with visionary and imaginary musings of the virtual give rise to a participatory spectatorship. This effect, Martin asserts, transforms the western viewer from all-knowing passive observer to creator of links and mediator of signs that serve a larger human continuum.

With **Nina Nørgaard**'s essay, the focus turns to the boundaries between linguistics and literary studies. Nørgaard extends Halliday and Hasan's concept of cohesion in literary texts to include metaphorical relations that are usually far apart, as well as ties between textual elements that encompass far longer passages than customarily are considered in discussions of literary cohesion. 'What Can Literature Do for Linguistics? Metaphorical Synonymy and Distant Cohesion in James Joyce's *Ulysses*' effectively shows how Joyce uses cohesion as a meaning-making resource; at the same time, Nørgaard's analysis shows how the concept of cohesion can and should be extended.

In 'Humpty Dumpty's Fall: Failing to See the Writing on the Wall', **Hande Tekdemir** discusses the potential in Lewis Carroll's *Through The Looking-Glass* for challenging and overturning conventional values as these are imbedded in language. For Carroll and his fictional creation Humpty Dumpty, words do not suffice to fill in the gaps of language, and so Humpty explores alternative semantic constructions (of which 'un-birthday' is perhaps the most famous). Humpty's loneliness, Tekdemir concludes, shows that we are both the victims of language and its survivors because language is both a social and a highly idiosyncratic phenomenon.

The final article in this volume deals with one of the most hotly contested debates in contemporary theory. As opposed to the 'somatophobia' of traditional disciplines that base their foundations on the so-called 'unbridgeable' gulf between mind and body, contemporary life and human sciences acknowledge 'the fact that bodies construct and in turn are constructed by an interior, a physical and signifying view-point, a consciousness or perspective'. (Grosz 1994: 8) The corporeality of writers and texts and the way they interact is **Fiona Tomkinson**'s point of departure in 'Crossing the Boundaries of Flesh and Narrative'. French feminist theory has already introduced the concept of 'writing from the body', a 'feminine' and 'feminist' way of writing that challenges the dissolution of boundaries between the physical and the spiritual as well as those between the poetic and the theoretical. Tomkinson starts by examining Hélène Cixous's own style as a perfect example of that kind of boundary-crossing and engages in the question whether or not something is lost when the demarcation between the pre-reflective and language is erased. Accompanied by evocations of current phenomenological theories of 'flesh', she extends the Ricoeurian theory of metaphor and the pre-reflective to cover narrative and judgement and beyond, employing the theoretical constructs of chiasm and dialectic without synthesis as posited by Maurice Merleau-Ponty, with examples from Keats and Lawrence.

As we suggested at the outset, all of these articles point to a movement, a flow of concepts, models and methodologies rather than a fixed and specified position; hence as editors we risk a slippage from a focus or style in terms of our presentation of different emphases in the three-dimensional space that our contributors created. We trust that our readers will discover their own dialogue with the particular horizons articulated in each of these essays.

We end on a sad note. Just as we were sending this book off to the publisher, word reached us of the death of Professor John Sinclair, one of the keynote speakers at the Istanbul conference and a longtime friend of PALA. Professor Sinclair's keynote address opens this volume, which we dedicate to his memory with affection and respect.

Bebek-Istanbul and Heath, Massachusetts
April, 2007

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The Exploitation of Meaning: Literary Text and Local Grammars

John Sinclair

Abstract

This paper reviews the position of stylistics in linguistic and literary study, tracing, for the author, the origins of the approach in the 1950s and its relatively low profile recently. The interim conclusion is that, while the main contention of textually orientated linguists holds – that literary text is organised along linguistic principles – the apparatus of linguistics was and is neither mature nor flexible enough to offer reliable and replicable descriptions of stylistic phenomena.

The main part of the paper focuses on Pope's *Essay on Man*, and discusses in detail a single verse paragraph. This is highly mannered poetry, and shows up the inadequacy of conventional descriptions of the grammar and vocabulary in arriving at, or even moving towards, a satisfactory description of the way in which the text makes its meaning.

An alternative view of the relation between structure and meaning is then offered, and the notion of *local grammar* is invoked and applied. By recognising a plurality of meaning sources, a portfolio of local grammars is assembled, which can even compete with each other and give rise to different meanings of the same text.

This result is in harmony with growing perceptions both within linguistics and beyond its borders that the large and complex single-source grammars that have been developed in the last century cannot do their designated job, and need the support of local grammars.

Key words: stylistics; heroic couplet; local grammar; arrest; rhetorical structure; antithesis.

> Words are like Leaves; and where they most abound
> Much Fruit of Sense beneath is rarely found
>
> Alexander Pope, *An Essay on Criticism*

1. Introduction

When I first went to university, PALA had not been founded and there was no organisation like it. In British universities, 'Language' was taught in a strongly diachronic tradition, rarely venturing into the modern period. Linguistics did not exist as an undergraduate subject.

Most youngsters opted for Literature. Literature was presented in historical slices, related to ideas and classical influences, and there was some study of texts. Contemporary and recent literature was left undisturbed. Drama was seen as text, and I recall that my head of department was uneasy about his students presenting actual performances of Shakespeare in case the plays might be mistaken for entertainment.

I believe that my alma mater, Edinburgh University, was the first to take English literature seriously. An appointment was made in 1762 of Professor Hugh Blair to a new chair of Rhetoric and Belles Lettres. The early emphasis on rhetoric continued, and perhaps helped to pave the way for stylistics some 200 years later.

The structure of the honours degree in Edinburgh in the 1950s required a student to study subjects from at least two departments to a final honours level, which meant in practice that the literature specialists found themselves with at least one finals paper in the dreaded Language area.[1] By the time I came to finals, an agreeable accommodation of this requirement had been reached, and a special paper had been devised for the literature stream. It had a long, unmemorable name, like 'English Language – literary and colloquial usage from 1350 to the present day', but was universally known as 'Paper Eight'.[2]

I bring this to your attention partly because there is in the story a link with our host country for this PALA conference, Turkey. The lectures for Paper Eight in my year, 1954-5, were given by the Language professor, the brilliant and innovative Angus McIntosh, and a promising young scholar just up from Oxford called Jim Ure. After an unavoidable absence on Her Majesty's Service, I returned to Edinburgh as a research student and soon became involved in the work of Paper Eight. Jim Ure meanwhile had taken a year out as a British Council Lecturer in Turkey, and was so charmed by this country and its people that he secured a permanent job with the Council, left academic life and returned to Turkey.

So this is my first reason for being grateful to Turkey in my career: Turkey lured away Jim Ure, and I got his job – and with it a substantial role in Paper Eight. Linguistics, meanwhile, was on the move. Edinburgh had appointed a lecturer, Michael Halliday, and had

attracted J. R. Firth from retirement to support the establishment of linguistics courses – Firth had just published 'Modes of Meaning' (Firth 1957) and was keen on applying his contextual theory to literary texts, and Halliday adapted to his new surroundings with some powerful stylistic analyses (e. g. Halliday 2003).[3]

The view commonly taken by linguists in those early days was that there was nothing sacred or even ultimately mysterious about the way in which literary texts made meaning. No text was exempt from conventional linguistic analysis, and indeed it was claimed that such analysis would reveal relevant insights into how the texts were constructed and how the special effects were created. The long-term aim was to build a bridge between the objectively orientated disciplines of grammar, phonology, etc., and the subjective responses made in a sensitive critical reading. In simplistic terms, the linguists pointed out that literature was written in language and that the known conventions of language patterning were at least the starting-points for any discussion of the meaning of the text. Even if it was to be shown that literary text communicated in an unorthodox fashion, the ordinary meaningful patterns of the language were inescapable and had to be addressed. Although it was conceded that the ordinary patterns might in some circumstances be downgraded, the idea of dismissing them as irrelevant was not a serious option for descriptive linguists of the period.

The reactions of our literary colleagues ranged from occasional cautious interest, through scepticism to hostility, and there were some tense moments in discussions at both local and national level.

Edinburgh, of course, was not alone in this development. Randolph Quirk in Durham, then London, and Roger Fowler, first in Hull and then in East Anglia, were also probing the potential of grammar and phonology beyond the previous borders. In the United States, A. A. Hill was a pioneer in the late 1950s, and the most revered linguistics scholar of his generation, Roman Jacobson, published a paper (Jacobson 1960) that served as a rallying point for some years afterwards, and no doubt is responsible for the P in PALA.

By the mid-1960s stylistics in the United Kingdom was flourishing, conference sessions were devoted to it and journals started to appear. Then it slowly declined in popularity; it remained as a minority

interest and kept a place in the intellectual map, supported by the emergence of PALA, but it has never, in the eyes of some, realised its potential.

There are all sorts of reasons that can be adduced to account for this. Those who take a gladiatorial view of academic controversies can point to the bruising criticism of, for example, Stanley Fish (e. g., 1973), but the scholars who were striving for a measure of linguistic rigor, such as it was, were well aware of the shortcomings of their methodology. An evolutionary explanation of the decline would be that the study of literature evolved from within to make it resistant to voices of reform from outside. Western European scholars were developing a structuralist position from within the literary discipline, which played the role of an antidote to the infection of stylistics, and this reform received powerful support when important advances in the USSR became known. Although written in the 1930s, the work, for example, of Mikhail Bakhtin filtered through to the West a generation later and was very influential.

However, the main reason for the decline of stylistics was that linguists were not principally engaged in an attack on literary criticism, nor in a takeover bid, nor even in the preparation of a toolkit for literary analysis; their key concern was to develop their discipline to account for the particularly complex and powerful medium of literary text. The reason for the decline in stylistics was the failure of this enterprise, and the failure was pretty comprehensive. There was, and is, no lack of ingenious application of linguistic categories to literary works, with penetrating insights and fascinating comparisons, but there is no theory to explain how the patterns relate to meaning, no guarantee that the same patterns in another text will create the same effects, no detailed, comprehensive descriptive apparatus that is flexible enough to accommodate the extremely varied language of literature. Given this insecurity, and the locus of stylistics as perilously reliant on sensitive interpretation, it is not surprising that a set of techniques soon grew up, seamlessly connecting rigorous linguistic analysis and pretty straightforward subjective impressions. This was *not* the bridge that the first adventurers in stylistics were aiming to build – quite the contrary. Rather than a bridge, this was a crude causeway that muddied the waters considerably.

As well as the essentially *ad hoc* nature of a stylistic description,[4] most of it was also small-scale. Lexis was hooked on the word, and grammar on the clause; the phonological units were also small. But worst of all, it was common to come across a stretch of text that clearly had an emotional effect, perhaps gloomy, perhaps uplifting, perhaps threatening, but the linguist had no means of explaining why it was so. Stylistic analysis was, and is, irretrievably patchy.

Like many scholars and teachers of language of my generation, the initial impetus that I had to take up language work was a flight from literary study rather than a positive yearning for mainstream language work as it was presented at that time. I tried an experiment after graduation – I wrote (just for myself) a literary appreciation of an important poem, using biographical and circumstantial evidence and arguing convincingly an interpretation that I did not believe in for one moment. I concluded that this was a game rather than a serious intellectual pursuit, and that I had undergone years of laborious training in order to become a kind of superior snake-oil salesman. Like the last Edinburgh professor but one, I sought a discipline where it was normal to argue systematically from data.[5]

The new availability of electronic computers gave promise of good things to come, and were beginning to be used in authorship studies, but they were hopelessly crude for anything to do with meaning. But meanwhile the philosopher J. L. Austin (1962) had given the initial impetus to the study of discourse, and linguists began to glimpse the possibilities of describing language above the sentence – discourse and text structure. This occupied me in the 1970s, and the serious study of large corpora started in the 1980s. After 10 years or so corpus evidence began to find its way into literary explication, e.g. Louw (1993), but there was still no theoretical underpinning – only more reliable evidence, especially about word combinations.

During the 1990s I was developing a rather technical piece of software with Geoff Barnbrook, having no idea at the time of the broad-ranging relevance this might have. The umbrella notion is that of *local grammars*, derived from very modest suggestions by Maurice Gross in 1993. Gross was not alone in noticing that general grammars were inherently incapable of coping with many small but perfectly normal constructions that appear in corpora, often as simple as sums of money, addresses and phone numbers, names and titles. Gross

suggested that small, dedicated grammars, which could be quite unlike the large general ones, were the kind of supplementary arsenal that was needed to make a comprehensive account of language in use. What is now known as 'named entity recognition' is the kind of descriptive area that arises to cope with structures that require special attention (Grishman 1997).

Once proposed, it was clear that the idea of local grammars was one that could run and run, and it has developed strongly over the last decade. In this paper I suggest one of the ways in which local grammars can be applied to the systematic study of literary texts.

From a PALA perspective, then, my career has been a long odyssey starting from dissatisfaction with the methods of literary study. From there I worked in stylistics until frustrated by lack of a sound theory and a good toolkit. Searching for these, I developed a descriptive framework for spoken discourse, and made several attempts, not very successful, to generalise from this interactive model of conversation to the structure of written documents. I have returned to that venture recently, but at the time I moved on to work in a more focused fashion with text corpora, and in particular the development of software for corpus research and applications. The situation as of now is that I have assembled the components of a descriptive apparatus that, if not fully adequate as yet for literary description, is at least more firmly footed than when I started. I feel I can now face PALA with something to say.

It sounds all neat and tidy and purposeful, but of course it wasn't. It was the usual hurly-burly, grasping opportunities as they arose, and riding research on top of teaching and commercial contracts.

2. Objectivity

One theme that you can detect from the above is my preference for research that is founded on principles of maximal attainable objectivity, procedures that are as replicable as possible. While I think we should always be guided ultimately by our own personal taste and intuition, the more of our reasoning that we can place in the public domain, the better. 'Ferocious empiricism' was Patrick Hanks' phrase for my attitude to research (1997) and I am proud to wear that tag. Even within empirical linguistics, we are much too quick to take our eye off the language text in front of us and replace it by something

like it but a little more abstract and manageable, or to look *through* the language to some separate arena of meaning instead of looking *at* the language and seeing the meaning being created in front of our eyes.

The computer has no taste, nor intuition, and so it has to be instructed explicitly in its searches, and the accuracy of its output reflects precisely the accuracy of the understanding of language of the researcher who programs it. To work at this level of explicitness is laborious, slow and demanding, but it is a refreshing counterbalance to the slow slide back into subjectivity that we so often see.

The pressure to abandon replicable analysis is constant and strong. It is very tempting to follow the clear promptings of one's intuition, cut a few corners and get down to an issue that is socially or politically important, but too subtle for our current tools of objective description. Or we can just conjure up the evidence in our imagination, since we can claim command of a language, rather than checking it out, despite the frequent demonstrations that our intuitions cannot recover natural cotext. 'Discourse Analysis' morphs into 'Critical Discourse Analysis' to allow the researcher to adopt a subjective position, and after a while 'critical' can be dropped. The attempt to develop objective, replicable description of the way people converse with each other is subtly replaced by records of unique personal responses to text, usually driven by some ideology.

2.1. Computing methodology

The computer requires a set of instructions that are exact and comprehensive, so that each piece of data that it encounters can be immediately identified and processed according to its identification. This requirement highlights the gulf that exists between a string of characters and the meaning that can be derived from them. For a user of the language concerned the bridging of the gulf is effortless, and the meaning springs from the text, spoken or written, even in poor receptive conditions; for the computer there is as yet no reliable way of processing the text to reveal its meaning.

Since the beginning of linguistic computing, attempts to bridge this gulf have been many and varied, and the everyday software in use is typically full of shortcuts and partial fixes, leading to rather messy results. Statistical techniques are often used in order to sharpen the results, even in the knowledge that statistics is largely irrelevant in the

elucidation of meaning. The overall performance of current tools is far from satisfactory, and it is understandable that many scholars are not prepared to wait, or to handle inexact results from computers, even as stages in a methodology.

In recent years we have seen the development of hybrid methodologies to cope with this difficulty, of which the most prominent is what one might call 'heavy annotation'. A sophisticated descriptive framework is elaborated and a coding system devised to instantiate the description through textual annotations or 'tags'.

Annotations provide an alternative view of the text from the text itself. Over the years they have grown from simple textual mark-up that recorded aspects of the typography and layout of a written text that would otherwise be lost in transfer, to an open-ended opportunity to add classifications and commentaries to the text. The strangest aspect of annotation is the placement of the tags in the stream of text rather than running them in parallel – as if the researcher's notes had to interrupt the text at all times. There were probably reasons for this way back in the dark days when communication with the machines was awkward and rudimentary, but it has somehow stuck in many projects.

There are two types of annotation – those produced automatically and those introduced by off-line, human analysis. Automatic ones do not add to the total information given in the text, and they are a matter of convenience; tags that arise from an independent human analysis – what I am calling 'heavy' tags – introduce new information to the system, of a completely different order from the information derived from the stream of characters. These are not replicable, because if they were the computer could do the job; they have a substantial element of subjective judgement tucked away in a cloak of apparently objective tag assignment.

The strangeness is not in the desire or need to make a fairly subjective analysis of the text – this is everyday practice, whether or not computers are eventually involved. It is in the alternation of text and tag, where two logically incompatible views of a text are shuffled together like cards in a pack. This is a quite unnecessary confusion that can lead to the fallacious view that the two versions of the text

(the text itself and the tags) are somehow meaningfully merged; unfortunately accessing the tags obscures the text, and vice versa.

The main danger in the hybrid annotation method is that it looks more objective than it is, because the output is via the computer and the tagging looks very professional, and no doubt conforms to pompous recommendations by committees.

3. PALA priorities

Before coming to this meeting, I had wondered several times where PALA members, and where PALA itself, stood on methodology, whether computer-involved or not. I must confess that, having seen the programme and attended a number of sessions, I am no wiser. Also it seems that there is no PALA manifesto, no statement of topic area beyond the title, which is luxuriously broad, and no Terms of Reference, such as might be expected from an established and popular association in these days of Mission Statements. An inarticulate Association in the humanities is a rare creature, especially one apparently devoted to aspects of communication skills.

PALA members seem to be quite relaxed about this situation. Given its British origins, the lack of an explicit raison d'être may seem rather superior, like the non-existent British Constitution. New members are apparently attracted to PALA by other temptations than a fine call-to-arms, and of the other temptations there are many, especially on a sumptuous occasion such as this one. It does, however, leave visitors somewhat in the dark.

I proceed in the hope that at least some of the members respect my aim of improving the explicit, the shared, the replicable areas of language description, despite the shortcomings, the patience required, and the slow progress.

4. Heroic couplets

My research topic of choice as a tender postgraduate was the eighteenth-century couplet poetry of which Alexander Pope was the master; in particular, I thought *An Essay on Man* was much undervalued, as readers stayed with Pope's lighter satirical work, and no one wanted to read the more solemn pieces like the *Essay* or the translations of Homer. The excuse that we all mouthed for ignoring the Homer was that the couplet was not the right medium for the

grand sweep of Homer's verse, since the couplet focused on the half-line and not the verse paragraph.[6] Equally, it was felt that the couplet was not a convenient vessel for extended philosophical argument, although *An Essay on Man* won a prestigious prize for philosophical writing in Paris.

There were two toolkits that I had with which to study this complex language: the 'figures of speech' received from classical literature, and the emerging structural grammars; generative grammar was still in a primitive state at that time. The grammars made a tolerable job of dividing sentences into clauses, groups and phrases, and assigning structural values to the elements but took no account of the poetic form, and after an exhaustive syntactic analysis of the *Essay* it was not really clear what understanding had been achieved.

The figures of speech, chiasmus, anacoluthon, syllepsis, zeugma, etc. sounded like unfortunate things to happen to poetry, but they were in reality sketches for little local grammars. The most reliable crib was the long entry in Fowler's *Modern English Usage*, which offered a short definition of each figure and a good example (Fowler [1926] 1949: 597-627), but applying this information to text was another matter. The definitions were informal and relied heavily on interpretation, and the putative instances that one encountered in text were in large measure problematic. There were as many gaps – patterns that the ancients had not included – as examples of bona fide figures.

The couplet, especially in the strict control of Pope, was a natural vehicle for making comparisons, and the property associated with these comparisons was called *antithesis*. In literary study the term originally meant a position directly opposed to another, the *thesis*, but it was watered down to become a label for anything from straight antonymy, through various kinds of contrast and opposition to anything placed in a framework of comparison. The couplet was a natural carrier of this kind of pattern, with its paired lines and its option of paired half-lines as well, against a background of the neo-classical milieu of balance, symmetry and order.

The couplet has no monopoly of crisp antithetical statement. It is prominent in today's 'soundbites', and in much advertising. Consider a current Nissan advertisement:

WHAT OTHERS SELL AS EXTRAS
NISSAN GIVES AS STANDARD

The three contrasting pairs are clear when we put equivalent elements in a vertical relationship:

WHAT	OTHERS	SELL	AS	EXTRAS
	NISSAN	GIVES	AS	STANDARD

The main contrast is the final one between *extras* and *standard*, the implication being that since the luxuries are in with the price they are good value. The middle contrast is subtle, and can slip past subliminally: *sell* and *gives*. Clearly, Nissan is giving away absolutely nothing to anyone, and from that point of view it is a blatant lie, but the ever-popular idea of getting something for free is popped in. The tactic is the same as a bottle of cleaning fluid that boasts that the top 20% of its contents are 'free'.

The patterns of similarity from which these antitheses arise is pointed in heroic couplet poetry by the use of frequent and regular stops, where both the metre and the structure terminate, and we start almost from the beginning again. A large number of lines terminate in this way, and every second one adds rhyme into the rounding-up process. Quite a lot of lines even have a pause in the middle, so that sometimes every two or three words we have a boundary of some kind. Among the rich rhythmic variation that combinations of these options give rise to, there is one general rule that Pope observes carefully; the second line of the couplet has end-punctuation. This is called the *closed couplet*, and at times leads to apparently superfluous punctuation marks appearing because they ought to rather than that they serve a communicative function. One example of this could be the end of l. 6 in the passage quoted below from *An Essay on Man*.

The closed couplet is utterly different from the blank verse style of Shakespeare before Pope and Wordsworth after him, where a number of techniques were developed so that boundaries were somewhat rare, and verse paragraphs went on for many lines with no hope of stopping. Offsetting the grammar and the metre was one technique, setting up syntactic prospections (*arrest* – see Sinclair 1972), and adding more and more unexpected extensions to the structure was another (*release* – *op. cit.*). Since the romantics loosened up verse structure we have not returned to the tight control of the neo-classical

writers, and they are not easy to appreciate from a present-day standpoint.

The main way in which the couplet form is used is by successive couplets saying almost the same thing as each other. Instead of the meaning developing, changing and deepening as the poem progresses, the couplets pile up, all about equivalent to each other. Each one takes a slightly different angle on the central statement, adds fleshes it out a bit and adds some colourful images, but hardly progresses to another state. After several of these, there is a termination that expresses the central statement, now made powerful by the panorama of contributory statements.

In discussing Wordsworth's verse many years ago (*op. cit.*) I pointed out that the principal statements, coming at the end of verse paragraphs, were empowered by a kind of syntactic energy that came from the twin motors of arrest and release; the statements in themselves were, in isolation, somewhere between trivial and pathetic. In *Lines*, usually known as *Tintern Abbey*, one highly charged verse paragraph ends 'and rolls through all things'. Another ends 'we see into the life of things'. In their proper places at the ends of formidable verse paragraphs they are sonorous and profound, not in themselves but as energised by the verse.

Pope's technique is more reminiscent of the repetitive nature of the dance. I recall Benjamin Lee Whorf explaining the way in which Hopi dancing gained power through repetition; each repeat of the same movement gave it gravitas.[7] The repeats were never exactly the same, and the experience of each was slightly different, but they counted as repeats and so they added to the accumulation of power. If you just see them as the same thing again and again then they are pointless; Whorf said or implied that to a European a clock striking ten just tells you how many hours have passed; in Hopi culture this would be an impressive build-up of striking, more important than three o'clock.

An example

Consider one of Pope's verse paragraphs in *An Essay on Man*, the opening of Epistle II.

> Know then thyself, presume not God to scan;
> The proper study of mankind is man.
> Placed on this isthmus of a middle state,

A being darkly wise, and rudely great:
5 With too much knowledge for the sceptic side,
With too much weakness for the stoic's pride,
He hangs between; in doubt to act, or rest;
In doubt to deem himself a god, or beast;
In doubt his mind or body to prefer;
10 Born but to die, and reasoning but to err;
Alike in ignorance, his reason such,
Whether he thinks too little, or too much:
Chaos of thought and passion, all confused;
Still by himself abused, or disabused;
15 Created half to rise, and half to fall;
Great lord of all things, yet a prey to all;
Sole judge of truth, in endless error hurled:
The glory, jest, and riddle of the world!

(Gutenberg text)

A commentary on the text

This is something of a test for a couplet writer, because the point Pope is making is that Man is hanging in the middle somewhere, neither one thing nor another. One of the criticisms made of the couplet is that it is ideal for contrasting things, and ultimately polarising is a trivialising process. Pope was well aware of this danger, and tackles it neatly elsewhere in the poem:

If white and black blend, soften, and unite
A thousand ways, is there no black or white?

Note the subtlety of the chiasmus[8] – the unusual sequence *white and black* points up their separation, and contrasts with the verbs in the line; the second mention *black or white* integrates them again as a contrastive pair, and uses *or* as the linker to make the point.

Pope, handling a verse form that encourages bipolar contrasts, has to tackle the middle ground. The opening couplet does not set up a strong pattern and this is normal – there is an obscure chiasmus in the first line (*know … thyself – God … scan*), while the second line has no mid-break and reaches apparent finality with the similarity of *mankind* and *man*. There is another vaguely chiasmic pattern over the two lines *… God … scan – study … man(kind).* A full stop underlines the finality, but a single couplet is rarely a complete verse paragraph so we interpret the first couplet as an introductory positioning.

The second couplet is rhythmically the reverse of the first, with another undivided line in l. 3 and a four-way comparison in l. 4. In l. 3 the word *isthmus*, backed up by *middle*, sets the semantic sights of the paragraph – and note that Pope places the word *isthmus* in the middle of the line.

Line 4 is a characteristic structure, which has three components: two pairs of words in a common environment. The shared elements are *A being*, and the adverbs *darkly* and *rudely* have something in common, as have the adjectives *wise* and *great*. The adverbs are unusual in combination with the nouns, and detract from them; *darkly* hints at primitive and uncomprehending impulses, which jar with wisdom, while *rudely* suggests a lack of sophistication and a serious limitation on greatness. Man, then, is neither really wise nor great, but somewhere in between.

This couplet ends with a colon, a substantial break but one that raises the expectation that the following lines will be illustrative of the preceding; the gnomic phrases of l. 4 may be elaborated.

The third couplet is one where the two lines follow the same pattern, down to syllabification and alliteration. There is a frame, common to both lines, *With too much X for the Y Z*, and a contrast on the Y elements, *sceptic* and *stoic*. The X elements, *knowledge* and *weakness* do not seem to compare along any coherent dimension, nor do the Z elements, *side* and *pride*, which are little more than carriers for the Y elements. The couplet as it stands does not make an impact because there are no clear lines of contrast. No doubt the greater awareness of classical notions and stories in Pope's time would make the Y elements an interesting comparison, but there is nothing else beyond a similar mismatch between the X and Y elements, similar to the jarring of *darkly wise and rudely great*. Stoics have a reputation for toughness; perhaps sceptics were thought to be ignorant – I do not know but it is clearly implied here.

The point is that the same technique is used as before, juxtaposing meanings that, if not antonymic, certainly do not mix well. But in this case the couplet does not round off the structure; both the lines are prepositional phrases, and they prospect the rest of their clause, which comes in l. 7a (the first half of l. 7) – a clear case of arrest. The punctuation at the end of l. 6 is merely a comma, like l. 5, and there is

some build-up of structural energy from the very marked pattern of repetition in this couplet. In an almost Wordsworthian way, the brevity of l. 7a following this build-up makes it seem important, and in a distinctly Popeian way the words enact their meaning.

A brief digression to explain this last phrase. Pope's *Essay on Criticism* is justly famous because of the bravura with which he makes his words dance to their own meaning, especially in the famous passage beginning:

> But most by Numbers judge a Poet's Song,
> And smooth or rough, with them, is right or wrong;

and containing gems like:

> And ten low Words oft creep in one dull Line.[9]

Back with the *Essay on Man* we see that the word *between*, like *isthmus*, is close to the middle of the line, hung there by the word *hangs*. *Between* is a preposition and prospects that two points will be specified, 'between X and Y'. It is within the conventions of poetic licence that these do not need to be supplied, but the expectation is aroused and contributes to the suspense and suspension. The semi-colon in the middle of l. 7 suggests that the resolution of Man's unfortunate suspension will shortly be resolved.

The fourth couplet is then faced with something of a problem of what Pope would call *numbers*, the measure of the verse, its sophistication and the way it highlights the meaning. How is he going to steady the couplet in a line and a half? It is not a big problem however, and Pope repeats the frame technique, this time using the frame *in doubt to X or Y*. The frame is modified in line 8 to *in doubt to Z X or Y*, where Z is *deem himself a*, conveniently taking up the extra syllables available in the full line. Here the contrasts of paired words begin to show more clearly than in the earlier couplets; the first XY pair are *act* and *rest*, which are *prima facie* antonyms, and the second pair, *God* and *beast* are seen as points on a cultural continuum on either side of *man*. The message of each phrase is always the same, but the technique has moved from juxtaposing words uncomfortably together, to seeing Man as in tension between opposites, hanging between them. Each line at this point closes with a semi-colon; each statement is essentially the same and is given the same status in the sentence.

The *in doubt* frame is used once more in l. 9, and this reduces the impact of the couplet end because it signals another of the same, the third in a row; the frame is further varied to *in doubt X or Y to prefer*. The verb, which was the point of contrast at first, is now part of the frame. Line 10 does not repeat the pattern, and so is a kind of summing up of where we are now. The four-part pattern of l. 10 is a favourite of Pope's, often used to devastating effect; the frame is *X but to Y*, and the Xs are a conventional antonym, *born* and *die*. The Ys are not so obviously antithetical to us nowadays, *reasoning* and *err*, but the way in which these words recur, even just in this paragraph, suggest that they were close to antonymic for the original readers. Making mistakes is as inevitable as dying.

Let us have a closer look at the fragment 7b-10. Three *in doubt* frames build up strength in repetition, and l. 10 signals a change, briefly to a new frame *X but to Y*. We interpret l. 10 as a rounding-off of the fragment, making generalisations from the instances above it. The generalisation seems to be an awareness that any action, impression or preference is perpetually cancelled out by its opposite, and l. 10 makes a physical and mental summary of the position.

Depressing though the message may be, the verse is in good shape, and has returned from the slight turbulence of l. 7 to the measured, balanced and familiar l. 10. The end-line punctuation remains the semi-colon, however, indicating that there is more to come.

The sixth couplet loosens up the verse, which had been becoming progressively more patterned in the previous fragment. The couplet again aligns with the antithetical patterns after the excursion in 7b-10. There is a sense of restarting, while still pursuing the main point.

The main point is that Man is still hanging between. Once again the punctuation, the least noticeable part of the structure, indicates with a colon at the end of l. 12 that we have returned to a similar situation to l. 4; the paradoxical difficulty of Man's thought processes is the next topic to be addressed. The next four lines each end in a semi-colon, as did ll. 7, 8, 9, and 10. Although the repeated pattern is less regimented, the couplet is low key and non-terminal, so we can expect that another build-up is on the way.

There is a trace of a chiasmus in l. 11 – *alike, ignorance/reason, such* – but while *ignorance* and *reason* certainly contrast in the semantics

of this verse, the other pair is trivial. Line 12 has another fairly banal contrast, between *too little* and *too much*.

The seventh couplet is rather similar; there is a hint of chiasmus again in the odd-numbered line, and l. 14 closely follows l. 12. Let us examine ll. 13 and 14 in turn. *Chaos* at the beginning of l. 13 is echoed by *confused* at the end, and *thought* and *passion* in the middle make it look superficially balanced, but the meaning does not follow the surface patterning. If the comma had been placed after syllable 4 rather than 7, it would have been an unmistakable chiasmus, but it would not mean the same:

*Chaos of thought, and passion all confused

It is always perilous to underestimate Pope. Was he aware of the underlying regularity that has just been presented in my tinkering with the line, but since he was talking about chaos and confusion, did he place the comma to create quite a little turbulence, a little chaos in the all-important Numbers? After the quotes from the *Essay on Criticism* one might imagine that this is just what he would do.

Line 14 is opaque to me, perhaps distorted by our unavoidable reaction to the word *abuse* in current English. Whatever it means exactly, it is unlikely that *disabused* is the opposite of *abused*, so the meaning is once again slightly at odds with the verse. In terms of pattern l. 14 is very close to l. 12:

Whether he thinks	too little,	or	too much;
Still by himself	abused,	or	disabused;

The second and fourth segments carry sharp antonyms.

So the sixth and seventh couplets have a lot in common, though it is not all just on the surface: the indistinct chiasmus patterns in the first lines; the commas after syllables 6 and 7 respectively, giving a similar feel to the rhythm; the close parallel structure of the even-numbered lines as shown above. It is worth noting again, however, the difference in the end-line punctuation. The comma at the end of l. 11 indicates that there is a syntactic dependency relationship between the two lines of the couplet; in fact l. 12 is a subordinate clause to the main clause that is still elaborating l. 7a, *He hangs between*. All the lines from 7 until 16, with the exception of 12, take off from 7a, so we understand, say, l. 13 as ‘He hangs between ? and ? in a chaos of thought and passion, all confused’. The punctuation at the end of l. 13 is the first of

the string of semicolons that mark the build-up to the final couplet in the paragraph.

The next couplet, the eighth, consists of two more lines each of which makes a simple opposition; *rise* and *fall* in l. 15, and *lord of all* versus *prey to all* in l. 16. Whereas *lord* and *prey* are not exact opposites, the repetitive structure of the verse is sufficient for them to fit in.

The pattern, and the build-up, continues in l. 17, which parallels l. 16 quite closely:

Great	lord	of	all things,	yet	a prey	to all;
Sole	judge	of	truth,	in	endless error	hurled:

The couplet break is made to feel unimportant at this point, compared with the build-up that started in l. 7 and restarted in l. 13. For line after line we have been expecting the balanced, simple two-term comparison, usually a fairly obvious pair of opposites; l. 18 completely foils our expectations of pattern by comparing three terms, *glory*, *jest* and *riddle*. Prominence falls on *riddle* because it is last, the other two form a pair, and it falls on syllables 6 and 7 with only a trite phrase to end the paragraph.

From the point of view of the meaning, this all starts with the word *isthmus* in l. 3. Pope is exploiting the very structure of the heroic couplet; this verse, as we have seen, naturally falls into half lines that effortlessly carry contrasts and comparisons. By gradually highlighting a third way, hanging between any pair of *God* and *beast*, *reason* and *error*, etc., Pope prepares the way for occupying the part of the line that is normally empty, the break in the middle. This is the location of his topic, Man – and sure enough there is Man in the middle of the last line, the riddle of the universe. The technique is akin to the Polo Mint company making a constant fuss about the hole in the middle, as they do.

5. A local grammar for the *Essay on Man*

We have now been through a not very erudite *explication de text* of a verse paragraph from this poem. I did not want to wheel out the complete critical apparatus because of the risk of being sidelined from the main issues. It is not possible to say for sure that this passage is ‘typical’ of the Essay, and indeed there are aspects of it that are almost certainly unique to it, as one would expect in any live communication. However, a general acquaintance with the poem and the genre

suggests that the verbal techniques employed here are reasonably representative of its kind of writing. A local grammar that fitted this paragraph, then, should need little revision in order to account for other verse paragraphs in the poem, then in other poems by Pope and his contemporaries, and ultimately to the whole genre of the heroic couplet. In fact, such are the fuzzy edges around the categories of genre that a good description will also function as a gatekeeper to the genre, as description drifts naturally into prescription.

What are the rhetorical units into which the verse paragraph divides? First there are *segments*, of indeterminate length, which retain some of the characteristics of the verse paragraph as a whole. Segments may be sequential with respect to one another, but can also be embedded within each other. So we can make a start by saying that a paragraph consists of one or more segments arranged either in the order:

segment – segment – segment …

or in the order:

segment (segment (segment …

and these two orders can be combined.

Segments are not necessarily made up of whole couplets or even whole lines, but can start and stop at any point in the verse structure. So the couplet pattern, which dominates the superficial appearance of the style, is not in a taxonomic relationship to the segment.[10] Segment and couplet operate in parallel, with the segment usually larger than the couplet, but with the opportunity for counterpoint in various places, as we have seen, for example, in l. 7.

A couplet consists of two lines. A line optionally divides into two half-lines, and occasionally into smaller units, marked by internal punctuation.[11]

The paragraph and the segment have approximately the same structural possibilities: a distinctive opening, a central passage and a distinctive closing. In our sample passage from *An Essay on Man*, the first couplet is a distinctive opening – it is a whole sentence and it sets the topic for the paragraph. The second couplet is the opening of a segment, and is also distinctive, the colon indicating that what follows is an elaboration of the statement in the couplet. This segment introduces the idea of Man's in-between position, with *isthmus* and *middle*, and with the paradoxical juxtapositions of l. 4. Then there

follows the central passage of this segment, where the repetitive patterns begin to be developed. The third couplet functions in this way, and l. 7a breaks the pattern and provides a termination for the segment. A new segment starts at l. 7b. Note that if the mid-line punctuation had been just a comma, it would have been difficult to justify a segment boundary. The semi-colon indicates that l. 7b is not just an expression of the points between which 'he' hangs, but starts another repetitive series.

In this second segment there is no distinctive opening passage, and I interpret it as being embedded within the first, and not sequential. As we noted in the discursive explication, l. 7b is required to make sense of *between*, yet the semi-colon separates it and places it in a new clause. And then we find that l. 7b is not alone, but is the template for ll. 8 and 9 as well. The pattern is broken at l. 10, which forms a distinctive closing passage both for this segment and the first one (see footnote 12).

The third segment begins at l. 11, and it is sequential. The sixth couplet, ll. 11 and 12, constitutes something of a distinctive opening, though we have noted that the pattern of l. 11 is not strong, and that there are quite strong affinities between the sixth and seventh couplets, which tend to obscure their different structural roles. Perhaps a sharply distinctive opening at this point in the paragraph would be too much of a break, so openings are muted as the paragraph develops.

The central passage of the third segment continues until l. 17, leaving the last line as a highly distinctive closing, not only to the segment but to the paragraph as a whole.[12] It is marked off by the colon at the end of l. 16 and the exclamation mark at the end of l. 17.

Notice that the length of the central passages rises as we go through the paragraph. In the first segment it is just one couplet; in the second it is a couplet and half a line; in the third it is three couplets and a line. The gradual emergence of the repetitive pattern over ll. 11-17 suggests that Pope was aware of the long haul, and made sure his early blows were muffled, as we saw in ll. 11-14. Lines 15, 16, and 17 show the verse razor-sharp and highly concentrated in meaning.

We can now turn to the smaller-scale patterns of the couplet and below, and I will first deal with the patterns found most prominently

in the central passages.[13] This is where the patterns called *antithesis* are to be found, and we must be careful of this potentially misleading term. As previewed above, an antithesis is essentially a comparison of two items or more within a *frame*. The frame is either *common* to the elements of the comparison, or *matched* by sufficient actual recurrence of words to make it stand as a repetition; if it has features of both we will call it a *mixed frame*. So in l. 4, the frame is *A being … and*, which occurs once only and so is common, while in ll. 5 and 6 the frame *With too much … for the* is precisely repeated, and the only structural difference between the two lines is the possessive morpheme *'s* in *stoic's*. Line 15 has a mixed frame, with *created* common and *half to* matched.

Comparisons are mainly of simple *pairs*, but occasionally more complex patterns like *double-pairs*, and some special cases, like the *triple* in the last line. Line 15 is a simple case of a pair, *rise* and *fall*, within the mixed frame just described. The pair is *antonymic* in that it can be claimed that users of the language are immediately aware of this relationship if the two words are presented in isolation or in a frame of this kind. The frame does not create the semantic opposition, but merely points it up.

One of the main exponents of the comparisons is the expression of co-ordination. Small words they are, but *and, or, but, yet* delineate most of the comparisons, and they are just as carefully chosen as any of the other words.

Other antonymic simple pairs are *act/rest, god/beast, mind/body, little/much, abused/disabused, truth/error*. We also admitted *ignorance/reason* in the explication above.

We are left with couplets 1 and 3, and ll. 4, 10, 13, and 18. Let us work upwards from the end. Line 18 is a triple; *glory* and *jest* are close to antonymic, and in the environment of the rest of the paragraph they would count as another simple pair; here the pattern is extended to a third word which is not antonymic to either of them and so requires special interpretation. The theme of the passage is the in-between state of Man, and so the notion that a riddle is somewhere between glory and jest arises, and since part of the riddle could be its precise position in the scheme of things, the line creates a unique and *ad hoc* meaning that triumphantly rounds off the paragraph, as the

exclamation mark demands. Man is simultaneously a glorious creature, a butt of jest, and above all a mystery and a puzzle. And hence, returning to l. 2, a proper object for self-study.

Line 13, we have already noted, has the superficial appearance of a chiasmus, but with a comma that breaks up the comparison. *Thought* and *passion* make a good antonymic pair but there is no frame; *Chaos* and *confused* would do fine as a frame matched by synonymy, and they even alliterate, but such an interpretation has to remain very much in the background, and the line itself is confused in its pattern.

Line 10 is one of the more powerful lines because it is a double-pair. Each of its pairs is an accepted antonym, so it is not trying any playful semantics, but we are invited to interpret the two pairs together as well as singly. When there is more than one pair there is more than one possible axis of comparison. There is a kind of equation,

> *born* is to *die* as *reason* is to *err*

This kind of pattern is very common in heroic couplet poetry. We interpret it as 'Just as being born raises the inevitability of dying, trying to reason raises the inevitability of making mistakes'.

This double-pair is the most deadly weapon in the arsenal of the satirist, but is kept sheathed in the philosophical poetry. To whip it out, the second pair should not be an accepted antonym, but a pair of words that are obliged to find whatever contrast they can, from which arises the fun. So, in *An Essay on Criticism*, there is a couplet:

> Yet let not each gay turn thy rapture move,
> For fools admire, but men of sense approve;

The accepted antonymic pair, *fools* and *men of sense*, form a *pair-frame* against which *admire* is contrasted with *approve*. Moderation in all things.

Line 4 in the second couplet gives us a neat double-pair, with both horizontal and vertical possibilities. Because there are no recognised antonyms among the pairings, the effect of the line is to introduce the idea that Man may be a bit tricky to pin down, a bit inconsistent, not falling into the readymade categories.

The third couplet is the most elaborate comparison in the paragraph, and in the discussion above it was pointed out that it does not make a strong impact. Each line provides a matched frame within which there

are three pairs, but none of them are strongly antonymic, though *sceptic* and *stoic* may be close.[14] There is another mild contrast between *knowledge* and *sceptic* in l. 5, and *weakness* and *stoic* in l. 6. The function of the couplet seems to be mainly to set up several somewhat opposing poles between which Man can hang in the next line; hence the pairs in this couplet are not making a separate statement with pithy content. We will call the contrast of *knowledge* and *sceptic* a *horizontal* contrast, and that between *knowledge* and *weakness* a *vertical* contrast.

The first couplet shows little meaningful pattern, though it lines up the vocabulary for the passage – *know, God, man.* In the earlier discussion we saw that there are two patterns of chiasmus present, but not very clear, like a limbering-up exercise. But since we have neglected the several chiasmuses in the paragraph, we will finish this pattern review with a brief account of them.

A chiasmus is one of the double-pair comparisons, with the ABBA order that we have noticed. If we take *know, scan* and *study* to be tolerable synonyms within the conventions of the verse, then *thyself* and *God* are put up as antonyms in the first line. Since *thyself* stands for Man, and God and Man are accepted antonyms, the line is neatly turned but unremarkable.[15] In the second chiasmus line 1b is re-used, and *study* replaces *know* while *mankind* replaces *man*. Again, not very clearly marked.

Line 11 is another weak chiasmus, hardly there at all, and we have already tackled the pattern of the fascinating l. 13, the other possible chiasmic pattern. The conclusion must be that this kind of comparison is deployed only in a very muted way in the paragraph. Along with the single instance of a double pair (l. 4), and the punch of l. 10 firmly pulled, the general tone of the poetry is established.

6. The couplet

The couplet has taken a back seat in our discussion of the antithetical style, which has ranged over line and half-line as well, and grouped couplets, and bits of couplets, together. Because the general view seems to be that the couplet is the pivotal unit of the verse, and not just one rank in the metrical hierarchy, we will round up the description by characterising each couplet in turn. The labels here are

not intended to be as firm as technical terms because of the smallness of the sample.

In couplet 1 the first line is broken up by punctuation into half-lines, while the second line is free of mid-punctuation. We will call this pattern *halved-whole*. A similar contrast is made in the two halves of the first line, which consists of three single words all separately punctuated. The overall effect is a gradual smoothing of the rhythm, and we will add the word *accentuated* to account for the movement of the first line. This couplet, then, is of the *accentuated halved-whole* type. We must beware of hindsight in assigning function, but such a line seems to be well suited to an opening.

The second couplet is opposite in its dynamics, and so the label *whole-halved* will suffice. Its first line runs without pause, and its second has mid-punctuation. The first line is preparatory, setting up expectations of something significant to come, and the second line is a double-pair, which we have identified as a powerful antithetical structure. As we have seen, this couplet is the beginning of an *arrest* that runs over to l. 7, so the possible punch of the second line is dissipated, but the basic function of the couplet is clear; it is similar to the launch of a weapon in the physical world, with a stage of preparation followed by the firing of the weapon.

In the third couplet the two lines share a strongly marked matched frame and within that the compared items also show similarity of syllabification. The second vertical pair, *sceptic* and *stoic's*, also alliterate, and the slightly different grammar is a minor matter.[16] We shall call this kind of pattern an *aligned* couplet. Two successive lines with identical characteristics are likely to be used in building up an effect, and with three antithetical elements in each there are plenty of opportunities for smaller points to be made in passing. Here the function is to build up the arrest pattern that we noted in the central passage of the segment, and the prominent initial prepositions make this function very clear.

The fourth couplet is superficially of the same kind as the first, a *halved-whole* structure. The structure is also *accentuated*, but by a different pattern, in this case the strong similarity between the second half of l. 7 and the whole of l. 8. Where there are loose chiasmus patterns linking the two halves of l. 1 and the whole of l. 2, there is a

sharp break in the middle of l. 7; we have already noted that this is a segment boundary. Where there is such a cross-cutting of units, the larger structures tend to dominate, and we should perhaps postulate an *ad hoc* unit, the *residual couplet*, in order to label the function of this one minus its first half line. The appearance of an antithetical pattern first in a half line and then in the following full line is a powerful *expansion*, and that will do as a label for the present.

The fifth couplet is of the opposite variety, a *whole-halved* structure with a strong double-pair antithesis in the second line. This recalls the second couplet quite a lot, and exposes yet another underlying chiasmus that I had not noticed before; it is on the verge of fanciful, but *mind* does go with *reasoning*, and *body* with *born* and *die*. The function of the couplet is very similar to that of the second, like the preparation and launch of a weapon; in this case l. 10 generalises the preceding build-up, and is the closing passage of its segment, so the effect is enhanced.

The sixth couplet is the first in which both lines have a mid-break. Without the comma in l. 12 the couplet would be quite similar to the first one, and it is also an opening passage with a very similar function; presumable the little phrase *or too much* is not weighty enough to contrast with the rest of the line without being pointed up. We will call a couplet with a break in both lines, and with nothing else to distinguish it, a *halved-halved* structure.

The seventh and eighth couplets are similarly unremarkable as couplets, seeming to operate more as individual lines; for the record they are halved-halved structures, and the final couplet is an unusual one; l. 17 is halved like the six above it, but l. 18 contains a list of three items and a final phrase that applies to all three of them. I will not attempt to characterise this kind of line with only a single example; it is not unique in the poem so it is best to wait until we have several examples to work from.

We have done our best to respect the couplet as the central unit, as it appears to be in the verse structure. But in the rhetorical structure it is on several occasions set against the argument, and rhetorical units take up more than a couplet and less than a couplet. In the last third of the paragraph the couplet all but disappears, except for its rhyme, in favour of the line.

The reader may refer to the Table at the end to see a summary of the way in which the various units are, and are not, related.

7. Conclusion

This study has brought out all the elements and relationships we need for an adequate local grammar of this paragraph. Hopefully it will suffice with minor variations to cover a lot of other paragraphs as well, and with some generalisation to be a good fit with the poem as a whole. Similar work on the satirical poems will show a great deal in common, and it is not possible to say with confidence at this point exactly what text types will be explained by a local grammar that starts with *An Essay on Man*. We can add variables as we build a corpus, such as other philosophical poems by the same author, similar poetry by his contemporaries, other kinds of poetry of the time, such as satirical, epic, lyric, all in the couplet form; earlier and later examples of these forms. If a step in expansion costs a great deal in elaboration of the grammar, then perhaps for that text type we should start again and write a simple grammar for it. Local grammars reflect the *ad hoc* nature of stylistic analysis; rather than trying to ignore the textual complexity or squashing it into predetermined categories or abandoning rigorous description, local grammars can overlap with each other and compete for offering the most salient analysis of a passage. If this sounds like a recipe for anarchy, then imagine trying to elaborate all the possibilities in a single general grammar. That has all the attributes of an Abercrombie *pseudo-procedure* (1965).

We have no reason to believe that text is created by a coherent process from a single point of origin. The weight of expert opinion is that this is an illusion, an interpretation from hindsight as the individual tries to account for what he or she has just done (Singer 2004). So while the final result of a poet's composition session may be some lines of polished verse, the composition process has probably involved several local grammars jostling together, barely under control; sometimes their demands may modify or divert the original communicative intent.

The descriptive scheme that I have sketched above relates four principles of organisation to each other; each of the organisational strands has the potential of creating meaning independently from all the others; even though this potential is only occasionally realised it is one of the major features of the poetry.

One organisation is that of the *verse structure*. There we see a taxonomic hierarchy of:

poem
epistle
paragraph
couplet
line
part-line

Each unit consists of one or more than one of the unit next below. Note that the last and smallest rank is not always invoked, but it is necessary to account for in-line punctuation.

The second organisation that we have identified is the *rhetorical structure*. This is where the argumentation of the text is organised and expressed. Because the extract that we are studying is a single verse paragraph, we keep an open mind about higher ranks of rhetorical structure, but within the verse paragraph there is a hierarchy:

paragraph
segment
passage

This is another taxonomic hierarchy, which does not fit well with the first. While there are general implications of relative size of the units, and a general tendency to respect the boundaries of the verse structure, a passage can consist of several couplets, or, as we have seen in l. 7a, it can be less than a line in length.

The sentence and its parts form a third taxonomic hierarchy of a familiar kind, much of its organisation being drawn from a general grammar of English. The main differences come from *poetic licence*, which consist of some relatively minor relaxations of general rules. Again the syntactic units do not fit neatly with the verse structure or the rhetorical structure; there is an example of the lack of correspondence below. The metrical and phonological units form a fourth organisation, which we will not examine on this occasion. The scheme that is sketched here is the intersection of a local grammar for this kind of poem, a general grammar and a verse structure.

Notice that the sentence grammar is but one of the components of the meaningful organisation of the poetry. It does not dominate, and very

often the meaning created in one of the other hierarchies takes precedence.

Consider the following passage, from earlier in the poem:

> Men would be Angels, Angels would be Gods.
> Aspiring to be Gods, if Angels fell,
> Aspiring to be Angels, Men rebel:

I have restored the original practice of capitalising most of the nouns to point up the dominating pattern:

> Men - Angels - Angels - Gods
> Gods - Angels - Angels - Men

There is quite an elaborate repeated frame, both in the first line and the couplet. The *if* in the second line is important in the grammar, because it subordinates l. 2 to the main clause in l. 3; but relative to the idea of spiritual ascent and descent it might as well not be there.

Firth (1957) put forward the notion of a spectrum of meaning, with all levels of language patterning contributing; at times the meaning was made via the taxonomic hierarchies of and within phonology and grammar, but any level could create meaning directly at any time, and bypass the hierarchies. The holistic approach that is required of a local grammar of couplet poetry fits well with Firth's proposals, and also with his recognition of *restricted languages*, where special conventions mark special varieties.

We have discussed each of the obvious antithetical patterns of couplet, line and half-line; but also we have tried to account for the lines that have less clear pattern. Often there is a trace of what could have been a chiasmus – even l. 3, if we concede that *perched* and *state* have something in common, and *isthmus* and *middle* we have already noted are similar in meaning. It does not really matter how far we wish to push the recognition of these less-than-distinct patterns, because it is clear that the couplet and the line are ideal vehicles if the poet wishes to mould a sharply delineated chiasmus, so muted and vague patterns are there for another purpose.

We recognise these lines as a kind of *continuo*, not drawing attention to themselves but fitting in with the general kind of expression of the poem. And they occur in the places where according to our description we should expect patterns that are somewhat different from the central passages, i. e. in the opening passages. These are ll. 1,

2, 3, and 11. The closing passages are also expected to produce something different; in this paragraph they are ll. 7a, 10, and 18, although ll. 10 and 18 are at least as strongly patterned as the ones they follow, the pattern changes: in l. 10 to a double-pair, and in l. 18 to a triple.

Note that the differentiation is more apparent in the paragraph as a whole than in the individual segments, and that the embedded segment has no opening passage. This may be a general trend, but until this analysis has been extended to the poem as a whole and beyond, we cannot be sure; these are not texts that yield their secrets to a casual glance. Also the verse paragraph is not the highest unit of patterning, because there are at least two higher units on the surface of the text – the *Epistle*, which is made up of numbered *sections*. These units may be too large to show immediately perceptible patterns, and so their principal function may be to organise the general argument; also there may be rhetorical units between the paragraph and the epistle, identified by their carrying a supra-paragraph pattern.

There is still much to be done; after all, this research is still in its first half-century. It is too early to attempt a more rigorous statement of the local grammar even though the main components may well be in place. Too early, too, to assess how computable the grammar will be, though I am optimistic about that within certain limitations.

The research began with the literary view of this kind of poetry as centring on the couplet, and the linguistic view of text as centring on the sentence and its parts. After close study it would seem that while the couplet is the most obvious unit, it is also rather superficial, and often forms a counterpoint to the meaning rather than a delineator of it. The details of conventional sentence grammar are normally observed with great care, almost obsessively, but in many places it seems as if the poet is carrying out a duty rather than making meaning, and when the patterns of antithesis, in the broad sense of the literary term, cut across the grammar, as they often do, there is no doubt that they carry the principal meaning.

The main argument of this paper is that we can identify four principles of organisation in the sample passage, all capable of independent meaning-creation, and by no means in a regular relationship with each other. Of these, three are well known in the description of poetry, and

can be seen as specialisations of more general types of apparatus. The fourth, the rhetorical structure, is the one that controls the meaning and arranges for its expression through the other, more superficial, hierarchies. It does not and cannot cancel the meaning that is carried by the others, but it prioritises and juxtaposes and sometimes almost suppresses meanings in order to create the special meaningful effects for which the poetry is noted.

We can summarise the 'local' nature of this descriptive approach as follows:

(a) The verse structure and metrics are highly specialised in order to cover this kind of poetry and only this; however their categories and conventions are drawn from a general pool that is used in the description of a very large amount of traditional verse.

(b) The syntax is a general grammar, slightly modified to cope with poetic licence.

(c) The rhetorical structure is a local grammar specially designed for this kind of poetry; no doubt with connections to other local grammars, but whose generality is at present unknown.

(d) The rhetorical structure controls the way in which meaning is expressed in the other three types of organisation; it has great freedom in squeezing and stretching the other units, and in superimposing meaningful patterns like antitheses on the other three. The particular way in which the rhetorical structure disposes the others is the main distinguishing characteristic of the poetry.

(e) Meaning is latent in the patterns of all four of the hierarchies, and to some extent they compete and offer alternative meanings; interpretation is guided by the rhetorical structure, though ultimately it is an individual response to the text.

Only a battery of local grammars can account for the flexibility and intricacy of the meaningful patterns that we observe.

This research is part of a broader attempt to assign meaning its proper place in a linguistic theory and description. We have tended either to lose sight of meaning as we elaborate grammars, or to take it for granted in writing programs for assigning structure. Despite all the

talk about 'living language' and 'dynamic text', the principal tools of the analyser, grammars, dictionaries, thesauruses etc. are collections of information that have three qualities:

(a) They are very general in nature, so that they have a good chance of being correct in a wide range of textual circumstances.

(b) They are largely insensitive to specific verbal environments.[17]

(c) They are organised to smooth over variation by assigning unusual patterns to the nearest regular one, not to assign meaning to the unusual patterns.

That is to say, most current theories have no place for the kind of meaning that is clearly under negotiation all the time in everyday speech and writing. Any resource book that claims it can capture meaning accurately, especially in a single word, is capturing only a fraction of the meaning that is being created, and any computational grammar that decides on meaning by statistical weightings must have taken a wrong turning, and finds itself having to make categorisations that are not supported by the text.

Analysers who boldly go where they should not, i. e. attempt to account for meaningful patterns with inappropriate apparatus, obscure the issue. A substantial proportion of the meaning of any text is created *ad hoc*, by the particular combinations and juxtapositions of the text at one particular point; these are in all probability unique patterns that are not enshrined in the reference collections and indeed should not be so documented because they are not established patterns of the language; in small ways or big ways they are *exploitations* of the established patterns. I am not just referring to the highly mannered poetry that we have been looking at closely above, but to almost every utterance beyond the most phatic of communions.

Here an analyser must give way to an interpreter. The analyser looks for familiar patterns for which it has stored meaning assignments; the interpreter looks for unfamiliar patterns for which it has to propose a meaning. The jobs are complementary, but the initial information is the same – a clear and comprehensive account of the established meaning-bearing patterns of the language. The more precise this can be, the easier will be the task of the interpreter in judging how far a

combination is from one or more normal ones. And precision comes from assimilating and summarising as much corpus data as possible.

Coda

There is one pattern that I have left to the end; not because it is particularly important but because it illustrates the almost parasitical nature of the rhetorical structure, ready to make use of any aspect of the metrical or syntactic structure. The pattern was not easy for me to isolate, so it may be rather subliminal for most readers.

When we were reviewing the forms and functions of the couplet, we had rather little to say about the later ones from the sixth to the end. Line 11 is an opener, and l. 18 a closer, but in between we have a succession of lines all with vaguely similar pattern and meaning. They clearly constitute an important build-up to give punch to the last line, but aside from their general repetitive quality it is not easy to see the gathering of poetic energy during the passage.

But consider the position of the mid-line punctuation. The number of the syllable after which the punctuation mark occurs is, for ll. 12-17:

7 7 6 6 5 4

And the first comma of l. 18 occurs after syllable 3. So the first half-lines are getting progressively shorter, anticipating the onset of the final line. In the first half of each of these lines we see also a move from a rather murky situation in ll. 12-13 to a repeated pattern in 14 onwards where the first half-line expresses a most positive quality about Man, and the second half gives the paradoxical opposite position. It is the positive phrases that are getting shorter as they get grander and more pompous (*great lord, sole judge of truth*), and a kind of irony arises as it seems that they may be engulfed by their lengthening and unfortunate antonyms. The last line comes to the rescue here, and first miniaturises the patterns of the previous lines by packing the positive side into three syllables and the negative side into one, *jest*. This reverses the length balance and leaves most of the line for the rather comforting middle ground, the balance of the opposing states.

Unless one dismisses this evidence as coincidental, which is a dangerous position to take with Mr. Pope's work, it is clear that the rhetorical structure switches its priorities gradually from the drumbeat

of ll. 7b-10 to a more subtle manifestation, controlling the build-up through a succession of lines which are unremarkable in themselves but which together create a powerful meaning.

Endnotes

[1]The story about this arrangement that passed among the students was that it was established by the last literature professor but one, Herbert J. C. Grierson, who felt that a strong dose of language work added intellectual backbone to the literature course.

[2]For information and confirmation of the content of this section I am indebted to another survivor of the period, Norman McLeod.

[3]This cryptic account omits even mention of the parallel developments in Phonetics with David Abercrombie and Applied Linguistics with Ian Catford, both with star-studded casts of colleagues, who projected Edinburgh into a commanding position in language studies by about 1960.

[4]For a recent confirmation of this point see Stubbs (2004), who quotes Toolan (1996).

[5]Very soon after this many linguists, led by Chomsky, moved away from giving pride of place to actually occurring language, in favour of hypothetical representations of sentences, thus leading back into a more subjective domain. My resistance to the siren call of 'TG' may well have been influenced by the way in which I came into linguistics, as a flight from subjectivity.

[6]This was not the perception at the time. The adjective 'heroic' was applied to the couplet because of the great classical translations such as Dryden's Virgil and Pope's Homer.

[7]'To the Hopi, for whom time is not a motion but a "getting later" of everything that has ever been done, unvarying repetition is not wasted but accumulated. It is storing up an invisible change that holds over into later events'. Whorf (1956). 'Unvarying' is a relative concept, since nothing is ever exactly repeated, so I think that Whorf's interpretation is close to my point.

[8]Chiasmus consists of two pairs of elements in comparison, organised in the sequence ABBA rather then the more straightforward ABAB.

[9](An Alexandrine is a line containing two extra syllables, sparingly used for special effects.)

> But most by Numbers judge a Poet's Song,
> And smooth or rough, with them, is right or wrong;
> In the bright Muse tho' thousand Charms conspire,
> Her Voice is all these tuneful Fools admire,
> Who haunt Parnassus but to please their Ear,
> Not mend their Minds; as some to Church repair,
> Not for the Doctrine, but the Musick there.
> These Equal Syllables alone require,
> Tho' oft the Ear the open Vowels tire,
> While Expletives their feeble Aid do join,

And ten low Words oft creep in one dull Line,
While they ring round the same unvary'd Chimes,
With sure Returns of still expected Rhymes.
Where-e'er you find the cooling Western Breeze,
In the next Line, it whispers thro' the Trees;
If Chrystal Streams with pleasing Murmurs creep,
The Reader's threaten'd (not in vain) with Sleep.
Then, at the last, and only Couplet fraught
With some unmeaning Thing they call a Thought,
A needless Alexandrine ends the Song,
That like a wounded Snake, drags its slow length along.

[10]There were, of course, all kinds of variations on the couplet, both before and after Pope and among his contemporaries. The tighter kind of writing always had a new verse paragraph starting with a new couplet.

[11]I will not go into the details of how the units are physically identified except for some attention to the segments. Nor will I engage at this time with the metrics of heroic couplet poetry, though these are integral parts of the whole.

[12]The separation of paragraph and segment is not absolute, and it is perhaps inaccurate to suggest that they are in a hierarchical relationship. I cannot open up the argument here, but there is reason to suspect that our familiar hierarchies of Sentence, Clause, etc. are also not as neatly boxed within each other as is normally supposed. So the paragraph-section relationship is not necessarily unusual, and for the moment I propose that any segment closing can also be seen as closing another open segment (in the case of embedding) and/or the paragraph as a whole.

[13]Lines 4 and 12 are part of openings, but they follow the structure of lines from central sections.

[14]We lack reference books to help us judge which pairs would be felt to be antonymic by the original readers of this poem, but the growing ease with which language resources can be accumulated and managed nowadays may eventually provide us with evidence.

[15]The word *then* recalls the latter part of the first Epistle, which is a fairly ruthless attempt to cut Man down to size, terminating in the blast:

One truth is clear, whatever is, is right.

[16]Pope could, I imagine, have just as easily used *sceptic* as a noun and written *sceptic's*, but would then have had a problem with the *s* sound. Robert Graves (1955) criticised Pope for having no control over his *s*'s, and perhaps the poet was aware of this weakness.

[17]The many lexicons for computational use give information about the cotext in generalised, categorial terms, but not usually concerning actual word forms. Some recent dictionaries and usage guides, derived from corpus research, come closer to the specific needs, but are far from comprehensive.

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Table: Analytical Summary

	line	couplet	passage	segment	para
Know, then, thyself, presume not God to scan;	(chiasmus)	(chiasmus) accentuated halved-whole	opening		opening
The proper study of mankind is man.	(chiasmus)				
Placed on this isthmus of a middle state,	(chiasmus)	whole-halved	opening arresting common frame	first	
A being darkly wise, and rudely great:	double-pair				
With too much knowledge for the sceptic side,	(pair)	aligned	central matched frame		
With too much weakness for the stoic's pride,	(pair)				
He hangs between;			closing end arrest		
in doubt to act, or rest;	pair	residual	central embedded	second	central
In doubt to deem himself a god, or beast;	pair				
In doubt his mind or body to prefer;	pair	whole-halved	matched frame		
Born but to die, and reasoning but to err;	double-pair		closing, release		
Alike in ignorance, his reason such,	(chiasmus)	halved-halved	opening	third	
Whether he thinks too little, or too much:	pair				
Chaos of thought and passion, all confused;	chiasmus?	halved-halved	central shared frame		
Still by himself abused, or disabused;	pair				
Created half to rise, and half to fall;	pair	halved-halved	mixed frame		
Great lord of all things, yet a prey to all;	pair				
Sole judge of truth, in endless error hurled:	pair	unclassified			
The glory, jest, and riddle of the world!	triple		closing, end release		closing

The ‘not-me in thee’: Crossing Boundaries Through Literature*

Willie van Peer

Abstract

Processes of identification and non-identification start from the very beginning of life and display a dynamic of their own. Initially, non-identification is gradually overcome and gives way to processes of identification. What is surprising is that at a particular point in time this process comes to a halt and non-identification overtakes the identification tendencies – the process is subsequently ossified.

I will argue that literature as we know it in the West (but perhaps also in non-Western cultures) functions as a corrective to this. It opposes and undermines entrenched views and ideological positions, thereby enabling itself to challenge established boundaries. The fictional nature of most literary texts allows them to be acceptable to most people’s tastes. However, this nature is a Trojan horse. Once (fictional) possibilities are entertained by readers, there is no return to the previous situation of established and entrenched categories. Now the possibility of a ‘negative’ identification is offered, the possibility of identifying with something otherwise forbidden by current societal norms. Such ‘negative identification’ processes have effects far beyond the merely literary or aesthetic realm, but also shape social and political developments.

Examples of how such processes of (non-)identification operate and how they influence our perception of the social world will be provided. From these considerations a new awareness of the power of literature to challenge existing boundaries may emerge.

Key words: defamiliarisation; deviation; effects of reading; foregrounding; identification; stereotypes.

1. The beginning

Let us begin at the beginning. Inside the womb, the foetus identifies completely with the mother. It must. It has no alternative. How

*This essay is a plenary address given at the 2003 PALA Conference in Istanbul. To preserve as far as possible the oral character of the presentation I have kept notes and references to a minimum. I hope the argument will thus speak for itself. My thanks to Donald C. Freeman for incisive criticism on an earlier version of this chapter, from which my argument has significantly profited. All remaining shortcomings are mine, of course.

profoundly this changes with birth. Although the newly born infant wants to prolong the symbiosis with the body of the mother, there are now moments of separation. Birth is the first boundary-crossing in life. What is worse: there is now an unknown stranger around, someone who also picks you up, but who smells completely different from Mommy.

Then further catastrophes are under way: 'Why do I need brothers and sisters? I don't like them. Why can't we be just the three of us?' But again, within the family initial resistance is overcome, and identification with brothers and sisters takes place. The child then gets to know the neighbours' children, then other children who live in the same street. They may play ball together, or other games, and eventually the child will also identify with these other children, who are for the child complete strangers. Eventually the child will go to school, where it will learn to know teachers, people very different from its parents, whom the child will shortly admire, and with whom it will identify, At one point the child may start learning a foreign language. It may join a sports club, where it will learn to know the trainers and the other children, and soon enough it will start identifying with its club, although all the people there are, initially at least, strangers. When the child gets older, it may start identifying with the region in which it lives, later with its country or religion, maybe later become involved in international exchanges with young people in foreign countries, and so forth. What we have observed in the above description seems to be universal: in all these cases is that what is initially unknown and strange ultimately becomes an object of identification. This, by the way, closely corresponds to theories of social identity, as they have first been proposed by George Herbert Mead (1934), and later developed by Henri Tajfel (1982) and Tajfel and Turner (1986). As Mead writes (1934: 195): 'When a self does appear it always involves an experience of another; there could not be an experience of a self simply by itself'. It is precisely on the borderline between the individual self and the other that identity is formed. In other words, developing a personality is the result of boundaries that are crossed: individuality emerges out of boundary crossings.

Thus all human beings have experiences of identifying with strangers. And to most people, such experiences seem to be rewarding, albeit

frightening in the beginning. And although there may be considerable differences in the way in which these processes are shaped in different cultures, in all human cultures children learn to identify with their fathers, their brothers and sisters, with other members of the extended family, with other children in their peer group, their community, and so forth.

2. Problems and games

So at the very beginning of life everybody looks like an enemy, everybody except the mother. And we must overcome these inimical feelings in order to be able to live. The situation is described magisterially in Amélie Nothomb's novel *Métaphysique des Tubes* (English translation, *The Character of Rain*), where the just-born infant is described as being nothing less (in its own eyes) than God:

> Dieu n'avait pas de langage et il n'avait donc pas de pensée. Il était satiété et éternité. Et tout ceci prouvait au plus haut point que Dieu était Dieu. Et cette évidence n'avait aucune importance, car Dieu se fichait éperdument d'être Dieu. (p. 6)
>
> God did not have language and so did not have thoughts. He was satisfaction and eternity. And all this proved above all else that God was God. And this piece of evidence was of utterly no importance, because God didn't give a damn about being God. [My translation]

And since the newborn infant is God, it feels under no obligation to identify with anyone other than itself. It is self-sufficient. That this insight is formulated in a novel, i. e., in a piece of literature, is no accident, as will turn out later in this essay.

Hence, for the first hours in our lives, we are on our own, and all others are potential enemies. As time goes by, however, the number of enemies significantly and constantly decreases. The circle of people with whom I can identify grows: we gradually get used to those boundary crossings that link us to other people. But only up to a point, when the processes of further identification 'freeze', at least for most people. Perhaps some of us have in the past 'frozen' any potential for identification with people from a Muslim country, thanks to media coverage of extremists' acts of violence. Maybe the conference in Istanbul offered the first possibility for many European delegates to come into contact with an Islamic culture, and maybe take the opportunity to cross the cultural boundaries and identify with Muslim people. Hence the 'freezing point' at which identification stops is evidently different for different people. And it is never final, as

‘defrosting’ may always set in. An interesting question is thereby raised: what can trigger such ‘defrosting’? I will argue shortly that literature is such a ‘defroster’; that it can help to raise our ‘freezing point’ for identification.

In everyday life, though, we constantly observe fellow humans who have frozen all identification beyond their present circle: they are no longer prepared to cross the self-created boundaries that isolate them from their neighbours. But not all do so. There are people who keep on identifying with new and different foreign people. Some of them have the capacity to identify with the poorest and weakest. Often they are known as saints, heroes, or wise men or women. Examples that come to mind are Jesus of Nazareth, Mother Theresa, or Gautama.

For most people, however, processes of identification may not take place so easily, certainly not in all areas of life. One such area where processes of identification are more problematic is gender. Boys generally do not that easily identify with girls, and men not with women – and vice versa. Obviously, some boundaries are not easily crossed, and gender boundaries seem to be of such a kind. Another area is age: the young and the old may lead very different lives and hence not really identify with each other. There may also be only little economic identification: the rich may not care for the poor, who themselves feel envious or even resentful at not having the wealth that they crave. And there may be difficulties in identifying with people of different nations. Finally, identifying across religious and ideological borders may sometimes seem insurmountable.

So the other side of the coin is that as soon as the child starts identifying with its own family, at the same time other families will be perceived as different, strange, even weird, perhaps also dangerous. If I identify with my village (or sports club, or nation) people from the neighbouring village (or club, or nation) may seem strange and threatening. Why is that so? I cannot give a full answer to this question, but I believe that one reason is that people unconsciously think of such relationships as zero-sum games. Zero-sum games are games (in the sense that this term is used in mathematical game theory) in which there necessarily is one winner and one loser. Chess and soccer are good examples of zero-sum games: there is only one winner, and the one who does not win automatically loses. Singing songs together, on the other hand, is a ‘game’ in which there are no

winners or losers: it is not a zero-sum game. The same goes for playing music together, hiking, or recreational skiing. But in zero-sum games, there must be a winner and a loser. Now I presume that the idea of zero-sum games is very much in the back of our minds when it comes to the kind of identification processes I have described so far. The process involved goes as follows: if women win, men must lose; if the immigrants win, the natives will lose; if the haves win, the have-nots must lose; if the Brazilians win the match, the Turks will lose.

The problem with these everyday mental processes is that they represent a totally flawed view of reality. The world does not function as a zero-sum game: it is only a preconception that seems to be wired in our head, but one that does not correspond to how things happen in reality. There is no reason why men should lose when women get equal rights – perhaps even quite the opposite. And it is not necessarily the case that when the wealthy get wealthier the poor may lose: they may also benefit at the same time. The world is not a zero-sum game. Yet this model is a very powerful one in the way in which people deal with the world. But identifying with hitherto unknown people is a clear example that the zero-sum game metaphor can be overcome.

Now what are the results of these identification processes? As we have seen, in each new process of identification the initial feelings of uncertainty are transcended. The result is a new person, a person who is enriched compared to the previous person he or she was. That person now has a wider network of social contacts, a wider array of emotional experiences, a richer access to other perspectives on life. It is at this point that the relevance of literature comes in.

3. Identification with literature

My proposal is that literature, at least where it exists freely, acts as a corrective against the petrifaction of the processes of identification. While identification starts off naturally in early infancy, for most people it somehow come to a standstill later in life. Literature, so I will argue, opens vistas for boundary crossings that had become petrified in daily life. Literature does this by opposing and undermining entrenched views and categorical ideological positions. Thus what I believe that literature ultimately does is what the theme of the Istanbul conference is all about: it fundamentally challenges existing boundaries that prevent me from identifying with other

people. For instance, in literature we read about characters who are very often different from ourselves. If I am a man, I may become acquainted with a female character, and in this way get acquainted with female ways of thinking, feeling, and acting. One may read about characters who live in other times, in other circumstances, in other places that I may not have visited and perhaps may never be able to visit. Literature has the power to make us cross the boundaries from within to outside ourselves by reënacting the processes of outward-identification that shape the individual from the outset of life.

At a more fundamental level, what we can witness is that literature (at least much of it) depicts characters that deviate from the usual and the average. We may remember that at the very beginning of literary theory in the Western tradition, Aristotle points out in his *Poetics* that the tragic character is elevated above the average everyday person, while in comedy it is the opposite: there we observe characters who are morally 'below average'. In literature we often read about characters who deviate from everyday people. There is an evident sense in which this is true: in reading a fictional story we read about others, who by definition are different from ourselves. Yet it is not in this, more everyday sense, that I mean that literary characters are different. My proposal is, rather, that literature differs decisively in its portrayal of human beings in that it as a rule depicts that which *deviates* from the usual and the average. Most of us certainly would not jump into the lake along with Beowulf; most of us do not have the courage of a Roland or an Antigone. Or we encounter characters who possess excessive skills or intelligence like Sherlock Holmes. Or characters with increased emotional susceptibility like Emma Bovary. We sympathise with Emma in spite of her actions, which we might morally condemn. Or characters with unusual moral integrity and perseverance, like Brecht's Galileo, facing the Inquisition, or G. B. Shaw's Saint Joan. Even in cases where at first sight we are dealing with characters who resemble most of us, they often turn out to be rather different after a while. Think, for instance, of Camus' *L'étranger*: the story starts off narrating trivialities from daily life of what at first seems to be a quite normal person, who is at the end of the story condemned to death because of the way he thinks, feels, and behaves. Or think of the figures in Samuel Beckett's stories, like Molloy, for instance. Or indeed, of the just-born infant feeling like God that Amélie Nothomb so powerfully invokes.

This idea, that literature as a rule deals with the unusual, has been a central tenet of literary theory in the West. For instance, the Russian Formalists and the Prague Structuralists, who developed the theory of defamiliarisation[1], made it clear that what we encounter in a literary text are usually deviations of some kind. The Formalists and Structuralists described instances of such deviations in the language writers employ, and in this sense they took a somewhat narrow view of the deviational aspect of literature. That their ideas are nowadays largely stigmatised is somewhat surprising. It has been argued, for instance, that by concentrating on literature's formal characteristics, Formalism neglected the sociohistorical and political dimension of literature and culture, thus leading us back to a traditionalist perspective. However, as Peter Steiner (1984: 243) has pointed out, 'These and similar attempts to "deconstruct" Formalism by pointing out its ideological or aesthetic basis proceed from a fundamental misunderstanding of its aims'. Moreover, the shortcomings of Formalism, which are not to be denied or swept under the carpet, can (and should) be remedied without abandoning their central epistemological stand or their major theoretical insights.

As the theory of foregrounding makes clear, crossing boundaries is precisely what literature is about: crossing the boundaries of our everyday assumptions, of our stereotypes and entrenched categories of thinking, of the usual and the banal. In crossing these boundaries during our reading, we overcome barriers we had ourselves thrown up around us.

And in crossing these, we change ourselves, we grow as individuals. Foregrounding is to be conceptualised here as what the Formalists called *ostranenie*: making strange. When we reach out as readers from our world into the world that the author has 'made strange', that world becomes un-strange. Now that world becomes accessible, perhaps even attractive. A threshold has been passed. We have come to feel at home in a hitherto unknown (and perhaps threatening) world. Reading literature changes us by redrawing the boundaries that had been erected. The foregrounding of which literary authors make use to deautomatise our perception forces us to look beyond the zero-sum game.

In that sense literature is profoundly subversive of any totalising world-view that would characterise the world as a zero-sum game,

whether of the right or of the left (which is why dictatorships of both left and right fear literature so much). One can make a case for the view that Solzhenitsyn's 'One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovitch' was more instrumental in the eventual downfall of Communism than all overt protests against its regimes. That literary work was mightier because it made readers for the first time identify with the zeks in the Gulag concentration camps rather than with their Communist leaders, and this set the scene for the whole sham edifice to come crashing down some decades later.

But is literature really that much deviant from what we observe in everyday reality? Should we not think of those many works of literature in which apparently everyday people form the focus of attention? Are Dickens' or Jane Austen's characters not often rather usual human creatures, with little of the heroic or the extraordinary, but instead vulnerable people with everyday anxieties of the kind you and I may have? And what about Aristophanes, Mark Twain, or Samuel Richardson, to name only a few examples that come to mind? I would argue that when we look at those characters in more detail, however, we notice that they are presented to us in ways in which they are often not seen at all.

I have shown elsewhere that Dickens' factory workers, for instance, are shown to be very different from what the bourgeoisie at that time thought them to be; see van Peer (1995). Similarly, Austen's Emma in the end turns out to be a very different Emma from what she appears initially. And Richardson's Pamela is more courageous and more intelligent than most 18th-century people of the upper classes would have believed a country girl to have been. Finally, although Aristophanes' plays are often made up of what must have been rather common people in a Greek city, they are nevertheless presented to us in unusual ways. Take *Lysistrata*, for instance. As Martha Nussbaum (1993) has pointed out, the women in this play are presented as human beings not really different from men, with similar emotional concerns, and likewise gifted with shrewd political instincts. We may find nothing surprising about that, but we have to remember that to a Greek male audience, this must have been an unsettling spectacle. Greek women were generally expected to stay at home, not to meddle with politics – and certainly not with military matters. The play negated everything that men at the time thought about their mothers,

their wives, and their sisters. And these women seemed to be calculating their strategies rationally, which they were not supposed to, concerned with vital issues of the state, of war, of political freedom, issues that were vital to male Greeks, vital also to the laws that they obeyed. So the experience, although it was partly comical, must also have been a defamiliarising one: it broke out of the entrenched categories that men had about women at the time. And perhaps this could have led, after a while, to a reconsideration of categories. I am not suggesting that after having viewed Aristophanes' *Lysistrata* women were all of a sudden liberated. Obviously they were not. So it is not the case that after identifying for a short while with these characters one will automatically change one's categories. But at least for the time that you are in the theatre (or reading a book) something is happening to you: the boundaries of your identity become stretched and your identity itself becomes enlarged.

4. Three questions

I will now address three questions that arise out of the previous considerations. The first question is *why* literature apparently favours unusual characters of the kind I have described above. The second question is how we can explain the psychological processes by which we identify with the characters, in spite of the fact that often we are surprised, if not shocked by their ideas and actions. Think of Raskolnikov in Dostoyevsky's *Crime and Punishment*: how can we explain that although we are appalled by the carefully planned and cold-blooded murder we nevertheless continue to be drawn into Raskolnikov's world? Finally, I will address the question what the consequences are that we so easily identify with these deviant figures.

The first question then, the question *why* this is the case. Why, in other words, are the purely ordinary and the completely unexpected not 'tellable'? What drives us to prefer stories and poems about unusual and surprising events and actions, and to despise everything that is commonplace and clichéd in writing and art? With respect to such questions, we must be honest and modest. Both virtues compel us to confess our uncertainty. It is not that we are completely ignorant as to possible answers, however. One way to answer the question would be to say that humans love to make up stories. But that, of course, is begging the question. What must be explained is why there is this drive to make up stories in the first place. Maybe the best

possible answer to the question is to be given with reference to human imagination. As human beings, we cannot avoid imagining the world being different from what it actually is. The proof lies in the difficulty we have in *not* imagining things. Try to tell young children not to imagine, not to play games, not to pretend to be someone else. I think the example is clear in showing the futility of the effort. Even young babies, before they can walk or talk, already spontaneously join in a game of peek-a-boo if you start one. 'Had we but World enough and Time', Andrew Marvell writes. But we *know* that we have not time enough, we know that our lives are finite. Without death, without suffering, with limitless time – eternity! – without any constraints on any resources, then, yes *then* we would not *need* any imagination. But since we know that we will die, since we experience pain, and since we all too rapidly realise how very limited we are in what we can do, achieve, and experience, we have recourse to our imagination to experience that which is not on offer in reality. The human condition being what it is, however, we cannot *not* imagine things being different. This, presumably, is the anthropological basis of human imagination. As yet, however, we live under the imperative of our limitations, and hence of our need for creativity. In imagining characters in stories, we experiment with the parameters that constrain our possibilities and our happiness. The outcome of these manipulations shows us the logic of human behaviour and its consequences.

But if this is the case, then how is it possible to identify with these strange characters, some of whom are quite repugnant or frightening? This, it will be remembered, was our second question. However, it would seem that we now have solved that problem too: we engage so easily with protagonists who deviate from the usual, because we are born with this drive to explore the unknown. That insight also paves the way for a better understanding of what goes on psychologically while reading. Precisely because the things narrated in literature are unusual, we undergo some kind of alienation. The deviation from our well-known reality means a confrontation with something alien to us. Of course this view does not entail that there is only one such world-view. What is meant here is that the processes of alienation described here occur relative to readers' common sense model of reality. In the process, a cognitive and/or emotive conflict emerges. Insofar as we bring our own identity to the reading of literature – that is, our past

biographies, our knowledge and expectations, our feelings and concerns – that identity is partly negated. To the extent that literature confronts us with the negation of our selves, it can be said to be a force of 'negative identity', compelling us to come to grips with unresolved aspects of our world.

This clash with a negative identity may be quite powerful, and may demand strategies for coping with it. Generally, two courses of action are open. One may fully confront the issue, or one may (in various forms) rationalise it away. The latter seems to be what happened in Greek society. Aristophanes' comedy did not lead to a full-fledged equality of men and women the day after the performance. When a powerful image conflicts with our deeply held convictions, we always have at our disposal the escape route of turning away from it. In our times, this has given rise to a psychological theory, Festinger's (1956) theory of 'cognitive dissonance': when incoming information becomes too unsettling, we have the option of ignoring it, or of explaining it away. Maybe the Greeks did that: you know, it was just a funny story, those women wanting to stop the Peloponnesian War. Such remarks may have been the end. But note that this is unlikely to have been all there was to it. After all, we still have the play, and it continues to attract enthusiastic reactions of readers and actors, showing that, perhaps, after more than two millennia, Aristophanes' defamiliarisation is still operative, and probably more than 'just funny'.

If, however, the confrontation with the defamiliarised world of literature is taken seriously, this may lead to a reconsideration of entrenched ideas, to a reëxamination of what one had always believed to be the case. Such reflective processes may be fostered by the negative identity that literature regularly presents. Its outcome is not an evaporated individuality, not a loss of identity. In reading literature we do not rub out something in our personality and replace it with something else. Rather, what happens is that new ideas and emotions are integrated into what we already were. The process of transcending negative identity in our literary confrontations is a source of enrichment and joy. That, I think, solves the puzzle of how we can identify with the defamiliarised world of unusual characters. We come to know (usually at an early age) what personal benefits we may reap from such identification.

That leaves us with our final question, which may be the most important and the most interesting one. This was the question of what the effects are of literary reading. Some reflection on what has been said so far now allows us to provide some answers to this question, too. If literature is the source of enrichment and growth that has been outlined before, then societies may intuit the advantages this can bring them. If significant portions of its members can be made to go through such personality-strengthening confrontations with negative identity, society will ultimately profit from this. Hence it appears that literature fulfills a social function in human cultures. This function relates to adaptability, the capacity to adjust its ideas and attitudes to a changing environment rather than stick to a fossilised tradition. Perhaps in the course of our evolution we have learned that we have more chances of surviving if we adapt to the changing circumstances in which we find ourselves. And the better a society is in adapting itself, the more chances it has to survive. Literature may in some form contribute to this adaptability by providing the experiences with negative identity that I have described.

This does not mean, by the way, that someone invented this function, or that some authority prescribed it. Things functionally come into being without explicit or even conscious decisions being taken. Most often, we do not even know what functions are served by particular practices. This brings us back to the first question, namely *why* we observe defamiliarisation in literature. It now becomes obvious that this is one of the ways by which such adaptability in society may be accomplished. It should be pointed out, however, that the psychological processes that we have described before are crucial for its continuing endurance. The reading experience forms a kind of linchpin between the formal devices that authors employ in composing a literary text, and the cultural functions that texts fulfill. Without the mediating psychological experiences of readers such functions could not be fulfilled, and the energy invested by writers would be lost. What this means is that a viable literary theory should take account of all three phenomena: textual qualities, psychological processes, and cultural functions. At present, few if any theories are able to provide adequate accounts for each of those levels, let alone to combine them into a general framework that is able to explain the nature and rationale of literature as a human invention. The theory of

foregrounding, however, looks like a promising candidate, as the previous elaborations have hopefully indicated.

So far I have argued that effects of reading literature on identity formation may be assumed. Is that really the case, however? Must we not conclude, rather, that exposure to such texts leaves the reader unaffected and unchanged? Possibly – but unlikely, given the nature of our intuitions. However, intuition and plausibility are not enough if we want to know something for certain. It is one of the profound lessons to be learned from the history of science that our intuitions may betray us into believing things that are untrue. The consequence of this lesson is that we have to build in controls, so as to guard ourselves against false beliefs. Such work can be done. By and large, the social sciences offer us the methods for doing so. However, that will require a different (and harder) style of thinking and a more adult research methodology. My experience is that literary scholars are usually unprepared for this. They may also be unwilling to invest time and energy into such research. That may be a forgivable kind of inertia where one's own background and training are concerned. It is not forgivable, however, to oppose such efforts, or to withhold the possibility of exploring such research methods from a new generation of students. Since they are still in the course of their training, we can provide them with the necessary skills to seek solutions to our problems, for instance, by working together with social scientists, many of whom have a genuine interest in the arts and literature and would only love to gain some expertise from cooperation with literary scholars.

It is possible, of course, that one does not even want to do this either, and instead prefers to remain happy within the traditional boundaries of the literary realm. In fact, I have often seen (even fierce) opposition to the course proposed here. It is then claimed that the study of literature is not social science, and that any movement in this direction will mean the end of literary studies. But why would one wish to oppose new developments that offer themselves as a solution to one's problems? Such developments presumably can only enrich a discipline. Opposition against new approaches impedes our understanding of literary phenomena. And remember, the questions addressed here are real (and important) questions in literary theory

itself, not something dreamed up by a literary *dilettante* from psychology.

But may we presume the effects of literary reading to be real? Or are we presuming too much? The latter seems to be the prevalent attitude among literary scholars, namely that literature is only for the few, that its influence in the world at large is but marginal, and that our professional interests should not make us believe that literature is also deemed important by outsiders. I think this scepticism and relativism are misplaced and potentially self-destructive, in that they may contribute to the further erosion of reading habits in society. But it is also misplaced in the face of the evidence there is. Hakemulder (2000) presents the very best evidence on this issue. He reports on an extensive literature search he carried out in order to find some information concerning the question what the effects of identifying with unusual characters in literature are. What he found is interesting: out of some 50 studies he found, 16 were methodologically so reliable that their conclusions can hardly be doubted. What are these conclusions? That reading stories about an outgroup has a marked and perhaps even lasting positive effect on one's perception and evaluation of that outgroup. The same was the case for readers' view on gender roles and up to a certain point also for critical thinking: compared to a control group, readers of literature were more inclined to think critically.

However, much more work is needed here. In particular, we would like to know what it is in literature that causes these effects. This is obviously a valid and highly important question, because the answers to it will to a significant degree determine the value we can and should attribute to literary reading.

5. Stereotypes and their enemy: literature

It is time to take stock. What I have claimed so far is that processes of identification occur naturally and spontaneously in everyday life from the earliest moments onwards, that these processes are felt to be rewarding, and that in principle there is no reason why they should come to a halt. Furthermore, I have argued that literature provides ample opportunities for extended, albeit imaginative, identification possibilities, and that such reading experiences may eventually alter our own views and attitudes. I have also claimed that some such effects are documented in the research literature, but that in order to

understand such processes more fully, we need far more studies probing the concrete devices that bring to life such processes of transformation.

When we go about our business in everyday life, we largely rely on stereotypical views of the world. Social psychologists tell us that we cannot live without such stereotypes, and that they are a natural part of our cognitive make-up. Here is how Walter Lippmann ([1922] 1965: 21), who invented the term long ago, defines stereotypes:

> [They] are an ordered, more or less consistent picture of the world, to which our habits, our tastes, our capacities, our comforts and our hopes have adjusted themselves. They may not be a complete picture of the world, but they are a picture of a possible world to which we are adapted. In that world people and things have their well-known places, and do certain expected things. We feel at home there. We fit in. We are members. We know the way around. There we find the charm of the familiar, the normal, the dependable; its grooves and shapes are where we are accustomed to find them. And though we have abandoned much that might have tempted us before we creased ourselves into that mold, once we are firmly in, it fits as snugly as an old shoe.

How different this is from literature! How much literature deviates from the stereotypical images of reality we carry in our heads.

Iser (1978: 50) had an insightful formulation for this:

> [I]t is only when the reader is forced to produce the meaning of the text under unfamiliar conditions, rather than under his own conditions …, that he can bring to light a layer of his personality that he had previously been unable to formulate in his conscious mind.

And through the use of literary devices deviant characters in literature are made acceptable, more tasteful, even attractive to us, so that through that attraction, readers may identify with them, and through this identification let themselves be changed. Thus literature is a Trojan horse: once you start entertaining the idea that the world could be different from what stereotypical views tell us, it may open the way for change, not only of the individual, but also of society. It may take time, but eventually the Trojan horse will open and soldiers will come out of it. This, I believe, is why censorship exists. If literature were not capable of inducing social change, there would be no need for censorship. But the powerful have always known that literature can be dangerous and they therefore realise that they must control its influence at all costs.

6. Conclusion

Let me conclude by drawing your attention to the title of this chapter, a Quaker proverb:

> 'It is the not-me in thee that is to me most precious'.

The Quakers have always been known for spreading their message of love peacefully. This proverb beautifully illustrates what I have been trying to say. It epitomises, with its cleft sentence construction, with the archaic 'thee' (reminding us of the language of Shakespeare), with the strong long rhyme of the /i:/-vowel, the essence of the identification processes I have described before. And it sums it up in a cognitively salient and emotionally appealing formulation. We know from research that when one is surprised one will be apt to give the message one's full attention and explore its potential meaning and ramifications, will remember it better, and will be more inclined to be affected by it and enjoy it. All of this is well known in poetics and stylistics as a result of previous investigations of the theory of foregrounding. The implication of this is that one of *the* hallmarks of literature, foregrounding, exalts the very learning modalities for identifying with fellow human beings. It is an advantage that the characters with whom we associate ourselves do not exist: we are thus allowed to overcome what would otherwise be forbidden or frowned upon. When learning to identify in life, and later, when identifying with deviant characters in literature, it is precisely that which is not like us that we hold dear and that transforms us into different human beings:

> It is the not-me
> In thee
> That is
> to me
> Most precious.

Endnote

[1]This theory is usually called 'foregrounding'. See, for an overview, van Peer (forthcoming) and van Peer, Zyngier & Hakemulder (in press).

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Foucault: Explorer of the Limitless Reign of the Limits

Daniel Defert

Abstract

The limit is a central category in Michel Foucault's description of the historical construction of values of any culture. But it is subjected to a multiplicity of perspectives through a permanent problematisation of western interiority or subjectivity, a concept of power without exteriority and a fascination for the enigma of exteriority of thought and language.

Key words: Foucault; madness; reason; sexuality; literature.

My purpose is to sketch some debatable propositions that stem from the complex ways that Michel Foucault, while resisting disciplinary boundaries, problematised some of the major Western cultural, theoretical, and emotional limits – the boundaries of man, of reason, and of language.

* * *

'One should write a history of the limits … '.

Such are the words that open Foucault's seminal work, *Madness and Civilization* (Foucault [1961] 1965). I apologise for my own translation here*; in most cases, where an English translation is available, I use it. But the English version of *Madness and Civilization* represents only two-thirds of the French version (I must confess my pleasure in discovering, here, that the Turkish translation is based on the original French edition).

> One should write a history of the limits, those obscure gestures necessarily forgotten as soon as accomplished, through which a culture rejects what will be the outside for that culture, and along its history this void, this white space through which this culture isolates itself.

**Editors' Note*: Quotations from Foucault are from the French original as translated by Professor Defert. The citations to the English versions of Foucault's works are included for ease of reference, but the page numbers are only approximate.

> It is this void that designates it, as much as its own positive value might do ... this void, this white space is the region where a culture exerts its main choices, builds the dividing wall that shapes the figure of its positivity. (Foucault [1961] 1965: 161)

To problematise the limits was from the very beginning, for Foucault, to propose a totally new history of their constructions, to question their apparently natural but fragile evidence. Treated as 'human gestures', the main intellectual and institutional divisions of our culture became for Foucault a powerful, interpretive framework, connecting materials from philosophy, literature, theology, and medicine with political, economic, and social practices. I will try to indicate how deeply this interpretive framework is opposed to a dialectical way of thinking.

'One should write a history of the limits' should be amended to 'There is no history, except of the limits'.

To illustrate the complex relationship between Western culture and what has been constructed as its limits, I will concentrate my presentation on what can be seen as three 'limit-experiences'. Foucault borrowed this notion from Georges Bataille; while Bataille used it for individual and spiritual rather than psychological exercises on oneself, Foucault applied the notion as a grid to sociohistorical experiences, as events. These three limit-experiences that I will focus on have a paramount significance in Foucault's thought.

First there is the historical experience of madness, as the visible face of transgression for centuries – which has long occupied an indeterminate area between the prohibitions directed at action and those directed at language.

Then there is the historical experience of sexuality, which in every society is embedded in a complex network of taboos, lines not to be crossed, norms of conduct, and norms of speech.

And third there is literature. We know how much Foucault privileged those who were writing from behind the walls of prisons or asylums: Sade, Hölderlin, Brisset, Roussel, Artaud, and Genet. Foucault made famous – even as writers – Pierre Rivière, a parricide, and Herculine Barbin, a hermaphrodite, for their transgressive gestures.

What was the point of collecting their texts, why the irruptive inclusion in our language of the speech of the excluded? 'Why

discover oneself in their utterances and not in themselves?' Foucault asked.

Madness, sexuality, literature: three domains where limits have specific history, a history that has been his ceaseless object of research, in which there has been transgression of both a code of conduct and a linguistic code.

'The domain of the prohibitions in language should itself be studied someday'. (Foucault [1964] 1997: 100)

Foucault proposed a classification of four major prohibitions in language that may be considered as a vector along which madness has been displaced in Western history (this vector may account for displacements in the domain of literature, too).

The first prohibition in language is in the ambiguous area between the forbidden and the impossible – the domain of linguistic errors.

The second is in the domain of blasphemous words, which are related mainly to religion, sex, and magic.

The third is in the area that is tolerated by the linguistic code but not, at a certain time, by the culture. This is the domain of censorship.

The fourth takes place when an utterance that appears to conform to the accepted code is subjected to another code, whose key is contained within this same utterance. So this utterance is divided against itself. It is transgressive not only in its meaning – in its verbal aspect – but also in its inner play. Freud was the first to have decoded this silent surplus, which enunciates what it says.

In their utterances, mad persons enunciate the linguistic code in which they enunciate their utterances. They alone may come through it by making unlimited free associations. The distinction inaugurated by Ferdinand de Saussure between speech and language (*parole* and *langue*) may help us to understand this process.

What really concerns me here is the conclusion drawn by Foucault:

> We still don't know much about the organization of the prohibitions of language. But what is not allowed to appear at the level of the word is not necessarily what is forbidden in the realm of the deed. The Zuni Indians narrate incest between brother and sister, which is outlawed, and the Greeks told the legend of Oedipus. (Foucault [1964] 1997: 100)

So prohibition in the domain of language – which concerns madness, sexuality, and literature as well – must not be considered as the verbal expression of the other systems of limits. It is a whole domain still to be explored.

Now I would like to try to retrace in more detail what is at stake in each of these three cultural experiences.

For most historians and for the psychiatrist David Cooper, the core of *Madness and Civilization*, a seminal work of Foucault's research, is the invention of madness as a disease or 'mental illness'. But among the first critics to review the book was Roland Barthes, who later commented: 'Michel Foucault has begun to speak of the Reason/Unreason as, ultimately, the essential subject of all theoretical work on literature'. (Barthes 1981: 33)

In fact what Foucault achieved was a series of displacements of the cultural, ethical, and scientific status of the division between reason and unreason through modern history – how the boundaries between reason and unreason have been challenged since the Classical Age, and how this challenge accounts, still, for our so-called scientific and medical constructs of mental illness.

At the heart of Foucault's enterprise is a history of Western reason – the reason that at once binds together and separates reason and madness.

I quote the first preface to *Madness and Civilization*:

> We have yet to write the history of that other form of madness by which men, in an act of sovereign reason, confine their neighbors, and communicate and recognize each other through the merciless language of non-madness ... to define the moment of this conspiracy, before it was permanently established in the realm of truth ... . We must try to return, in history, to that zero point in the course of madness, at which madness is an undifferentiated experience, a not yet divided experience of division itself. (Foucault [1961] 1965: ix)

We know that this 'conspiracy' has a name in Foucault's work: It is the 'great confinement', a distinctive feature of the European 17th century, when a significant portion of the population was confined, within a few months, in asylums without therapeutic purposes.

I would like to list, and distinguish between, some of the salient features of this huge historical division between madness and reason; for setting limits is such a historical process that to challenge

boundaries supposes the understanding of their complex nexus:

> In its broadest terms, this is a narrative of the loss of the tragic sense of madness within the secularization of the culture (or, in the Nietzschean terms that Foucault repeats), the tragedy of the loss of tragedy. (During 1992: 32)

'Classical confinement' encompasses madness as such

> libertinism of thought and speech, the obstinacy within impiety or heterodoxy, blasphemy, sorcery, alchemy; in short, everything that characterizes the spoken and forbidden world of unreason ...[,] those who, against the code of language, pronounce words without meaning (the insane, the imbecile, the demented); or those who utter sanctified words (the violent ones, the furious); or those who bring forth forbidden meanings (the libertines, the headstrong). With Freud only, madness ceased to be a linguistic error or an intolerable meaning. (Foucault [1964] 1997: 106)

Administrative confinement represented also an economic policy against unemployed, vagrant, poor, idle people. More than an effective economic policy of forced work, this practice underlined a new ethical consciousness of work.

In the same manner, sexual offenders, free thinkers, and those guilty of religious profanities were no longer presented to a religious tribunal as 'religious offenders' but were submitted – like idle people, or venereal-disease sufferers, or those practicing sodomy – to an administrative procedure, a moral appreciation, all reduced to a violation of bourgeois morality.

The Classical Age assimilated, through confinement, two experiences of insanity: first, the old medical category of madness – 10 percent of all the arrests made in Paris for the Hôpital General – , a category that had been already identified and isolated within Arabic medicine and Spanish hospices; and, two, a broad category of unreason confusing illness and immorality (simulated madness was treated like unintentional madness).

Madness was no longer an experience of evil (the big other), or of the infinity of the deity, or of contact with the cosmos (the outside, the unlimited outside), as it had been until the Renaissance. It was now rooted in the moral world, human ill will: the inner world of the individual where, later on, the psychiatrists would locate it as the truth of the individual. The target of confinement was an ill will.

Being an ill will, a wrong choice, an ethical error, unreason still communicates with reason when, in the 17th century, reason is represented as free will – the good, ethical choice.

The 17th-century classical division between reason and unreason is an impressive paradigm from which we can judge how complex cultural boundaries are. They must not be thought of as a wall built of one material. Religion was no more the absolute frontier, and medicine was not yet the limit. The split between the normal and the pathological, physiologically determined, was not yet the principle of classification.

Classical unreason was neither pathological nor blasphemous. Since Roman law, it was a principle accepted by lawyers, one by which true madness could excuse a crime. But classical rationalism would not conceive a madness where reason would be totally absent. Will and not reason was wrong. The limit between fault and reason was obscure.

Madness was experimented with within an ethical framework. Descartes, the doubting philosopher, had excluded madness as grounds for his philosophical doubts. As long as his meditations were an exercise of his will upon his intellectual proceedings, there was no risk of madness. Sanity is as unquestionable as the fact that he thinks and exists.

> Madness is located in an unforeseeable freedom, where frenzy is unchained ... .
>
> To respect madness is not to interpret it as the inevitable accident of disease but to recognize a limit – not accidental but essential. As death is the limit of life in the realm of time, madness is its limit in the realm of animality. (Foucault [1961] 1965: 81)

But the history of exclusion is, generally, the history of inclusion – inclusion within architectural structures, within technical and institutional discourses, and within scientific discourses, too – that will soon reduce the forbidden, mad utterances to silence. From the beginning of the 19th century, a new profession would be entitled to profess the only correct discourse on the experience of madness: psychiatry. Then madness would cease to be at the limits of the world, of man, of death (an eschatological figure), and would find its proper place in a hospital. In Foucault's late terminology, we can speak of a subjectivisation of madness on ethical grounds.

* * *

The psychiatric profession has been deeply offended by the way that Foucault has treated it in his history of madness – not as part of the history of scientific progress in medicine but by placing it in the

history of exclusion and confinement. He shocked, even more, psychoanalysts and radical movements, which were campaigning for sexual liberation, with the first volume of his *History of Sexuality* ([1976] 1978).

Here we are confronted with a very different interpretation of what limits do, of the role of limits.

In an answer to an interviewer, Foucault said that sex has become, in our culture, as emotional a limit as madness was in the age of confinement:

> Perhaps sexuality has become the only division possible in a world now emptied of objects, of beings, and of spaces to desecrate. It permits a profanation without object, a profanation that is empty and turned towards itself. (Foucault [1964] 1997: 29-30)

That is precisely consonant with what Bataille meant by transgression.

> We like to believe that sexuality has regained in contemporary experience its full truth as a process of nature ... . We have not, in the least, liberated sexuality, though we have, to be exact, carried it to its limits: The limit of consciousness, since it ultimately dictates the only possible reading of our unconscious; the limit of the law, since it seems the sole substance of universal taboos; the limit of language, since it traces that line of foam showing just how far speech may advance upon the sands of silence ... .
>
> Sexuality is a fissure, not one which surrounds us as the basis of our isolation or individuality, but one which marks the limit within us and designates us as a limit. (Foucault 1998: 24-5)

In the first of the three volumes of his *History of Sexuality*, Foucault raised two doubts:

> Is it so certain that our societies have repressed sexuality for centuries? We are supposed to live for centuries in societies where sexual conduct is carefully confined to parents' bedrooms and absorbed into serious functions of reproduction. Is the rest of sexual conduct condemned by taboos, prohibitions, censorship, and denials?
>
> Are we right to interpret limits, or any exercise of power, only in terms of repression? (Foucault [1976] 1978: 10)

In fact, sexual conduct is interwoven with and structured by a deployment of heterogeneous elements – practices, institutions, techniques, discourses, scientific discourses, illicit discourses, forms of financial profit – which submit sexual practices to a classification, a normative distribution, a moral rating of sexual acts (and of those who practice them), a differentiation and intensification, or decrease in intensification, of pleasure.

This ‘apparatus of sexuality’, as Foucault has designated this deployment, or network, has primacy over biological impulses. The shift to modern sexuality, which Foucault situated between Sade and Freud, started when doctors, psychiatrists, police, administration and that specific state management of the health and demography of the population named biopower by Foucault (which characterises modern states and modern wars since the end of the 18th century), when these new social actors took over the religious professions that had framed, at least within Christendom, the control of this apparatus of sexuality.

This apparatus of sexuality is not only a grid for analysis; it is an implementation of emotional intensities associated with sexual conduct. When doctors had charged Western bourgeois parents with caring for the sexual practices of their children, at the end of the eighteenth century – with inspecting their bedsheets, to check where they kept their hands while sleeping, to prevent them from masturbating – they implanted infantile sexuality, and the practice and emotions linked to it, in a new family drama. They were not only imposing limits but also creating a new area of sexual emotions and social concerns at the same time.

According to historians such as the British J. K. Dover (1978) or the French Paul Veyne (1987), or Foucault himself ([1976] 1978), in ancient Mediterranean civilisations, Greek and Roman, homoeroticism was not a separate issue. The conduct of a Greek or Roman was not judged by his (these things were more codified – or their archives are, at least, more numerous – for men than for women) preference for girls or boys, but whether he respected a code of age and a code of role with his same-sex partners. (Foucault [1984] 1985)

Only the passive role was condemned, as it was formulated not within a psychological interpretation but a political code. The education of a free citizen, i. e., an active citizen in public affairs, had to prevent him from any submissive inclination, attitude, or status that was permitted for women or slaves.

The construction of homosexuality as a perverted identity, by psychiatrists and jurists in the late 19th century, became almost simultaneously the very ground for liberation movements. It meant that homosexuals now constructed as such, with a psychological, political, and social identity, could only resist the new scientific and

social categorisation through acknowledging it. They had to transform a pathological categorisation, in Western countries, into a human right. As David Halperin (1995), an American theoretician and militant of the 'queer movement', phrased this situation, accurately: 'Sexual liberation is not only to free us to express our sexuality but the requirement to express it. It enslaves us to a specific mode of freedom'.

We are far from D. H. Lawrence's conception of free sex, which ignores all social contracts. The most accurate image, if we want to use a figure to represent this kind of limit, is the spiral – one where the outside becomes the inside and then the outside again. The image of the split of Classical reason and unreason, then, could be a mirror, where these two faced each other. The mirror could, as well, have (in Foucault's poetic, metaphorical language) the 'solid transparency of a window pane'.

* * *

To think of limits in terms of transgression may be an accurate paradigm when we turn to literature. I have already made the point that the regime of prohibitions and permissiveness is not the same for words and deeds.

Foucault accounted for the persistent presence, in Western literature – but, I suppose, in any literature – of such disruptive language as that of Sade, Hölderlin, Nerval, Roussel, and Artaud, but even of Bataille and Maurice Blanchot, who both constructed their writings as transgressive experiences:

> The sovereignty of these experiences must surely be recognized someday, and we must try to assimilate them; not to reveal their truth, a ridiculous pretension, with respect to words that form our limits. But our task today is to is to direct our attention to this nondiscursive language. (Foucault [1963] 1977: 38)

What does this mean, the notion of a 'nondiscursive language'? It points to a characteristic of literature that Foucault also refers to as the intransitivity of literature, at least modern literature, which has nothing else to transmit than the pure act of writing itself.

Is it possible that literature transmits nothing that is outside the work? Why such a fascination with a literature that has been written from the other side of asylum and prison walls, a literature of madness and crime – if the main quality of literature is its intransitivity, its

emptiness? Shall we assimilate Sade and Mallarmé? Most literary criticism written by Foucault is concerned with this issue. I will just briefly focus on two cases: the German poet Friedrich Hölderlin, and the French contemporary of Proust, Raymond Roussel.

In 'The Father's "No"' (Foucault [1962] 1977), a short essay devoted to Hölderlin, Foucault explores again the relationship of art and madness after the long cleavage in our culture. Clinical psychology, Foucault reports, has been concerned, 'Karl Jaspers, first and foremost', with the point at which a work of art ends and madness begins, through the erosion of meaning, the struggle at the limits of language.

To refute the psychological paradigm that concerns the limits of a work of art, Foucault turned toward the historical construction, in Christian Europe, of the concept of the psychology of the artist, as a way to interpret what lay outside the work itself.

The story starts, according to Foucault's research, with Vasari's *Le Vite de Piu Eccelenti Pittori, Scultori, e Architteti Italiani*, which was published in 1550. *Le Vite* is a heroic story of the continuity between an exceptional life and the exceptional work of art. Foucault himself has been a victim three times since his death of such chronic mystification of biography.

Vasari tells us how Giotto, a shepherd, was sketching sheep on a rock when Cimabue – the one who emancipated Italian painting from the Byzantine canon – found him and paid homage to his hidden majesty. This happened as, in mediaeval tales, a prince would suddenly be recognised in a crowd, because of a mysterious mark.

Through the ages, the theme of an other, an exterior of the work, accompanied our understanding of artists under various guises – the heroic figure, paramount in the Renaissance, was ultimately displaced by the madness of the artist. As Foucault observed,

> It is a madness that identifies the artist to his work and that makes him different from all those who remain silent; and it also situates the artist outside his work when it makes him deaf even to his own words. (Foucault [1962] 1977: 75)

To this mythology, Foucault opposes another reading, that Hölderlin's work was ruined by what initially constituted it: the inevitability of

death, the inaccessible existence of mortals, the disappearance of gods and, last, madness. Foucault comments:

> In the pleasure of an artistic work, at the border of its language, a limit emerges whose function is to silence its language and bring the work to completion; and this is the limit that formed the work against all that was not itself. (Foucault [1962] 1977: 79-80)
> Hölderlin occupies a unique and exemplary position: He created and manifested the link between a work and the absence of a work....
>
> He stripped the artist of his capacity to raise every event to the heights of language. Hölderlin's language replaced the epic unity commemorated by Vasari with a division that is responsible for every work in the culture, a division that links it to its own absence, and to its dissolution in the madness that has accompanied it from the beginning. (Foucault [1962] 1977: 86)

Why does a work of art have such a proximity to madness, to the absence of work? It is not because of a resemblance between themes of lyricism and psychosis but more fundamentally because the work of art at the same time poses and transgresses the limit that creates, threatens, and completes it.

So what is outside a work of art is at its heart, as death is at the heart of Blanchot's writing.

This complex play with the limits of and transgression in a work of art is developed again in an entire volume devoted to Raymond Roussel, the English title of which is *Death and the Labyrinth*.

Roussel's point of departure is almost the same as is Ferdinand de Saussure's: there are fewer words than things, and fewer sounds than words. Therefore, it is possible to say two things with the same words, and any phrase may be transformed into another, phonetically similar one. If the same sounds have different meanings, verbal signs are hollow; this demonstrates either the failure of language to connect firmly to the world or its very finitude.

> Language, that thin blade that slits the identity of things, flows toward an invisible void where things are beyond reach and disappear in its mad pursuit of them. (Foucault [1962] 1977: 86)

Consequently, writing is a play in the void that has been opened by the poverty of language. It is what is meant by the intransitivity of literature, a limitless play on the very linguistic limits.

> Before Mallarmé, writing consisted of establishing one's utterance within a given linguistic code, as if the work of language were of the same nature as that of the rest of language, close to the familiar signs of rhetoric, of the subject or of the images. By the end of the nineteenth century (around the

> time of the discovery of psychoanalysis, when there was certainly no dearth of discoveries), literature had become utterance that inscribed in itself its own principle of decipherment – or the gesture of writing suspended from the reign of the code. (Foucault [1964] 1997: 102)

I must thank you for your willingness to dash with me through these major limits of language, reason, and sexual identity, and to look at these major domains of transgression in deeds and speeches. But you may have noticed how, for Classical reason, madness was not the absolute other. Reason and unreason mirrored each other as two different sides of a free will, split by the solid transparency of a windowpane. Inside and outside are social constructs in the Western history of sexuality; the subject is successively constructed, dissolved, and reinterpreted through an apparatus of power-knowledge along a continuous spiral.

Madness, sexuality, and transgression in literature from Sade to Bataille are powerfully linked in Foucault's mind to the theme of a disappearance of a more fundamental limit, for those who take seriously the withdrawal of god or of being; I have insisted on the secularisation of madness and of sexuality as well in Foucault's work. Transgression, a powerful concept that organizes Bataille's work, refers not to a real profanation, religious or juridical, but to a profanation in a world that recognizes no more positive meaning in the sacred.

* * *

Transgression refers only to the limitless reign of the limits.

I will conclude with Foucault's description of transgression:

> Transgression is not related to the limit as black to white, the prohibited to the lawful, the outside to the inside ... . Rather, their relationship takes the form of a spiral that no simple infraction can exhaust. Perhaps it is a flash of lightning in the night that gives a dense and black intensity to the night it denies ... and becomes silent now that it has given a name to obscurity.
>
> It must be detached from its questionable association to ethics; it must be liberated from the scandalous or subversive that is from negative association.
>
> Transgression does not oppose one thing to another. It does not transform the other side of the mirror. Transgression is neither violence in a divided world (in an ethical world) nor a victory over limits (in a dialectical or revolutionary world).
>
> And exactly for this reason, its role is to measure the excessive distance that it opens at the heart of the limit, and to trace the flashing line that causes the limit to arise. (Foucault [1963] 1977: 35)

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Vatic Craft: The Science and Poetics of Perception

Sharon Lattig

Abstract

This essay surveys the major theories of creative inception put forth in Western poetics in order to reconcile the view of the poet as 'vates' with the competing notion of the poet as 'maker' within the neurobiology of the creative process. Taking to heart the insight, common to many different theories of poetry, that creative activity builds upon and/or is homologous to perceptual processes, poetic utterance is seen as a representation and an instance of the action that perception prompts and guides. Poetic 'making', I argue, is born from the shaping muse of memory, and the vatic source is traced to the input of sense data from the environment. Recursivity in the form of the feedback and feedforward loops identified by the field of neurodynamics renders these two sources of perception not merely interdependent, but mutually constructive and simultaneous. As exemplified in the convention of invocation, action is implicated as primary within the creative process, as St. Thomas Aquinas's theory of intentionality, elaborated and grounded by Walter J. Freeman's neuroscientific research, suggests.

Key words: neuroscience; inspiration; chaos theory; lyric poetry; perception; memory.

Western poetics is heir to contradictory accounts of the nature of creative conception. The first, which imagines the poet to be a vatic or prophetic figure, is given seminal philosophic defence by Plato: the argument staged within the *Ion* that the poet, like the prophet, is a ministrant of divinity serves to relegate him to a mere mouthpiece whose performance is devoid of both personal artistry and authentic knowledge. To compose, the rhapsodist must be 'out of his senses', possessed but not self-possessed (*Ion* 533d-534e). Plato's devaluation of poetic artistry is a necessary tactic deployed along the way to discrediting poetry as a didactic instrument. The poet is a conduit,

> ... like a fountain which gives free course to the rush of its waters, and since representation is of the essence of his art, he must often contradict his own utterances in his presentations of contrasted characters, without knowing whether the truth is on the side of this speaker or of that. (*Laws* 719c)

Yet the view that the poet is 'inspirited' by divine breath, and poetry a balanced transaction in which output equals input is persistent in its appeal. In Sonnet 74 of *Astrophil and Stella*, Sidney's speaker dubs himself a 'layman' and then coyly inquires

> How falls it then that with so smooth an ease
> My thoughts I speak, and what I speak doth flow
> In verse, and that my verse best wits doth please?
> (8-10)

The answer divulged as the poem climaxes is that his lips are 'inspired with Stella's kiss'. Although his muse is flesh and blood and his process humanised, the poem replays the originary occasion of Caedmon's versifying: from the mouths of the unschooled and the inarticulate spews the miracle of finely honed verse. It is precisely the lowly station of the neophyte that serves to underscore the divinity of the verse's source. The most extreme versions of vaticism inhere in the visionary poetics of Blake, who claimed to transcribe metered passages as long as 30 lines against his will (Letter to Thomas Butts 25.4.1803) and in Yeats's siphoning of the poetic metaphors channeled, conveniently, by his wife (Yeats 1937: 8).

Vying with the vatic conception of poetic praxis is the superficially less glamorous idea inherent in the English word 'poetry', deriving from *poeisis* or 'making'. In an implicit quarrel with the Platonic sentence to madness, Horace's *Ars Poetica* marks an initial attempt to formalise and prescribe technical standards for poetic greatness. The robust revival of the Renaissance treatise as technical manual produced ample fodder for the parodic pen of Edgar Allan Poe, who, in 'The Philosophy of Composition', purveys formulae for the calculus of poem-making, an enterprise realisable through what he calls 'the precision and rigid consequence of a mathematical problem' (Poe 1983: 1081). His search for terms prescriptive of superlative poetry culminates in the determination that *o* is 'the most sonorous vowel' and *r* 'the most producible consonant' (1083).

If Sidney is as delightfully arch in his treatment of the vatic as Poe is when prescribing rules for *poeisis*, he is also quick to embrace the mode as evidence of the poet's proximity to divine creation (Sidney 1989a: 214-15). At the same time he divests the pejorative sense of imitation, he secures the poet a divine lineage by installing him a competing *maker*, one who 'groweth in effect a new nature' (216).

Poetic creation is an echo of divine creation because the poet is the supreme creation of the Almighty in whose image he was made (217). If Sidney's is not quite a syncretic view, it is through the marriage he arranges that 'The Apology' apotheosises the poet and organicises the poetic act, giving us imagination as a synonym for invention. Poetry is rendered appropriately didactic by virtue of its credibility and effectively didactic based on its eternally alluring beauty (219).

From a vantage point posterior to the advent of psychological interpretation, these historical and polemical shifts in emphasis seem to make for quaint taxonomy. In isolation, each view at worst rejects and at best sublimates talent and genius, the first to a godhead and the second to the tradition-driven expectations of audience. Yet the 20th century neither escaped their influence nor transcended the dichotomy as such. The Beat poets – and Ginsberg in particular, following Kerouac – recuperate the visionary poetics of Blake and Whitman in an attempt to distance themselves from various formalisms, most notoriously New Criticism's quasi-mathematical reduction of the well-wrought artefact to a singular thematic value. The Beats' *carte blanche* eschewal of editing follows Blake's dictum that 'First thought is best in Art, second in other matters'. In a conversation with Robert Duncan, Ginsberg muses that composition is believed to flow from 'an absolute, almost Zen-like, complete absorption, *attention* to your own consciousness, to the act of writing' (Ginsberg 1974: 147). The notion that poetry emanates from a source below or beyond the level of conscious control serves to preserve a shroud of mystique for the form. Even the prevailing, temperate view that allows the obfuscation of genesis – the superstition that Eurydice, as inspirational principle, must not be looked upon – to exist in tandem with a conscious command of technique separates the two as processes, for example, pure creation and editing, or inspiration and execution. These distinctions persist even in Monroe Beardsley's refinement of the dyad and its relocation into a conscious, non-intentional poetics on the grounds that pre-conscious processes are unknowable (Beardsley 1965: 300). In the 'finalistic' or telic mode, as in the vatic, a vision of the final product is believed to pre-exist its execution while in the 'propulsive' mode, creative agency pre-exists the process without foreknowledge and each individual selection regenerates the directionality of the piece (Beardsley 1965: 294). Following Coleridge's observation that to distinguish is not necessarily to divide,

I would like to suggest that the two notions – one involving initiation, mystification, surrender and by some accounts genius, the other long apprenticeship, the painstaking mastery of skills, experience, and free will and by some accounts genius – rather evolve within a single process in which they constrain, inform, and create one another, and that the dynamic merging the two may be explained by adducing the dynamics of certain neuroscientific theories of emergent perception, as well as their implicit epistemological revision.

The necessary interdependence of making and inspiration finds an inchoate expression that is usually attributed to the romantic revision. It is precisely because romanticism negotiates what might be considered a definitive turn to internalisation, because it naturalises but does not fully divest its mythic inheritance, that the classical dichotomy is given complex formulation within its lore and theory. The figure of the Eolian harp, deployed especially by Coleridge, recasts the inspiriting source as the literal wind, a natural force, personified on occasion, but never deified. It re-figures the poet, redefining him from vessel to tuned – that is, meticulously prepared – instrument, capable of harmonic precision and technical virtuoso but still passive with respect to the physical agency of the inseminating wind. The relevant contribution of romanticism is the flipping of the active/passive dyad, dramatised at the moment in 'The Eolian Harp' when Coleridge's speaker veers to ask

> And what if all of animated nature
> Be but organic Harps diversely framed,
> That tremble into thought, as o'er them sweeps
> Plastic and vast, one intellectual breeze,
> At once the Soul of each, and God of all?
>
> (44-48)

The source of Aeolus's mythic breeze is internalised, rendered an intellectual animator of the instrument nature that is in turn inspirited by human thought. This inversion and consequent doubling of directionality will allow the creative source to be relocated to the subconscious from which it is projected and interpreted psychologically. What is often under- or even unacknowledged about the romantic dynamic is its recognition of the importance of sensory input to the creative process. The internalising of creative inception and the outward projection of its emergence is preceded and informed by an exterior source made internal. The 'alliance', to use

Wordsworth's word, between perceiver and object of perception, between within and without is given poetic utterance in Book II of *The Prelude*:

> ... his mind
> Even as an agent of the one great mind,
> Creates, creator and receiver both,
> Working but in alliance with the works
> Which it beholds.—Such, verily, is the first
> Poetic spirit of our human life.
> (1805: 257-261)

Wordsworth's Latinate terminology is unfalteringly precise: 'alliance' suggest a contractual relationship, an agreement between peers to fulfil a joint obligation, that is, to act in a way motivated by the alliance. To the extent that romanticism builds upon the genre of the romance and is, as Harold Bloom has suggested, the internalisation of the quest motif (Bloom 1973: 3-4), it redirects the gaze of Eros trained upon a beloved toward '*inanimate*' nature. The injunction of Sidney's Muse to 'look into thy heart and write' (Sonnet 1) is, then, a prod to find inspiration in the beauty of Stella, the heart's inhabitant. The ultimate source of inspiration is the image. Following the pattern common to the conversation poems, 'The Eolian Harp' opens with due indulgence in the multi-sensory imagery offered up by the consummate landscape. Revelling in 'the clouds that late were rich with light', imbibing the scent of the nearby bean-field, and attending to 'the stilly murmur of the distant sea' can be seen as attempts to abstract sensory experience from the perceptual process, to acknowledge the primacy of the primary imagination before the secondary imagination begins to dissolve 'in order to re-create' (263) and suffuse it with its own thought.

Coleridge's prescient understanding of imagination as a perceptual faculty marks the culmination of a long tradition of enquiry into the nature of its functioning, particularly the attempt to reconcile empirical psychology's basis in sensation with the notion in 'The Apology' of creative transcendence. The perfection of the 18th century's dismissal of the idea of poetry as an act imitative of subject matter and its mastery as a technical feat was indeed one of romanticism's central accomplishments. Coleridge writes, famously and infamously: 'The primary IMAGINATION I hold to be the living Power and prime Agent of all human Perception, and as a repetition in

the finite mind of the eternal act of creation in the infinite I AM' (263). Coleridge's secondary imagination, responsible for the generation of artistic product, is identical in kind to the form of imagination that generates perception (263). 'It was romanticism which fixed in the modern mind the valorisation of creativity and purely original invention over the wider concept of antiquity' (Marsh & Brogan 1993: 629). In so doing, it fixed the locus of creation firmly within the mind.

The importance of perceptual influence to poetic creation was by no means a romantic epiphany. Aristotle's metempiricism held imagination to be the reproduction of sensory input and recognised that metaphor, the mark of literary genius in his estimation, followed upon 'the intuitive *perception* of the similarity in dissimilars' (*Poetics* 1459a 5-8) (emphasis added). Evidence for the primacy of perception within poetic utterance is then not merely to be found in the preponderance of imagery, which is often thought to be the mediated record of a seminal perception, but in the recurrent intuition that creative or imaginary processes are homologous to perceptual processes. The admission of an originary relationship between sensory perception and the creative act is so pervasive as to be shared by classicism, where it is valued negatively by Plato and positively by Aristotle, and romanticism. Perception also garners post-romantic championship for its role as a prime source of poetic energy. In rallying poets to circumvent what he calls 'the lyrical interference of the ego', by which he means the rigid bourgeois category of the self, Charles Olson urges the direct registration of perception through the preservation of its energy within the poem and the transformation of that energy into a form transducible by the reader (16). 'ONE PERCEPTION MUST IMMEDIATELY AND DIRECTLY LEAD TO A FURTHER PERCEPTION'. Working at the speed of the nerves (lest the ego solidify and intervene) the poet must keep in mind that '... always one perception must must must MOVE, INSTANTER, ON ANOTHER!' (17) if 'a change beyond, and larger than, the technical' (15) is to be effected. And lest contemporary thought be slighted, a perception-based poetic is given overarching, non-polemical formulation by Susan Stewart who pushes poetry's beginnings back to the pre-perceptual. It is the premise of her recent book *Poetry and the Fate of the Senses* that all poetry is a 'force against effacement', a material vehicle to move one out of darkness and into sensory

awareness (Stewart 2002: 2). Each of these theories either proclaims or assumes poetry to be fuelled by perceptual fodder and/or to function as record and residue of a perceptual act.

It is not insignificant that Coleridge and Olson lean rhetorically on capitalisation to stress the urgent need to attend to the immediate juncture at which the nerve centre, or being (I AM), is maintained. The breath is, after all, the first medium of poetic speech: it is not only in postmodern poetics that poetic being manifests specifically as voice. And here the ancient understanding of the breath as the site of divine influence – as inspiritus or afflatus – makes for neat formula. To imagine that the stimulus to creation enters on the breath weds the creative impulse to the life-sustaining ebb and flow of respiration. It also ensures that the 'output' arm of the respiratory mechanism will be engaged. Poetic utterance – aboriginal oral expression – transpires on the exhalation. But inhalation not only entails exhalation, it is a stream on which sensory stimuli, the precursors to perception, are transported. Sense data, in the physical form of olfactory chemicals, are borne on the breath. Sensory ingress rides the current on which the divine and the mysterious are conceived to flow. Inspiration, in its distinctively Latin formulation, cannot but import collateral sense data. It is this that the high romantics realised in both senses of the word: the creative act transpires at the vital intersection of an organism and its environment.

* * *

The view of the poet as an imitator and the derivative idea that poetry represents the world is as much the baggage of philosophy as it is an insight of poets. The complementary movements of empiricism and idealism (and later rationalism) share a model of the mind as a reflective mechanism representing a discrete and cognisable world, a task which it either perfects or flubs by misrepresenting. The view that perception is a mediating function (one thinks of Blake's 'The altering eye alters all') is now commonplace, yet the former position is still espoused within the functionalist approach of cognitive science, the affiliation of disciplines that regards the mind as a computer.[1] The mind does not function as a computer, however, nor is it in any sense the disembodied processor of symbols cognitive science claims it to be. The last decades of neuroscientific research have offered an alternative view of cognition, one that allows the formulation of

preliminary answers to the question, 'Is the poetic process kindled by or in some way indebted to the physicality of perception and if so, how?' It is now possible to explain the manner in which perceptual acuity is, as Aristotle surmised, the genius of the poet. Two theories of the emergence of perceptual awareness based on models of distributed cognition will provide the basis for a neurological dynamic of perception and support the claim that inspiration naturalised and regarded as a synecdoche of all perception, is indistinguishable from the making, craft, or shaping of sensory input that is perception.

The first body of research is that of Walter Freeman, a Berkeley neuroscientist who founded the hybrid field of neurodynamics, the marriage of deterministic chaos theory to neuronal activity. His studies of olfaction serve not only to implicate the poetic medium of breath; they are further exemplary for present purposes because olfaction is both analogous to and simpler than the other sensory systems. It is also an especially evocative modality, evolutionarily primary and close to the memory loops of the so-called limbic system (Freeman 2000: 67).[2] Freeman's highly elaborated model is as follows. Olfaction begins when the sense receptor neurons lining the nose are engaged as they capture a scent molecule for which they have a particular affinity. The relatively few neurons that are activated by a given odourant form a pattern over the sheet of nasal neurons called an 'aggregate' (Freeman 2000: 67). Due to the turbulent nature of inhaled air and the highly individualised repertoires of the sense receptor neurons, each encounter with a stimulus, no matter how ideal the conditions under which it is generated, produces an entirely new aggregate pattern, one arranged partly by chance as air currents swirl unpredictably within the nose (Freeman 2000: 68). From this early stage in sensation, there is no consistent correlation between odour and aggregate and thus no firm basis for a correspondence theory of truth. As each aggregate pattern is distinct, the aggregate cannot be said to represent the odourant (Freeman 2000: 67).[3] Respiration first impresses one as pre-meaningful pattern, inchoate sound evoked from a wind-caressed instrument hinting that meaningful order is possible.

What is transmitted to the brain is then 'simply a quantity of energy that is proportional to the input of energy from the environment' (Freeman 2000: 67). One can hear echoes of Olson, who pegged energy as the highly convertible, consistent medium of poetic

creation. As the aggregate pattern is relayed to the olfactory bulb, the next way station along the olfactory pathway, it is met by 'background' neural activity generated by the random firing of the bulbar neurons. This confluence elicits a burst of oscillating motion in the form of a wave pattern, created by the synchronised alternation of excitation (firing) and inhibition (suppressing) of groups of neurons and pervading the bulb. The amplitude modulation (or 'AM') pattern graphs as a chaotic attractor arising with an increase in gain, which tends to occur at synapses between neurons that excite one another preferentially as a consequence of past learning, as first theorised by Donald Hebb (1949).[4] In other words, these synapses and clusters of synapses, or nuclei, become efficient by producing output that is disproportionate to the input received. The increase in gain prompts a positive feedback cycle that generates the AM patterns (Freeman 2000: 69-81). Perceptual history is revived, or re-collected in the presence of the foreign as part of the activity of identification.

A point of functional anatomy that bears introducing at this point is the brain's hierarchical organisation. As in any hierarchy, the successive levels of neuronal assemblies along sensory pathways receive information from a broad number of sources on a need-to-know basis. A single sender targets multiple recipients, which are contacted by multiple senders. AM patterns are transmitted from the bulb to the olfactory cortex by means of a divergence-convergence tactic that effectively eliminates the original aggregate pattern: its waveform is 'ironed out', so to speak, in the generation of the next attractor (Freeman 2000: 83-84; Crutchfield et al 1986: 53). The more expansive neuronal assemblies of the cortex will spin, or chaotically reorganise this input once again, but it is possible to conclude even at this early stage that it is an individual's history with a similar input, written in the synaptic assemblies (the way that groups of neurons have learned to interact) that gives form to the patterns the brain uses to identify stimuli and not the stimuli themselves (Freeman 2000: 82). In other words, the brain must decompose and reconstitute the raw sense data it collects before it can apprehend them. It formalises meaning by bringing known relevant information to bear on sense data that are unknowable as they are while maintaining their significance by means of the dynamic principles of deterministic chaos theory. Chaotic attractors create unpredictable but coherent patterns that can both regularise over discrepant input and absorb

novelty, providing for novel response by amplifying initial uncertainties. Non-linearity is the phenomenon in which small inputs (sense data) have disproportionately large effects. Freeman writes, 'brains are drenched in chaos' (Freeman 2000: 87). Their activity, ranging from the firing of single neurons to the choreography of an entire hemisphere, is non-linear.

The neuroscientist Gerald Edelman also relies on the principles of non-linearity as part of his information systems approach to the dynamics of the brain. He hypothesises a 'dynamic core', a complex system of linkages throughout the thalamocortical system (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 42). This extensive network of cortex and thalamus-wide interconnections is functional because it is both highly integrated and highly differentiated into smaller 'functional clusters' of neuronal groups, that is, units that 'make a difference' (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 146). He quantifies the change in neural complexity and arrives at the same conclusion as Freeman:

> ... [E]xtrinsic signals convey information not so much in themselves, but by virtue of how they modulate the intrinsic signals exchanged within a previously experienced neural system. In other words, a stimulus acts not so much by adding large amounts of external information that needs to be processed as it does by amplifying the intrinsic information resulting from neural interactions selected and destabilized by memory through previous encounters with the environment. (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 137)

Small degrees of 'extrinsic' mutual information, that which is quantifiable between a stimulus and an organism, tend to alter drastically the value of the 'intrinsic' mutual information that inheres among the functional clusters of the brain (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 137). As the preponderance of information is generated from the unique history of the organism, Edelman calls the scene of perceptual experience the 'remembered present' (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 78, 138).[5]

We have, then, two models of brain functioning in which the past infiltrates the present, and initial energy, the fluid matter of interconnection between world and being, is *ab initio* converted by pre-organised energy, seemingly beyond recognition. 'Things as they are' in the words of Wallace Stevens, are unknowable precisely because the brain reshapes itself, 'making' sense of sense data by contextualising them within its history and rendering the original sense datum unintelligible in and of itself. 'Things as they are/Are

changed upon the blue guitar' (Stevens [1954] 1990: 165). Inspiration cannot be articulated because it is reformed as it is presented to consciousness. It is no surprise then that percepts are imaginative in the romantic sense: they are formed by a consummate plastic faculty, and they render objects as objects 'essentially fixed and dead' (263), to rehearse Coleridge's critique of Newtonian physics.

The classical agency of creativity was, of course, provided by the sisterhood of the Muses. Sired by the all-powerful Zeus and given birth by the goddess of memory, Mnemosyne, they specialised along genre lines. In his book about the evolution of self-consciousness, Bruno Snell (1953: 43-70) stresses that in pre-classical Greece, the motive force for all personal agency, including mental contents and actions, was believed to be external. 'According to [Homer's] view – and there could be no other for him – a man's action or perception is determined by the divine forces operative in the world; it is a reaction of his physical organs to a stimulus, and this stimulus is itself grasped as a personal act' (Snell 1953: 43). One was informed and driven by external powers; whether battling or poeticising, one never felt, thought, or acted but at the behest of the gods. It is perhaps not earth-shattering that pre-classical mythology should have recognised the role played by memory in composition, but the curious lineage of the Muses takes on new significance given the extent to which we know the shaping agent of perception to be memory. At every stage of sensory processing, the present is 'remembered'. Input is shaped by the synaptic memory of prior perception, the mysterious, interior transformer that regularises immediate experience. In an analogous framing of the dynamic, inspirational force is born from the insemination and subsequent shaping powers of memory. Zeus's power is expressed in the generative, seminal, and informing act that initiates procreation and by extension creation. His is the force of external movement and the fertilising infliction of difference that his offspring recapitulate, rousing memory, a gift of the gods, as they inspire. Whether knowledge is put on with the power is matter for rhetorical cynicism in the completely passive 'conception' of 'Leda and the Swan', a poem that exposes the sheer receptivity of Yeats's mystical view when the helpless Leda is read as a figure for the poet himself.

Snell goes so far as to credit lyric poetry, and particularly Sappho's practice of it, as the vehicle by means of which the recognition of a consistent, internal self first evolved within Western thinking. He interprets Sappho's realisation that she will love again in the poem Jim Powell entitles 'Artlessly adorned Aphrodite' and her self-deprecating tone when lamenting her suffering in love as indications that she conceives her emotional reactions to be within her own power (Snell 1953: 53, 57, 65). Love is still by injection: the dart of Eros causes one to love, but the response to that condition is now entirely Sappho's own. Through the practice of a derivatively perceptual art, Sappho has perceived herself into the discovery of her unique personal agency.

Perception is both a selective function and one that functions by differentiating. From the earliest stages, visual perception, in particular, proceeds by means of either/or differentiation mechanisms to implicate larger and larger oscillating neuronal networks that ultimately correspond to the perceived division between the self and the non-self – the lyric 'I' and 'you'. Orpheus's glance at Eurydice dishonours his earthly marriage to her, their inviolable physical inter-connectedness. In violating divine law, he renders her object and effectively kills her as a living being. Her repatriation in Hades restores her to the realm of separateness that the gaze instigates.

However, before perception culminates in the subject/object divide, further integrative action must transpire. First, the input from each of the several sense modalities must be unified. Freeman maps the itinerancy of the olfactory AM patterns from the olfactory cortex to the entorhinal cortex, whose function is to integrate the disparate information relayed from each of the sensory systems by merging their waveforms into a unified signal (Freeman 2000: 101-02). Synchronous oscillating motion provides a common dynamic that overcomes the modular nature of perception and provides a basis for perceptual integrity, the experienced unity of consciousness. Signals from the entorhinal cortex then flow forward into the motor systems to gather proprioceptive information specifying the location and position of the body, particularly the muscular system, in space (Freeman 2000: 101-2). The motor systems feed information back into the entorhinal cortex and hippocampus, which provides the space-time orientation that is critical to the planning of action (Freeman 2000:

103). The proprioceptive feedback messages and space-time limitations amount to order parameters that bias the formation of attractor landscapes in the sensory cortices, i. e., the AM patterns are constrained based on physical reality, the body's motor capabilities and its memory of past motor actions and their results (Freeman 2000: 102).

Conscious awareness, then, (as distinct from self-awareness) arises when the feedback flow from the motor cortices enables 'the formation of a global AM pattern that reflects the integration of the activity of an entire hemisphere' (Freeman 2000: 102). These 'global' attractors lead to awareness and explicit memories, those of which one is consciously aware. Global AM patterns revive memories that are potentially pertinent to the input. When faced with input it cannot easily identify, what it must account for afresh, the brain creates a set of hypotheses from its store of memories, together representing a sum of relevant experience, and embodies them as a set of attractors. Chaotic attractors are significant at every stage in this process because, as part of their expanding phase, they lend the capacity to generate endlessly new patterns or potential complexes of meaning, thereby creating information (Nicolis & Tsuda 1999: 216). They are unpredictable due to sensitive dependence on initial conditions (here the stimulant) and because the history brought to bear is continually modified by new input. As much as fickle winds and the whims of demigods, the imagination is a mercurial faculty. Unpredictability is infused throughout the imaginative process as the potential for novelty, and the uncertainty amplified in chaotic activity is a key factor in engendering the originality that is the goal of origination.

The set of memories accessed by the brain are embodied as co-existing strange attractors within what is called an attractor basin. Freeman hypothesises that the brain entertains several options by making what he calls a tour of the attractors (Freeman 2000: 80). As it does, the object pending recognition may be partitioned into a number of co-existing attractors (Nicolis & Tsuda 1999: 226). Because a particular stimulus is imperfectly known, it moves within the range of other attractors as it approaches any one. In shuttling between destinations, the brain effectively tests its hypothesis. The unknown signal will land on an attractor with which it forms the largest cross-correlation (Nicolis & Tsuda 1999: 218). This instigates the

contracting phase of chaos in which initial uncertainties are constrained (Nicolis & Tsuda 1999: 216). Feedback loops eliminate the chicken/egg syndrome; observation (the taking in of stimulation) and categorisation (the bringing to bear of a set of experiences and the selection of an appropriate subset from it) are performed in unison by means of recursive feedback loops (Nicolis & Tsuda 1999: 216). The brain's hierarchical organisation enables this: as in any hierarchy, high-level mass activity defines the role of new low-level input at the same time new low-level input is a parameter shaping higher-level processing. The two are contemporaneously and mutually formative. The complex and rapid synthetic capacity of the brain that permits effective simultaneity and expeditious response may also account for the Eureka experience, the suddenness with which inspiration descends.

In order for the brain to define a stimulus with multiple meanings, one that is initially ambiguous, it must be re-inspired, that is, it must court further perceptual influx. At the same time a feedback flow is responsible for the generation of the memory-attractors, a feedforward flow proceeds from the entorhinal cortex through the motor systems in order to gather in more sensory data (Freeman 2000: 102). The mechanics of such perception-generating actions are often quite simple: they may involve, for instance, the positioning of the body or the eyes toward a particular view or the turning of the head toward a surmised location in order to pinpoint the origin of a sound. In the event that input is sufficiently unfamiliar that it becomes necessary to create a new attractor, all of the others in the basin move over to make room for it (Freeman 2000: 80). By consolidating the basin of attraction created earlier onto one attractor, the processor resolves ambiguity. This reduction in uncertainty is a necessary accompaniment to the selection of an action and is tantamount to an increase in information (Edelman & Tononi 2000: 147-8). Perception is at core a creative mechanism because its primary function is not to represent the world as it is, but rather to govern action back into the world. Motor action must be perceptually guided: in both the perceptual and poetic sense, one is inspired to action, to verbal action in the latter case. Emerson tells us that it is in the nature of words to be active: ' ... all language is vehicular and transitive, and is good, as ferries and horses are, for conveyance, not as farms and houses are, for homestead' (463). The irrepressibly self-assertive 'I AM' is ever-

active on its own behalf and perhaps no more so than when it is versifying. The mother/memory is properly the maker because she gives birth not only to action, but through action. She is the active principle.[6]

It is action that the organism constructs as part of the ongoing process of forging an 'alliance' with the environment: in order to fulfil the terms of the alliance it must act into the environment. The terms themselves are created as part of the evolutionary process of adapting within a niche. The formation of the action so constrained by adaptation is the organism's intentionality. Freeman recuperates St. Thomas Aquinas's Aristotelean position that perception is the result of action into the environment (Freeman 2000: 26).[7] Aquinas's correction of medieval church doctrine distinguishes intentional processes, through which organisms self-realise as a result of their actions, from the fully self-conscious, wilful ones that qualify them to make ethical choices (Freeman 2000: 26). Freeman defines intentionality as '[t]he process by which goal-directed actions are generated in the brains of humans and other animals' (Freeman 2000: 8). It draws on past experience with an action to calculate the result of the action in the present circumstance (Freeman & Hosek 2001: 511). The Freeman/Aquinas model of intentionality differs substantially from the analytic concept, which describes the apparent relation between mental states and the objects at which they are directed. Philosophical intentionality is a strictly psychological phenomenon, often conceived of as the 'aboutness' of mental contents or the relation of thoughts and beliefs about the world to the world (Freeman 2000: 26). Belief and desire in the broad sense of wanting are intentional states. This stance toward intentionality assumes the representational mode of cognition endorsed by cognitivism, the idea that objects in the world are re-presented to a passive consciousness that subsequently adopts an attitude toward them (Freeman & Hosek 2001: 512). The assumption that the mind interprets inert symbols of the external world and then acts in accordance with its interpretation runs counter to the pragmatist model in which intent arises in the minds of embedded, embodied organisms and subsumes their action into the environment. It is the biological 'process by which humans and other animals act in accordance with their own growth and maturation' (Freeman 2000: 8).

To root poetic composition convincingly in the neurobiology of perceptual processes, it is necessary to recognise and account for the privileged role action plays with respect to perception. Empirical and rational approaches might grant the functional interdependence of perception and action; they may further espouse the truism that perception exists to enable motor action. However, the directionality assumed by this commonplace is at best partial and at worst artificial. It derives from the precedence granted to sensation by empiricist philosophy, a legacy influencing the cognitivist view that the brain represents sense data as it perceives, and action follows as a response to the world as it is. Yet, this assumption overlooks the organism's reformation or 'information' of stimuli based upon its history and the coincident reformation of its self. 'The body does not absorb stimuli, but changes its own form to become similar to aspects of stimuli that are relevant to the intent that emerged from within the brain' (Freeman 2000: 27). To engage in intentional behaviour is to change the self through action. It is not, on the contrary, a reason for the action.

Compelling neurological evidence for the necessary precedence of action is provided by the phenomenon of corollary discharge that enables the process Freeman names 'preafferance'. When a motor plan is sent to the motor systems in preparation for innervation of the spinal column, a 'copy' of the plan is simultaneously relayed to the sensory cortices to enable them to predict the sensory consequences of the intended action (Freeman 1999: 151). Preafferance allows the organism to imagine 'how the actions to be taken will change the relations of the eyes, nose, ears, and fingers to the world' (Freeman 2000: 33). The senses are primed, in other words, to expect specific stimuli. In mathematical terms, the corollary discharge message acts as a parameter constraining attractor landscapes by 'deepening the basins of attraction'[8] and thereby facilitating identification (Freeman 2000: 133). Action, in other words, reconciles memory and perception because it is constructed by both perceptual input and past history with the same. In granting that action co-emerges with perception, sensation – the cornerstone of the empiricist project – can no longer maintain its primacy. Coleridge issued a similar critique in recognising the same bi-directionality. His primary imagination is the '*Agent* of all human Perception' (emphasis added). It is the 'repetition

in the finite mind of the eternal *act* of creation in the infinite I AM' (263) (emphasis added).

The inversion that underlies Freeman's notion of intentionality is a critical re-prioritising. The late neuroscientist and Buddhist scholar Francisco Varela goes a step further in conflating perception and action. The first of two criteria he establishes for what he dubs an 'enactionist' view is the belief that 'perception consists in perceptually guided action' (Varela, Thompson & Rosch 1991: 173). The second is that 'cognitive structures emerge from the recurrent sensorimotor patterns that enable action to be perceptually guided' (173). Perception and action are identical within the experience of cognition, and they are jointly primary with respect to 'higher' cognitive function. The neuronal 'representation' of a hypothetically isolated percept is, in a strictly enactionist view, a schema for action that is potentially conceptual. Freeman's theoretical stance leans very near enactionism but does not ultimately align with it. He is, first of all, more concerned with the activity of the physical substrate than with the contents of consciousness. Action and perception are not identical in his view, but continuously formative with respect to one another. The process of assimilation to the environment involves the simultaneous extension of bottom-up and top-down operations. By means of recursive feedback loops, global attractors bias lower-level action (sensory input) at the same time lower-level action shapes global activity and informs memory and action (Freeman 1999: 154). This is an example of a highly enmeshed 'circular' causality (itself a simplistic metaphor) from which linear arms are abstracted for the sake of comprehensibility. We say, exemplifying empiricist doctrine, that perception causes action or, if we are rationalists, that pre-existing mental contents shape perception. But these are retrospective assignments of agency fitted to our particular worldview and allowing us to distinguish cause and effect in order to make sense of the world. The construction of action and perception, however, is ongoing and mutually effected. As the dynamic enabling it is complex in the technical sense, it is fundamentally impossible to isolate one or the other. The number of individual components in the system, the thwarting of proximity through the connectedness of neurons relatively remote from one another, divergence and convergence mechanisms involved in hierarchical 'ascension', and non-linearity all contribute to the impossibility of disentangling the origin of either.[9] It

is no surprise, then, that divinity should so easily become the explanation for what is in fact unknowable. This highly developed constructivist model accounts for original action. The flexibility of chaos, in Freeman's words, 'expresses free will' (Freeman 2000: 9), and individual freedom is a necessary component of originality. Sidney's advertisement for a poetic creativity vying with divine creation specifically ascribes 'divine force' to the '*liberty* of conceit' (114, emphasis added).

Evidence for the primacy of action within the compositional process may be found in the poetic gesture by means of which one courts inspiration: the poet's active receptivity is formalised in the convention of invocation. The ritualistic calling forth of the muse is a peculiarly literary-poetic invention and inventive device, and its fitness for the poetic enterprise runs deeper than its personification of the inspiriting source. By virtue of its live enaction of the process of summoning inspiration, it establishes itself as a gesture originary to poetic making. Invocation is a form of action, the action of calling in, the issuance of an invitation to a visit, or a visitation as it were. Invoking is a directed action that positions one to receive specific input. Within the pre-Platonic view and the practice to which Plato responds, the external stimuli or stimulant to inspiration is courted through action that is directed in however simple or representative a sense. When Sappho sings the following stanzas of her only complete extant poem,

> Artfully adorned Aphrodite, deathless
> child of Zeus and waver of wiles I beg you
> please don't hurt me, don't overcome my spirit
> goddess, with longing,
>
> But come here, if ever at other moments,
> hearing these my words from afar you listened
> and responded: leaving your father's house, all
> golden, you came then,
>
> …
>
> Come to me again, and release me from this
> want past bearing. All that my heart desires to
> happen – make it happen. And stand beside me,
> goddess, my ally. (Powell 3-4)

it is her utterance, or speech act that positions her to receive the blessing of the goddess she looks to based on her successful past experience with said action. The ritualistic formality, the oral mode,

and the athletic tenor that typify the invocatory tradition serve to intensify the sense of physicality attending its practice. The calling into being of Aphrodite, the expressed wish that she linger, like Wordsworth's beholdings as *ally* (in Powell's and others' translations), is the wish to effect the palpable presence that will inspire the poem. The device survives in the figure of apostrophe. Each treats absence, which must be imagined or conceptualised, as presence, which may be perceived. What is granted the poet given the capriciously granted favour of the gods is the activation of a perceptual dynamic at the level of the imagination. Both enactionism and preafferance preliminarily confirm that the composing imagination is in fact 'an echo' of perceptual processes as Coleridge conceived it to be, a truncated repetition in which beginning is lopped off and latter processes reiterated.

> The secondary Imagination I consider as an echo of the former, co-existing with the conscious will, yet still as identical with the primary in the kind of its agency, and differing only in degree, and in the mode of its operation. It dissolves, diffuses, dissipates, in order to re-create; or where this process is rendered impossible, yet still at all events it struggles to idealize and to unify. It is essentially vital, even as all objects as objects are essentially fixed and dead. (263)

The secondary, creative imagination, that which produces poetry, does not necessarily engage in original perception in the act of creation, but is built upon its processes. It is an active process whose agency differs in that it gives rise to imagined products – perception in the broader, secondary sense – rather than percepts. In preafferance, the failure of an expected stimulus to materialise activates the imagination of the stimulus. 'When an expected stimulus is present, we experience it. When it is not, we imagine it' (Freeman 2000: 108). It is possible to infer, then, that action plays a formative role in the generation of both percepts and imagined images.

This particular Sapphic invocation and the goddess's response to it are unusual in that together they constitute the whole of the poem, the subject matter of which is unrequited love and the search to assuage a vacancy. The invocation both positions the poet to receive intake and is itself the inspired output, the poetic expression praising the god that cannot but be inspired by the gods. It becomes the poetic utterance in reconciling action and perception. We are provided the flank of action, if we choose to perceive it that way, in what is at bottom the

presentation of an integrated perception-action event in which the dual nature of creation, the constant subtle shifts and adjustments between self and environment are distilled into the images of vates and maker. Plato overlooks the crux of the praxis of invocation, the critical, active role the poet plays in summoning images into being and the fact that his gesture toward the goal overrides mere passive attending and remains absent the record of the ritual. For Wordsworth, Stevens, and Verlaine, the act of walking was invocatory. Invocation is a pre-compositional process that finds expression in the superficially tautological folk wisdom that in order to write one must 'show up at the page' – in order to write, one must write. It is an example of why often the sheer act of beginning to write is the prompt to further writing.

What Plato interprets as the poet's passivity is in part attributable to the substance-induced ecstasis that accompanied composition within the Orphic tradition. Platonism demonises the poet, accusing him of wielding a hypnotic power over his audience that lulls it into a similarly receptive passive state preclusive of the engagement of the reason necessary for dialectic success and the end of representative truth. Poesis assumes a reason-disabling infiltration that degrades creative acts as reproductions. Yet ecstasis is a going out of one's self that presumes a moving into something else, the prerequisite for knowledge in the pragmatist sense.

If the dawn of self-consciousness in the West can be attributed to Sappho, one can also locate in her the embeddedness of that aborning self that is assumed by the acausal relationship of perception and memory. The classical conceit at large does not imagine self and world as discrete entities that interface as assumed by the customary usage of the word 'interact'. Her poem implicitly recognises multiple fonts of creative agency while giving final efficacy to the unanalysable issue of their genetic union: the goddess-muse. Ultimately, organism and environment, perception and action, Zeus and Mnemosyne, are co-extensive. The creative act is situated at the site of their merger and therefore derivative of all organismic-environmental interaction.[10] The pragmatic, non-representational model of cognition in which meaning amounts to the way the action an organism takes toward an object changes that organism provides a basis for its fit with poetry, the linguistic mode that sharply curtails

the expository and minimises language's representational function. Poetic language is usually assigned a role other than reference or denotation, be it an expressive, an emotional, a visceral, or simply an imaginative one, with the extreme form of *poésie pure* striving toward the complete dissolution of the functions on which communication is based and the release of language into what has come to be viewed as its natural, autonomous state.

Finally, it bears noting that perception and action transpire mainly below the level of conscious awareness. Perception-action events may and often do occur unconsciously and result in the instantaneous and unquestioned recognition of an object of perception and the appropriate action toward it (Freeman 2000: 17-8). This pre-conscious dynamic is evolutionarily primary: it exists in organisms that are not conscious, and it constitutes the better part of the experience of organisms that are. Our feeling that we are consciously controlling our actions is mostly illusory: the coordination of action and perception is mainly an unconscious skill, and the assignment of causality to the will retrospective (Freeman 2000: 17-8). Perhaps it is no surprise that Frye describes the initiation of poem-making as a compulsive act, one the poet is drawn to without awareness of the source of motivation, but that in any event 'blocks' quotidian self-inquiry (Frye 1985: 32). We find further evidence for the generation of poetry at this instinctual level in the mystifying and deifying of the inspirational source. Whether the muse will visit is below or beyond conscious awareness and control. Attracting her involves a dynamic receptivity to an only apparently external voice, an active attention, or a listening for the poem, in Emerson's notion (Emerson 1983: 449). Another way to think of this is that the biology happens; the organism functions. As William James states succinctly, '*It* thinks.' (emphasis added)

It is precisely this pre-attentive level of functioning that Olson aspires to access in order to achieve the poetic registration of perception. He wishes to position writing on the back of the perception-action event by recording each perception as soon as its predecessor is enacted, or given verbal form, before a self-aware 'I' can intrude upon an unwavering attention to the poetic voice as registrar of perceptual flow and ponder its efforts. The speed and attentiveness required in attending to the movement of perception are defences against interruptive self-reflection, what Ginsberg called the 'feeding back'

that distracts the attention from the object at hand (Ginsberg 1974: 147). And indeed, self-consciousness is, according to Freeman, a mechanism of delay inserted into the uninterrupted flow of pre-conscious organismic functioning. '... [P]erception is a continuous and mostly unconscious process that is sampled and marked intermittently by awareness, and what we remember are the samples, not the process' (Freeman 2000: 18). The meaning the poet seeks to convey is more capacious than that accessible to self-consciousness. It includes if not the presence of others, the presence of what is other to the self.

According to Olson, romanticism flounders as it fails to admit that the emergence of self-consciousness inhibits the creative act, and distances one from, rather than reunites one with, nature. High romanticism in particular suffers from its failure to revisit the 'lost hour of splendour in the grass'. Spontaneity or no, in order to compose, the emergence of the self-aware 'I' tends to arise, an eventuality secured when Coleridge collapsed the will into the imagination. Though its goal may have been to re-enter nature, romanticism can be seen as an ambivalent attempt to achieve and maintain embeddedness and embodiedness. That poetry must do so is the central paradox of the self-conscious genre of the lyric. The romantic miscalculation preserved the goal for generations of poets to come.

Endnotes

[1]Functionalism operates on the assumption of functional equivalence. Any model of the mind (and particularly the model of mind as a computer) is valid so long as it is functionally equivalent to its referent, that is, so long as it produces the same results. The similarity of the underlying systemic operation is not at issue, and therefore, a model of the mind need not be based on knowledge of the actual workings of the mind.

[2]The limbic system is controversially a system. It is an assemblage of interrelated regions of the brain participating in the representation of emotion and consists of the limbic lobe -- a ring of primary cortical tissue that includes the cingulate gyrus, the parahippocampal gyrus, and the hippocampal formation – and the subcortical regions it abuts, including part of the hypothalamus (which activates the autonomic nervous system responses involved in emotion), the septal area, the nucleus accumbens and the amygdala. The amygdala and the hippocampus are implicated in implicit and explicit memory respectively.

[3]This characteristic extends to the other sensory modalities. For example, in vision there is no constant correlation between a colour perceived and a particular wavelength received. The brain rather identifies colour by its context so that it can

regularise perception, even though the external physical constitution of the colour changes. See Land 1977: 108-28.

[4]A popular formulation of Hebb's rule is 'Neurons that fire together wire together'.

[5]Although each uses deterministic chaos or complexity theory to explain the integrative directionality of cognition, the objects of their measurements are different. Edelman defines complexity in terms of the degree to which interconnected neural networks are differentiated and the amount of information processed relative to the information available from the environment. Freeman measures the chaotic activity of the wave oscillation of the synchronous firings of groups of neurons.

[6]Evidence that sensory and motor information are, in fact, indistinguishable within the cortex continues to accumulate. Indeed, a rather neat way that the final irresolvability of the two is exemplified is in the recent discovery of 'mirror neurons', neurons in the post-parietal cortex that fire both when an action is undertaken and when the same action is observed.

[7]Maurice Merleau-Ponty ([1945] 2002), John Dewey (1914), and Jean Piaget (1930) each prioritise action in relation to perception.

[8]The metaphor of the basin conceptualises the idea of attraction in gravitational terms. A basin is defined as 'the set of points that evolve to an attractor' (Crutchfield et al 1986: 50). Input is less likely to escape and more likely to be drawn into or 'attracted' to a pattern the 'deeper' its basin.

[9]Quantum mechanics provides for a fundamental level of uncertainty with respect to measurement. It is not resolvable through further knowledge (Crutchfield et al 1986: 46, 49).

[10]As neurodynamics exemplifies, the relationship between these co-implicated sources of perception in the physical sense of impinging sensation and memory in the form of neural attractors is one of a mutual and coextensive construction derivative of a larger relationship between organism and environment. Susan Oyama (1985) meticulously dismantles the logic of giving priority or discrete status to either nature or nurture in her landmark text, *The Ontogeny of Information*. She further exposes the grounding of this dichotomy in the Western separation of form and matter. The holistic, ecological thinking she clarifies was only recently taken to heart within the hard sciences, due most likely to the diversion of resources funnelled into the development of cognitivism's computer model of the mind.

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Grand Principles of Narratology

Henrik Schärfe

Abstract

Through an analysis of a number of narratologies, three Grand Principles are rendered as the epitome of much effort in narratology. The Principles are: Succession, Transformation and Mediation. The Grand Principles of Narratology correspond to three textual levels with their own characteristics in relation to different narrative concerns. Succession corresponds to a Narrative Syntax, addressing narrative coherence. Transformation corresponds to a level of Narrative Semantics, addressing the significance of correlating properties of textual elements distributed throughout the narrative. Finally, Mediation corresponds to a level of Narrative Pragmatics, addressing questions of intentionality and relevance. The description is subject to ontological considerations.

Key words: narrative theory; succession; transformation; mediation; semiotics; syntactics; semantics; pragmatics.

1. Introduction

One of the long-term goals of narratology is to account for the mechanisms of *all* narratives and *only* narratives. In this paper, I suggest a framework for narratologies based on a combination of three fundamental principles and three semiotic dimensions. The three fundamental principles of narrative and of narratology are considered as the elementary forces of narrative discourse, of storytelling, of story logic, and of story comprehension. In consequence of the immensely diverse manifestations of narrativity and of the equally diverse scope of narrative analysis, narrative elements are considered as signs. Based on the grand principles of narratology and the dimensions of semiosis, a Narrative Matrix can be generated by means of which the principles and the dimensions qualify each other.

2. The principles of narrativity

I submit that narrativity can be defined as what takes place in texts where a complex relation consisting of three parts governs the relation between the text and that for which the text stands, between

expression and content; and I submit that this insight is the epitome of much effort in narratology.

Firstly, in narration, incidents, objects, and descriptive elements are not simply stated (that would amount to nothing more than description); they are arranged in sequences. This is the *principle of succession*, which is rooted in our experience of time and change, and in our ability to think and reason about time and change.

Secondly, in narration, sequences are more than episodic accounts (that again would amount to nothing more than description); they are arranged in patterns signifying that some state of mind or some state of affairs undergoes some sort of change. This is the *principle of transformation*, and it is rooted in our perception of unities. Comprehension of unities enables us, among other things, to define beginnings and endings. The notions of time and succession in themselves do not.

Thirdly, narration conveys something other than the content to which the expressions refer. This is the *principle of mediation*, rooted in our desire and ability to communicate about more than our immediate surroundings. Mediation differs from the description of unity and time in that this principle allows us to let the configuration of the unity refer to something outside the world of the text. Words like 'premise' and 'rationale' point to this principle.

None of the three principles can stand alone as valid explanations for the extremely complicated mechanisms of narrative communication, and none of them can be omitted. Taken together, however, they explain how we utilise narratives to isolate, designate, and mediate – that is, they account for the essential parts of how we make sense of the world through narratives. Seen as a whole, the principles of succession, transformation and mediation allow us to describe all and only narratives, and they provide a backbone for describing and evaluating narratologies. Texts that feature some but not all of these principles are not considered as narratives, but as something else. But this does not entail that a narratology by necessity must address all three principles. In fact, it is quite common to find theories that focus on one or two of the principles. The essential methodological move in this paper is not only to identify these three constitutive elements of narrative, but also to apply them to the description of narrativity itself.

2.1. On Succession

According to Kant, all things are in time, and in the substratum of time only coexistence or succession can occur (Kant 1934: 212). Coexistence (conjunction) does not constitute a narrative since nothing goes on. Things may happen, but nothing goes on. In coexistence, things simply are, and there is no temporal order. For the sake of argument, imagine two propositions:

(A) Peter fired his gun.

(B) Paul dropped dead to the floor.

In coexistence 'A and B' equals 'B and A'. That is to say that the interpretation of A has no bearing on the interpretation of B and vice versa. For all we know, the two incidents could occur at different continents (in a Californian sunset and in a Scandinavian daybreak). All we can say is that two things happen at the same time. But if the incidents are placed successively, we get:

(C) Peter fired his gun and Paul dropped dead to the floor, *or*

(D) Paul dropped dead to the floor and Peter fired his gun.

It is possible to maintain that the two incidents in (C) as well as in (D) are separate occurrences, but it is much more difficult, especially in (C). Given a frame containing the propositions that someone fires a gun and that someone dies, we are likely to infer that the first person shot the second. The reason is that we apply inferences with respect to temporality and causality to the text. In the words of Tomashevsky (1965: 66), 'we must emphasize that a story requires not only indications of time, but also indication of cause'.

We are beings of time, and we are aware of it. This was evident to Kant and to many others before him including Leibniz, who argued that our reasoning is based on two principles: that of contradiction and that of sufficient reason (Leibniz 1999: §§31-32). Both of these are based on temporality and causality.

To illustrate the principles, consider the following well-known fable by Aesop. This example will follow us throughout the presentation of the three narrative principles:

The Hare and the Tortoise

A HARE one day ridiculed the short feet and slow pace of the Tortoise, who replied, laughing: "Though you be swift as the wind, I will beat you in a race." The Hare, believing her assertion to be simply impossible, assented to the proposal; and they agreed that the Fox should choose the course and fix the goal. On the day appointed for the race the two started together. The Tortoise never for a moment stopped, but went on with a slow but steady pace straight to the end of the course. The Hare, lying down by the wayside, fell fast asleep. At last waking up, and moving as fast as he could, he saw the Tortoise had reached the goal, and was comfortably dozing after her fatigue.

Slow but steady wins the race. (Aesop)

We recognise the principle of succession by which the incidents are arranged. The sequence of the events is pretty clear, and the temporal aspect of succession can be rendered as follows:

I-1. A hare ridicules a tortoise.

I-2. The tortoise replies laughing that she will beat the hare in a race.

I-3. The hare believes that the assertion of the tortoise is impossible.

I-4. The hare assents to the proposal of a race.

I-5. The hare and the tortoise agree to let a fox arrange the race.
  a. A fox arranges the race.

I-6. They start the race together.

I-7. The tortoise never stops racing.

I-8. The hare lies down at the roadside and
  a. falls asleep.

I-9. The hare wakes up and
  a. runs as fast as possible and
  b. sees that

I-10. The tortoise has finished the race and is resting.

Here, the incidents are presented in canonical (Ohtsuka & Brewer 1992) or unequivocal order (Herman 2002: 213), meaning that for any two incidents it is possible to ascertain an exact temporal relation. It should be mentioned, however, that for narratives in general, the partial order is much more common than the unequivocal order. This is especially true if we consider time as durations rather than as

instants. In theories of time and temporal logic the matter of time as instants versus time as durations has been a great concern. Under this perspective, it is somewhat surprising that this matter by and large is left unremarked by narratologists, even by those who most vividly posit the principle of succession as a prime principle in narrative. Neither Todorov, Prince, Rimmon-Kenan, nor Tomashevsky makes a distinction between the succession of instants and the succession of durations. On the contrary, Todorov seems to exclude duration from the constitutive elements of narration (Todorov 1990: 28). In the tradition following Genette, who used the terms *order*, *duration*, and *frequency* to describe the ratios between the told and the telling, the term *duration* simply denotes a relation between discourse time and story time (Genette 1980). Thus, the telling can have more or less duration with respect to the told. But sometimes a temporal description in terms of instants is insufficient to account for the story elements.

Without a doubt, the first grand principle in narratology is that of succession. I am not aware of any narratology that questions this. But true as this may be, the principle of succession in itself has some severe limitations. The principle of succession simply establishes an order. For example, what exactly do we mean when we infer a causal relation? Certainly, it cannot mean anything like Mill's 'invariable sequence' according to which A is immediately followed by B and anything similar to A is always immediately followed by something similar to B. This would entail that whenever (this) hare agrees to race a tortoise it will go to sleep during the race. And 'cause' cannot be explained by counterfactual implication, which is to say that if A had not happened, B would not have happened; since this would entail that if the hare had not begun the race, he would not have fallen asleep (Goddard 1998: 262). A graphic representation of the causal relations in the fable is displayed in Figure 1 below.

Notice that the chain of dependencies simply breaks once the race begins. The incidents 7-10 are not in any logical sense dependent on elements stated in incidents 1-6. Not even the portrayal of the hare as arrogant (in I-1) is enough to anticipate the strange case of a runner who goes to sleep in the middle of a race. Even for small and dense narratives like this, the notion of an unbroken chain of causes and effects does not hold because it does not take into account the

phenomenon of *peripeteia*. Moreover, it is important to note that the dependencies are traceable only backwards. A forward counterpart is simply not feasible. On the contrary: from (almost?) any point in the narrative it is possible to envision alternative courses of action, and hence different conclusions. Sometimes this is exactly the point: see for instance Manfred Jahn's work on 'garden-path narratives' (Jahn 1999).

The principle of succession, granted a primary status, lends itself to another principle of massive importance. This principle is that of transformation, and the reason for the intricate relationship between the two principles resides in the fact that succession is a prerequisite for describing change, and without change there can be no narration.

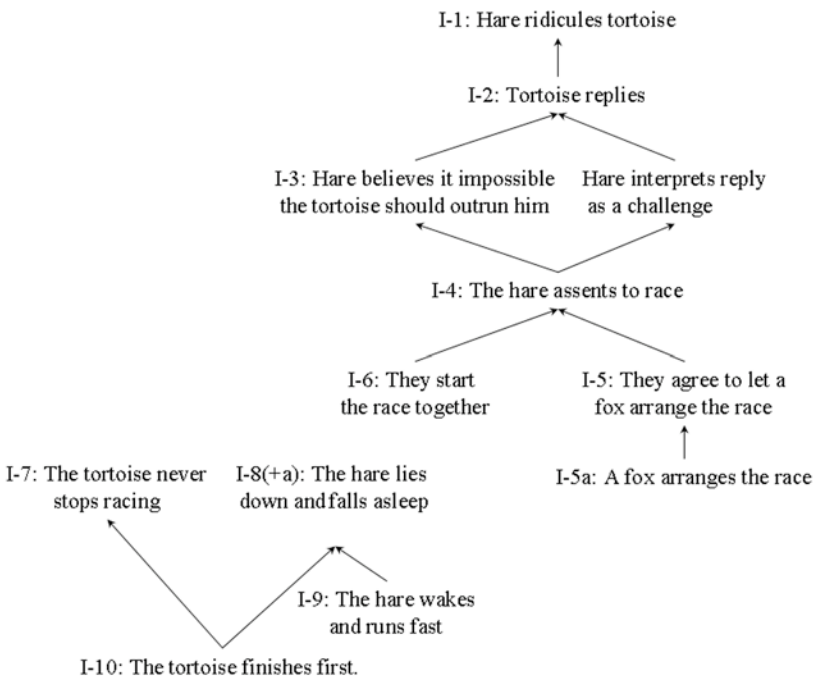

Figure 1: Causal dependencies in fable

2.2. On Transformation

Aristotle's notions of beginning, middle, and end illustrate this principle and its consequences vividly. In the *Poetics* (Book 7), Aristotle defines a beginning as '… that which does not itself follow something by causal necessity, but after which something naturally is or comes to be'.

Both parts of this definition points to a temporal order. But the notions of 'beginning' and 'ending' have wider bearings than just that of temporality. Prominent scholars such as Ricoeur and Bruner have enriched our understanding of this matter. Ricoeur, for his part, investigated in great detail the relation between time and narrative, rooting his thinking in the works of Aristotle, Augustine and Heidegger (Ricoeur 1984). In Ricoeur's thinking the matter of time plays an important role not only because sequentiality is a prime factor in constructing narratives, but equally important, because our understanding of narratives is grounded in temporal experience, at the level of reading and at the level of existing. Bruner, for his part, also points to the principle of succession as the first property of narrative. And like Ricoeur, he stresses that sequentiality is established by means of a higher principle. On the nature of narrative, Bruner (1990: 43) argues:

> Perhaps its principal property is its inherent sequentiality: a narrative is composed of a unique sequence of events, mental states, happenings involving human beings as characters or actors. These are its constituents. But these constituents do not, as it were, have a life of their own. Their meaning is given by their place in the overall configuration of the sequence as a whole – its plot or *fabula*.

In the fable, the principle of transformation is recognised by the overall configuration of elements. In the text we find not only *actions* (characterised by verbs) along with *descriptive elements* (a fast vs. a slow character) and *patterns of reaction* (e. g. insult – response). All of these elements are tightly woven into a unity, here underlined by the rhetorical trope of a chiasm. The structure of the narrative can then be displayed as follows:

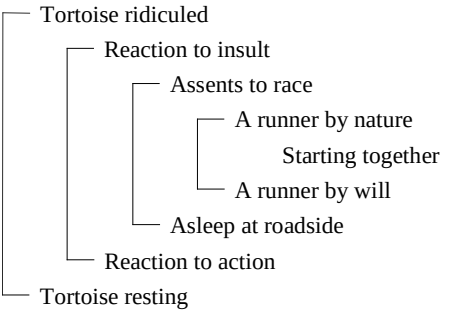

Figure 2: Chiasmic display of events

Even in a narrative as simple as this small fable we see how the principle of succession generates a coherent structure in which the elements are held together because one situation is transformed into another. Narratologies such as those of Propp (1968), Lévi-Strauss (1963), Greimas (1966) and Campbell (1993) come to mind. Todorov (1971) summarises this in his now famous claim that:

> Thus it is incorrect to maintain that the elements are related only by succession; we can say that they are also related by transformation. Here finally, we have the two principles of narrative.

2.3. On Mediation

But there is more. If we are to account for all and only narratives, these two principles are insufficient. Succession and transformation are essential components of narratives. But they are also fundamental principles of many other texts, including recipes, travel plans, and many scientific papers. In the definition of narrativity, I include a third principle: that of mediation.

We may describe this principle with words like relevance, intention, rationale, and verisimilitude. In the context of narrative communication, none of these can be accounted for by the principles of succession and transformation. If we look at the text itself, and the inner workings of contingencies relating textual elements, the highest level we can rise to is the phenomenon of *reportability* as proposed in Labov (1972), which means that some incident has qualities that make it worth reporting. The first two principles cannot account for the communicative power of narratives, nor can the third principle be understood independently.

The principle of mediation means that the text refers to something other than the content of the text itself. If we think of two texts, say the hare-tortoise fable and a recipe for apple pie, and than ask a number of questions, the difference will be clear. Consider questions such as: (1) what is the text about? (2) what does it tell us? (3) what do we learn from the text?

For the apple pie recipe, the answers to all of those questions are exactly the same: how to make apple pie. The text does not refer to anything other than what is actually denoted by the elements of which the text consists. But for the fable, the answers differ greatly. Suppose a group of listeners heard this fable for the first time, and suppose that we than asked them questions (2) and (3). If their answers were simply accounts of the incidents, I would conclude that they had not understood the story at all – that is to say, that the *point* of the story had gone unnoticed. Moreover, I would not be surprised at all if the answers obtained were very much alike: typically something about good human qualities, virtuous conduct, etc. But how is that? What is it that makes us 'tolerate' speaking animals, and infer that the outcome of their doings has some bearing on our lives? The answer resides in the power of narrative mediation.

This fable can give rise to another perspective on mediation. It is quite well known, and can be identified as type 275A in the Stith Thompson catalogue (Thompson 1973). And the central idea (motif) can be found in many variations in different cultures. The Stith Thompson catalogue reports versions from Latvia (275B), Spain (275C), Japan, India, West Africa, and different places in North America as well as from Europe. I would like to draw attention to a version from the Nez Perce tribe of northwestern America, called 'Turtle Races with Bull' (Hines 1999: 171). In this variation, the winner gets as his prize the right to eat the loser. The stakes (or steaks if you prefer) are higher, but the two stories are quite similar. The conclusions, however, differ substantially. In the Nez Perce version, the turtles defeat the bull and than devour it, after which the author concludes that: 'Thus it came to be said that turtle meat is very, very good for eating; it is really Bull's meat' (Hines 1999: 173). The question that now arises now is this: How can it be that the same narrative structure can be used to promote a cosmogonic premise (as in the case of the Nez Perce story) and an

anthropological premise (as in the case of the fable by Aesop)? In the words of Ricoeur (1981: 277):

> … [A] narrative conclusion can be neither deduced nor predicted. There is no story unless our attention is held in suspense by a thousand contingencies. Hence we must follow the story to conclusion. So rather than being *predictable*, a conclusion must be *acceptable*.

Thus the definition of narrativity cannot be confined to the principles of succession and mediation, but must include the notion of mediation as well. The questions that naturally arise are how these three principles work, and how we can describe these workings. The three grand principles of narrative and of narratology have a counterpart in semiotics.

3. Semiotics

It is sometimes said that the purpose of narratology is to account for narrative competence, that is, the investigation of what is necessary in order to produce and understand narratives (Prince 1983: 527). For the purpose of investigating these matters, I shall suggest the presence of three distinct but interdependent layers or levels of narrativity, by which narrative competence succeeds. If we think of the minimal unit of narrative as a *sign* in the semiotic sense, it becomes possible to consider the aspect of succession, transformation, and mediation from a different perspective. In the tradition of American semiotics, the notion of a sign is defined as 'something which stands to somebody for something in some respect or capacity' (Peirce 1992: 2.228). Following this definition, it becomes obvious that the level of analysis is not determined in advance, and that a theory of signs is suitable for different kinds of analysis. According to the American philosopher Charles Sanders Peirce, the theory of signs is anchored in three phenomenological principles, named Firstness, Secondness, and Thirdness, and any sign consists of three sign-relations, defined in terms of these.

> A *Sign*, or *Representamen*, is a First which stands in such a genuine triadic relation to a Second, called its *Object*, as to be capable of determining a Third, called its *Interpretant*, to assure the same triadic relation to the Object in which it stands itself to the same Object. (Peirce 1992: 2.274)

The triadic relations of the sign and the subdivisions of different categories of signs have formed a framework for many kinds of investigations. Based on these distinctions, C. W. Morris later defined three dimensions of semiotics that have earned him a reputation as one

of the founders of semiotics (Nöth 1995: 49). The division is that of *syntactics*, *semantics* and *pragmatics*. Like Peirce, Morris (1938: 3) believed that semiosis consists of three parts:

> The process in which something functions as a sign may be called *semiosis*. This process, in a tradition which goes back to the Greeks, has commonly been regarded as involving three (or four) factors: that which acts as a sign, that which the sign refers to, and that effect on some interpreter in virtue of which the thing in question is a sign to that interpreter. These three components in semiosis may be called, respectively, the *sign vehicle*, the *designatum*, and the *interpretant*; the *interpreter* may be included as the fourth factor.

In continuation of these distinctions, Morris (6-7) suggested three (dyadic) relations as the dimensions of semiotics.

> One may study the relations of signs to the objects to which the signs are applicable. This relation will be called the *semantical dimension of semiosis*, symbolized by the sign 'D_{sem}'; the study of this dimension will be labelled *semantics*. Or the study may be the relation of signs to interpreters. This relation will be called the *pragmatical dimension of semiosis*, symbolized by 'D_p', and the study of this dimension will be named *pragmatics*.
>
> […]
>
> Since most signs are clearly related to other signs, … it is well to make a third dimension of semiosis co-ordinate with the other two which have been mentioned. This third dimension will be called the *syntactical dimension of semiosis*, symbolized by 'D_{syn}' and the study of this dimension will be named *syntactics*.

This terminology suggested by Morris has prevailed to the present day, except of course that that his successors readily renamed syntactics as syntax. The tripartition into syntax, semantics, and pragmatics has been of great influence, especially in the area of linguistics, but in Morris's theory, as in that of Peirce, the notion of a sign is not restricted to the linguistic sign. Thus, by following this tradition, the framework that emerges embraces the transposability of narratives from one media to another.

4. The Narrative Matrix

I shall now return to the pivotal idea that 'narrative can be defined by three principles, each of which extends in three semiotic dimensions'. The three intimately related principles can be briefly summarised as follows:

By *succession* a sequence is formed:

> The principle of succession entails an ordering of elements in time.

By *transformation* a sequence is rendered as a unity:

> A transformational pattern essentially closes a sequence in the sense that it must be considered complete. Sequentiality as a concept does not imply any privileged parts of the sequence – only order. Transformation, on the other hand, unifies the sequence by appointing specific parts of the sequence as beginning, middle, and ending (other vocabularies could also be applied).

By *mediation* a sequential unity is justified:

> The justification of a given unity is obtained by something not inherent to the text. The reasons for choosing one transformation over another are not grounded within the presented material. Similarly, the reasons for choosing one way of presenting the material over another are not grounded within the text itself.

These principles can now be investigated in a semiotic framework by considering three dimensions of the creation of meaning. Here, Syntactics denotes the study of ways in which a set of relations can join units together; Semantics denotes the study of the significance that units obtain from the things they represent; and Pragmatics denotes the study of how collections of units become bearers of information distinct from the objects that they represent.

The workings of the principle of succession may now be described in the following ways.

> 1. Elements are ordered in sequences. The ordering in itself does nothing more than to establish a sequence: an order. Consider this example: if A is an agent and L is a location, we may have a sequence such as ‘A is at L1’, ‘A is at L2’ … ‘A is at Ln’. This is a syntactical operation.
>
> 2. The ordering may also be seen as signifying something. This something is derived from the sequence, but signifies something else than the sheer relation among the elements. The process of signification is usually constrained by several contextual markers. In this simple example, the sequence of locations may signify an activity such as ‘a movement’ or ‘a journey’. Here, the ordering takes on a semantic dimension.
>
> 3. In addition, we may ask how a sequence can be interpreted in terms of a something that serves as a justification or evaluation of the sequence. A sequence of movements may be interpreted as, e. g., ‘fleeing’ or ‘searching’. The notion of performing something in a given order does not in itself warrant this interpretation. In this capacity, ordering takes on a pragmatic dimension.

So far, information is obtained from the events solely by considering the units and the order imposed on the units. The formation of sequences by the principle of succession then facilitates the

foundation of the seminal notion of transformation. Also the principle of transformation can be described in different ways.

1. Bringing elements into plot entails more than establishing a sequence. It entails the notion of one state of affairs being transformed into another, while the entities concerned retain their identity. The sequence is thus portrayed as a unity of events despite the fact that something must be assumed to precede and follow that sequence. What makes the sequence a unity is the appointment of parts of the sequence as beginning and ending, respectively. The agent that moves from place to place is indeed one and the same agent, but he is progressing from state to state. The notion that something changes is not warranted by the principle of succession, but by the relations between elements, progression is shown.

2. In addition to describing some entity as moving through states of affairs, transformation also signifies something by and of that change. In the case of our traveller a transformation sequence may at a given point signify outcomes such as 'getting there' or 'returning'. The linking of events into a schema of progression does not account for an outcome, but may be used to signify one. The semantic process of signification is obtained by reference to related parts of the sequence.

3. A transformational sequence can be indicative of more than the outcome of a progression. It also points to something by which the progression is bound to the outcome. For example it may give rise to interpretations of the sequence as portraying some or all of the entities belonging to the sequence. Our traveller may be portrayed as 'persistent' or 'lazy', and the travel may be portrayed as 'tedious' or 'comfortable', although these predicates, or traits, are not explicitly mentioned anywhere in the text. This attribution cannot be explained solely by what the elements represent, but must also include what connects them.

Succession and transformation alone cannot be said to account for all and only narratives – counterexamples abound. As the third constitutive principle of narrative, I posit the existence of mediation, defined as referring to something more than the elements of the text by means of succession and transformation. Mediation can also be investigated in different respects.

1. The relations between elements can be used to mediate something. This is often the case when events are not presented in canonical order, and may in this capacity depict modal concerns, such as the epistemic or the axiological. The mediating instance of discovering something may be conveyed by means of relations between elements,

in which case it is a syntactical matter. This points to the justification of a progression, and it can be labeled relevance.

2. Mediation can also be obtained through the referents of elements. Often roles are assigned in this manner. Roles like, say, opponent or helper cannot be rendered purely by activities or the outcome of activities (a friend and a foe may perform very similar actions). But the outcome of activities may be rendered as an attribute beyond the semantics of the individual outcome. Since this is accomplished by references between textual elements and their referents, this is also a case of semantics.

3. Furthermore, mediation can take place by means of that which justifies the rendering of semantic features. The semantic attribution of something like roles must be grounded in a mechanism that can generate and assign those roles. Also this feature must be found outside the text itself. A prime example is a value system communicated through a narrative.

These considerations may be organised as in Figure 3, which I call the Narrative Matrix.

	Principle of Succession	*Principle of Transformation*	*Principle of Mediation*
Syntactics	The ordered set of narrative units.	A unity among the ordered set of narrative units.	What unites elements among the ordered set of narrative units.
Semantics	What is signified by the ordered set of narrative units *(e. g.: an activity or description).*	What is signified by a unity among the ordered set of narrative units *(e. g.: outcome or result of a transformation).*	What is signified by that which unites elements among the ordered set of narrative units *(e .g.: the role of a hero or villain).*
Pragmatics	The evaluation and justification of the ordered set of narrative units *(e. g.: motivation for a character's actions).*	The evaluation and justification of a unity among the ordered set of narrative unit *(e. g.: trait of a character or incident).*	The evaluation and justification of what unites elements among the ordered set of narrative units *(e. g.: reason, high level message of narrative communication).*

Figure 3: The Narrative Matrix

5. Conclusion

By stating three fundamental principles of narratology, and by combining them with three semiotic dimensions, a model I have called

the Narrative Matrix is generated. The names of the slots in the matrix may be subject to discussion, and depending on the scope and purpose of analysis, different terms may indeed be applied. Moreover, the model sustained by this double tripartition can be used to evaluate and compare different narratologies, since a given theoretical observation is bounded rarely (if at all) by just one of the areas in the narrative matrix.

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The Ottoman Phenomenon and Edward Said's Monolithic Discourse on the Orient

Esin Akalın

Abstract

This paper examines the correlation between cultural representations and ideological domination by offering a selective overview of a range of plays written about the Ottomans in the 17th and 18th centuries. In addressing the relationship between text/history, knowledge/power, Other/self, this paper questions Edward Said's model of 'fixity' in ideological constructions. It challenges Said's binary oppositions of the East and the West through configurations such as weak/strong, inferior/superior, etc. The paper shows how the plays in question reflect the ambivalence, complexity and chronological transformations of Western attitudes towards the Ottoman Empire. Essentially, this paper explores the relationship between the 'Turk' as a cultural and composite Other constructed through diverse representational discourses (literary, linguistic, dramatic) and the Ottoman Empire (real, material subject with its own history and tradition of thought).

Key words: Ottomans; Edward Said; history; ideology; drama.

Since its original publication in 1978, Edward Said's account in *Orientalism* of the Western approach to the Orient has been both pivotal and a major incentive for the growth of work on colonial discourse. In seeking out to trace the interrelations of culture, history, and textuality, Said (1985: 57) in his widely read and greatly influential book ultimately leaves the reader with the perception that: 'Europe is powerful and articulate; Asia is defeated and distant'. Said separates East and West from a wide range of perspectives − political, religious, economic, historical, cultural − that go back as far as Aeschylus' *The Persians*, and claims that Orientalism is a 'broadly imperialist view of the world' (Said 1985: 15). In discussing the East/West relationship from a 'general and hegemonic context', Said (1985: 9) draws attention to a 'geopolitical awareness into aesthetic, scholarly, historical and philosophical texts' (1985: 120). He claims that Western political and intellectual domination over the East has

defined the nature of the Orient potentially as weak and that of the Occident as strong. Said's model of 'fixity' in the ideological construction of 'otherness' (Bhabha 1983: 8), is for Homi Bhabha[1] (1983: 25) a 'historical and theoretical simplification'. This applies to the Ottoman case from the point of view that Said's ahistorical and ageographical approach to the Orient does not do justice to the historical realities of the Ottoman Empire as a world power in the 16th and 17th centuries.

What is essentially problematic in *Orientalism* is that, as Said explores the relations of knowledge and power, and of culture and politics as the determining elements in defining the worlds of Islam and Christianity, he refers to the Ottomans only in passing. In his introduction to *Orientalism*, which has widely informed studies of Western encounters with Islam from the time of the Crusades to the present, Said defines his premise with precision and clarity. He states that he will deal with the Near East with occasional reference to Persia and India. Said (1985: 17) indicates that in his work 'a large part of the Orient seem[s] to have been eliminated' such as Japan, China and other sections in the Far East 'not because these regions were not important (they obviously have been)'. In his amply documented book, Said (1985: 17) begins by confronting the domination of Britain and France of 'the Eastern Mediterranean from about the seventeenth century on'. He is almost apologetic about the fact that his discussion will 'not do justice to the important contributions to Orientalism of Germany, Italy, Russia and Portugal'. Ironically, though, in his apparent chronological progression of Orientalist exploration, Said, as he focuses on the British and French experience of the East, makes a conscious choice not to talk about the Ottoman Empire. The problem here is that the semantic domain of the concept of power includes the concepts of appropriation and domination, concepts that turn up frequently in Said's characterisations of will to power. Paradoxically, however, based on Said's own appropriation of the domain of the Orient, the 600 years of the Ottoman experience are discarded outright or even 'when mentioned is rendered unrecognizable or irrelevant' (Zilfi 1997: 4).

In his approach to the Orient, Said chooses to homogenise the East and fails to recognise, let alone particularise, the element of power associated with the Ottoman Empire. Thus, part of the problem of

understanding the Ottoman phenomenon on the basis of Said's scholarship is his failure to cover the historical reality of the 'Orient', which to the Europeans primarily signified the Ottoman Empire with its lands including all of Asia Minor, the Levant, the Arabian peninsula, Egypt, North Africa and so on. While Lord Acton posits that 'modern history begins under the stress of the Ottoman conquest' (Coles 1968: i), it is a commonplace that dramatic events such as the conquest of Constantinople (now Istanbul) in 1453, the first siege of Vienna in 1529 and the Battle of Lepanto in 1571 generated a widespread and ongoing interest in the Ottoman Empire. The presence of the Ottomans in the Mediterranean and the extension of Ottoman rule over large parts of southeastern Europe and North Africa deeply affected Westerners politically and culturally. While religious diversity within the empire made the Ottomans among one of the great imperial powers in history, as a 'new life-force' in the Orient their contribution to history was twofold:

> First, through their early successor-sultanates they revived and reunited Islam in its Asiatic lands; then through the imperial Ottoman dynasty they regenerated European lands of Eastern Christendom. As agents of continuity, uniting East with West, they filled a void by the disintegration of the Arab Empire in Asia and of the Byzantine Empire in Europe, to evolve within it a new and creative Ottoman civilization. (Kinross 1977: 613)

Said blames the entire discipline of Orientalism by holding Orientalists responsible for perpetuating the myth of an unchanging Orient and for creating the distinction between Western superiority and Oriental inferiority. He disregards the fact that the Ottomans, who had excelled in statecraft and administration, financial policies, land system, and military power, were, however, a 'self-consciously imperial state' (Kafadar 1995: xi). In that sense, if Orientalism is a 'corporate institution for dealing with the Orient – dealing with it by making statements about it, authorizing views about it, describing it', then the current counter-hegemonic 'regime(s) of truth' (Foucault 1980: 131) that Said propagates pose some historical and theoretical questions for the Ottoman case. In other words, a theoretical approach to understanding the Ottoman phenomenon on the basis of Said's key text on East-West relations seems too speculative to admit any empirical verification. It is only in one of the very rare moments of his *Orientalism* that Said refers to the subject of the 'Ottoman peril' that 'lurked alongside Europe' up until the 17th century. He writes that '[f]or Europe Islam was a lasting trauma' (Said 1985: 59). Although

Said's main focus is on the post-Napoleonic period, in which the European powers began the process of imperialism and colonisation of the East, his work has been widely effective in the studies of Western encounters with Islam in different periods. In this respect, his overgeneralisation of the Orient is problematic and his general claims made through a rough historical overview are misleading. Since there are already difficulties in overcoming the pervasive negative assumptions about the Ottomans embedded in Western understanding, the overgeneralisation of the historical interactions of systems and cultures and an unwillingness to confront concrete realities of the past make the Ottoman case particularly challenging.[2]

The implication in Said's work is that Orientalism is a Western style of dominating and asserting authority over the Orient based upon the ontological and epistemological distinction made between the East and the West. Obviously, the traditional repertoire of Western cultural concepts about the Ottoman Turks is deeply rooted in history and ideology. Furthermore, the relationship between the 'Turk', as a cultural and ideological composite Other constructed through diverse representational discourses (literary, linguistic, dramatic, etc.), and the Ottoman Empire (real, material subject with its own history and tradition of thought) is a complex issue to address. Yet Said's binary opposition of the East and West through configurations such as weak/strong, inferior/superior, colonised/coloniser, etc. are highly multifaceted as revealed through the representations of the Ottomans in European drama from the 16th to the 18th centuries − representations that are mostly based on history.[3]

To pose a relationship between history and drama implies a kind of narrative and textual politics, which are part of the myriad ways in which the relations of power can be interpreted. Given the numerous instances where history and drama intersect in these plays in question, even the unseen presence of the Turks on stage play on the widespread fears about the Ottoman power. As Virginia Mason Vaughan (1994) has shown in her historicist analysis of *Othello*, Shakespeare, for example, portrays the 'Ottomites' as an unrelenting danger yet an invisible power kept offstage. While *Othello* exemplifies on stage the English concern about the threat of Ottoman expansionism, the play, which was performed several times at court

during James I's reign, derived much of its 'anxious suspense' (Vitkus 1997: 147) from Ottoman might in the Mediterranean world.[4]

In his examination of the history of domination and power, Said's focus is on the image of the Arabs in European thought in the post-Napoleonic period, when the European powers had begun the process of colonising the East. Since his definition of 'Orientalism' is rooted in 19th-century British and French imperial history, Said concentrates on how European and Western writers have developed methods of scholarship by which they 'constructed' and 'defined' the Other in order to justify the process of continental and British colonisation. In that sense, in *Orientalism*, Said writes about what he calls, after Foucault, the discourse of 19th- and 20th-century Anglo-French Orientalism as it confronted the Islamic Near East. Modern literary critics who adopt Said's templates of power and domination in interpreting Western literary discourse about the East disregard his 'historical parameters' (Matar 1996: 187). Thus they adopt and focus on the postcolonialist discourse from the perspective of power and domination and they apply it to the canonical texts of the Renaissance period. This desire to apply Said's theory backwards is not only anachronistic but also misleading, considering that the Ottoman Empire and Islam up until the 18th century was 'beyond colonization and domination' (Matar 1998: 12).

In Christopher Marlowe's *Tamburlaine* (1590), for example, when Tamburlaine at one point converts to Islam, he has aspirations to 'dominate' the seas and keep 'in awe the Bay of Portingale/All the Ocean by the British Shore' (III.iii.258-9). It is highly debatable that Renaissance England would think of 'dominating' and 'imperialising' the Ottoman Empire. In fact, in the 16th and the 17th centuries, as Emily Bartels (1997: 48) argues, while 'imperialist ideologies and prospects were already in the air' and 'enmeshed in a cloud of unknowing', the idea of 'dominating' the Turk was 'unthinkable' (Matar 1996: 189) in England. In this context, it must be emphasised that knowledge of the Turks was 'almost nil in medieval England' (Beck 1985: 29) to the extent that the fall of Constantinople in 1453 'had passed without notice in contemporary English chroniclers' (Wood 1935: 1). Yet apart from Renaissance curiosity, anxiety about the Ottomans was soon evidenced in England in an outpouring of texts conveying ideas and knowledge about the Empire. English dramatists

also joined most continental artists (literary and visual) in representing Ottoman Turks on stage through a fascination that oscillated between fear and emulation. Although geographically the English were outside the periphery of the Ottoman danger, for England the establishment of the Ottoman power was one of the most ideologically laden threats to its identity. While the confrontation of the London audience with the Grand Turk took place at a level of fiction, in Shakespeare's *Henry V* it was Hal, the first king of the Tudors, who aspired to emulate the Ottoman Empire. As he wooed the French King's daughter, he pleaded with her to prove 'a good soldier-breeder': 'Shall not thou and I, between Saint Denis and Saint George, compound a boy, half French, half English, that shall go to Constantinople and take the Turk by the beard?' (V.ii.204-7) In essence, by the time Shakespeare displayed his literary fantasies in *Henry V* or depicted a Venice imperilled by a threat from the 'Ottomites' in *Othello*, the Ottoman Empire had already asserted itself in Europe culturally, politically, economically and militarily.

In France, the Ottomans were first brought to public attention in 1396 through the crusading expedition of a large body of French knights in the battle of Nicopolis, which in fact was a complete victory for the Ottomans. Later, by the 16th century, since Francis I had established a permanent embassy in Istanbul, despite their different customs, languages, and religion both the Ottoman dignitaries and the Imperial ambassadors in their spectacular and highly ceremonial meetings at the Sublime Porte spoke the same language of 'power, profit and monarchy' (Mansel 1996: 45). In fact, general interest in the Ottoman Empire was so great in France that the translations of the treatises written by the historian Paolo Giovio were published.

Besides this principal source of historical knowledge of the Turks in the mid-16th century, a number of internal events of Süleyman's reign were also familiar to French readers through chroniclers or dramatists. In 1672, following its highly successful performance, Racine's *Bajazet* received 'royal approbation from Versailles' (McGowan 1968: 11). Performed in magnificent Ottoman costume (McGowan 1968: 12), the success of *Bajazet*, which revolved around a tragic story in the court of Sultan Murad IV, was mainly due to the topicality of its theme. The audiences were familiar with Ottoman affairs through weekly newspapers like *Le mercure de France* and *Gazette*,

which attentively recorded events from Istanbul. As the Ottoman court ranked 'second to Versailles as far as public interest in its affairs [was] concerned' (McGowan 1968: 19), in addition to topical news and political history, a literary tradition kept the Ottomans and their affairs in the forefront.

In French drama the image of the Grand Seigneur was conveyed through a cycle of plays about Süleyman the Magnificent, beginning with Bounin's *La soltane* (1561). Essentially, the image of the sultan was in a constant state of flux between a powerful and rightful ruler and that of a despotic monarch as revealed through such 17th-century works as Mainfray's *La Rhodeiene* (1621), Mairet's *Le grand et dernier Solyman* (1635), Dalibray's *Le Solyman* (1637), George Scudery's *Ibrahim* (1643), Desmares' *Roxalane* (1643), Le Vayer de Boutigny's *Le grand Selim* (1645), Tristan L'Hermite's *Osman* (1647), and Jacquelin's *Le Soliman* (1653). At best, the analysis of these texts not only reveals a curiosity about the habits and customs of the Ottomans, but also indicates an effort to discover what was at the root of their power. At worst (although aesthetically and politically ingenious) they are ideological constructs, which reinforce cultural, religious and sociopolitical differences on stage in order to overcome, emulate, and ultimately surpass the Ottoman power.

Both in tragedies and comedies, the signifiers of difference visually portrayed stereotypical images of the East. As Bhabha (1994: 66) asserts, the 'stereotype', which is the 'discursive strategy' of 'fixity', vacillates between what is already known, and 'something which must be anxiously repeated'. By a curious irony, Said's radical theory and views about the Orient are clearly evident in the following statement, which represents a construct, not a reality, and his own stereotypical and mythic East of the past:

> The other feature of the Orient was that Europe was always in a position of strength, not to say domination. There is no way of putting this euphemistically … the essential relationship, on political, cultural and even religious grounds, was seen − in the West, which is what concerns us here − to be one between a strong and weak partner. (Said 1985: 40)

Considering the political significance of Ottoman-European trade relations and 'the fierce competition among' European countries to appear in treaties as the Ottomans' 'most favoured nation' (Naff 1977: 100), the relationship between the East and the West was one in which 'friendship' with the Ottoman Empire was one coveted by all trading

nations. In essence, after Columbus's 'discovery' of America, while Europeans ventured across the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans and 'took possession of the peoples they encountered' (Greenblatt 1991: 9) the Ottomans with their formidable army held power over Europe.[5]

In postulating important theories about the East and West relations and speaking for the Orient itself, Said has his own specific political concerns. As he seems to reintroduce the East through his own identity and the discourse of his own culture, Said reveals a power relation correlated to his field of knowledge. For Foucault (1980: 119) whose discourse analysis has provided the basis for Said's theories of Orientalism, '[w]hat makes power hold good, what makes it accepted, is simply the fact that it traverses and produces things, it … forms knowledge, produces discourses'. What constitutes a great challenge to adapting Said's theories to the Ottoman phenomenon is that when Said examines the identity and difference structures of the East and West by addressing historical, material and ideological issues, he treats the Ottomans as if they existed outside of history. The paradox here is that the Ottoman Empire, with the exceptional racial and religious tolerance of its administration, carries within itself the burden of an imperial past, which includes its centuries' rule of Eastern lands such as Egypt, Palestine, Jerusalem, and so on. Considering the pluralistic and open-ended nature of the Ottoman past, Said's generalisation of Orientalism as a constant and monolithic discourse poses a further challenge to the Ottoman case and becomes problematic. According to Foucault, for whom representation, knowledge, 'truth', and discourse are 'radically historicized', things have meaning and are 'true' only within a specific historical context (Hall 1997: 46). Foucault believes that discourse produces forms and practices of knowledge, which differ radically from period to period with no necessary continuity between them. Thus, contrary to Said's assertion, Western representations of the Orient cannot be generalised and taken as serious descriptions of the Ottomans as 'weak', 'defeated', and 'inferior'.

In *Orientalism*, which revolves around such ideas as history, culture and the geography of power, Said's persistent claim of unchallenged Western hegemony emphasises the dominance of imperialism of a single character. The geography of power or rather colonisation, which derives from the Latin word *colere*, meaning 'to cultivate or put

to use', is a 'process by which the frontier of a less technologically developed or less organized civilization – and organization is also a technique – yielded before a civilization whose technological equipment was superior' (Verlinden 1970: ix-xiv). In that sense, different societies at different historical moments appropriated new territories to build their civilisations. Like the Italian city-states, which had initiated medieval colonisations in the Holy Land, in the Aegean and Ionian Seas, and even in the Black Sea, the Ottomans had similar ambitions for imperial possessions. As the historical accounts of ancient and medieval politics are abundant with stories of invasion, occupation and subjugation from the sacking of Rome to the Norman Conquest, the Ottomans, building their civilisations, soon became participants of the 'conquest culture'. For Said (1985: 204), however, Orientalism is a 'political doctrine willed over the Orient because the Orient was weaker than the West, which elided the Orient's difference with its weakness'. In deemphasising what Lisa Lowe (1991: 5) calls the 'heterogeneity of imperialisms', Said's work lacks historical precision and disregards the question of hegemony as a process, which is neither static nor monolithic.

As Foucault (1980: 98) states, 'power does not function in the form of a chain'. It circulates and is never monopolised by one centre. Power is 'deployed and exercised through a net-like organization', which is rooted in particular contexts and histories. Thus, hegemony and domination are not permanent forms of power that radiate from one single direction, one specific source. In fact, the Ottoman sultans like the Habsburg emperors in the 16th century even aspired to resurrect the Roman Empire. Through the Empire's network of Western-oriented artistic patronage, the Ottoman-Habsburg-papal rivalry was disseminated to the European courts through iconographic representations such as the fantastic headgear of Süleyman the Magnificent in the 'shape of a papal tiara' (Kurz 1969: 249). While illustrations in woodcuts, engravings and later in etchings and lithographs helped mold the European image of the Ottomans, such iconography was aimed at conveying Ottoman claims of sovereignty to a European audience (Necipoğlu 1989: 401). Even after the Ottomans' defeat in Lepanto, Europe still had anxiety about whether the Empire could appropriate the entire world and claim itself as a universal monarchy. Thus the constant menace to Europe of an Ottoman invasion, coupled with a great interest in the character and

customs of the Turk, inspired playwrights to write about complex Ottoman themes such as tyranny, captivity, court intrigues, war, conquests and so on. In carefully crafted plays that concentrated upon key characters who were predominantly sultans, the dramatists, exploring the motives and the consequence of the actions of these rulers, ultimately created heroes or villains who fulfilled the needs of drama as much as the discipline of the historian.

As Nabil Matar (1998: 19) writes, the intellectual and religious impacts of Europe's encounter with the Ottomans were

> instrumental in defining early modern European culture: from Pope Pius II to Martin Luther and John Locke, from John Calvin to Christopher Marlowe … from Cervantes to Shakespeare, Massinger and Dryden − all reflected, to varying degree in their writings, on the interaction between Christendom and Islam.

As he writes on the Renaissance perspective on Islam in Britain by focusing on the element of power that Britons associated with the Ottomans, Matar (1998: 13) posits that Mediterranean Islam 'was self-sustained and self-representing because it was militarily formidable'. In this context, when Sir William Davenant wrote *The Siege of Rhodes* (1656), one of the most influential and pioneering works of Restoration drama, he essentially ushered onto the English stage an Ottoman fleet to represent ideas of greatness. As he chose for his subject Süleyman the Magnificent, whose reputation was nowhere greater than France, Davenant portrayed him as a 'heroic figure, [a] victorious [ruler and raised him] above everyone else both in valour and honour' (Hedback 1973: 6). In *The Siege of Rhodes*, which incidentally was the first play to introduce female actors on the English stage, Davenant's heroine Ianthe speaks highly of Solyman (i. e., Süleyman). As for her husband Alphonso, he admits that the Ottoman sultan is his 'superior not only in arms but also in courtesy' and valour. In John Dryden's essay on 'Heroic Plays', while he indicates that Davenant was forced to introduce examples of 'moral virtue' on the Restoration stage in order not to offend the Puritans, the English play, revolving around a historical siege, aims at portraying a strongly united Ottoman Empire as a contrast to Christendom split into factions.

Until the 18th century, representations of the Ottomans in European drama reflected Western thought fear of and fascination with the Ottoman Empire. As ideological constructs, they were designed to

ward off the powers and dangers of the Ottoman Turks in the 16th and 17th centuries. The 18th century, however, ushered in a time of defeat for the Ottoman Empire and the progression of events in this era led to a shift in the balance of power between the Ottoman Empire and Europe. Thus the sociopolitical context of comedies and light musical plays that provided the dynamic of the aesthetic representation of the Ottomans expanded on the diverse images of the Turk as noble, human, wise, generous, and compassionate, and as magnanimous lovers.

In sum, plays revolving around the Ottoman Turks reveal the ambivalence, complexity and chronological transformations of Western attitudes towards the Ottoman Turks. In that respect, it is difficult to pin down the representation of the Ottoman Turk in Said's monolithic discourse as a clear binarism. According to Lowe (1991: 5), on the one hand 'orientalism consists of an uneven matrix of orientalist situations across different cultures and historic sites' and on the other hand 'each of these orientalisms is internally complex and unstable'. This holds true for the tradition of writing about the Ottomans, as the plays reflect the ideological conformity of their writers to their social context and historic periods. In short, Orientalism seems to have a complicated life of its own.

Endnotes

[1]As Bhabha (1994: 66) writes in *The Location of Culture*, '[a]n important part of the colonial discourse depends on the concept of "fixity" in the ideological construction of Otherness. "Fixity" as a sign of cultural/historical/racial difference in the course of colonialism is a paradoxical mode of representation'. It connotes not only 'rigidity' but also 'repetition'.

[2]Thanks to the work of scholars such as Bernard Lewis, Justin McCarthy, Paul Coles, Virginia Mason Vaughan, and recently Nabil Matar, the Ottoman era has begun to receive the attention merited by its significant role in Europe. By focusing on the significance of Ottoman-European relations in the 16th and 17th centuries and exploring the social, cultural and economic role of the Ottoman Turks, a nation usually ignored by such theoretical constructs as Orientalism, these scholars have shed some light on the scope of its impact in the West.

[3]Inasmuch as more than 20 extant plays were written about the Ottomans between 1580 and 1642, it is clear that England, like all the leading states in Europe, took into account the Ottoman Empire from an aesthetic as well as from a religious, political, diplomatic and economic point of view. See Artemel (1973). For plays written about the Ottomans between 1656 and 1792, see Akalın (2001).

[4]During the reign of James I, despite anti-Ottoman sentiments and rhetoric against Islam, Britain carried on extensive trade with the Ottoman Empire. While the letters of patent granted by the queen referred to the Ottoman sultan as 'the most sovereign monarch' of the East, for Londoners the Grand Seigneur stood as the absolute ruler of an empire that was a threat to Christendom.

[5]In the 16th century, if the Ottoman Empire posed a serious threat to European sovereignty and played a great role in rivalries for commercial hegemony in the economic space stretching from Venice to the Indian Ocean, the objectives of Ottoman expansion, its power politics, and struggle for control of oriental trade were no different than those of 'European voyages of discovery: wealth, power, glory, religious legitimation' (Brummett 1994: 2).

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The Stylistic Dialogue of East and West in Orhan Pamuk's *The White Castle*

Dilek Kantar

Abstract

This study analyses *stylistic hybrids* that posit Western and Eastern conceptions of self in dialogic interaction in Orhan Pamuk's *The White Castle* (1985). Through Bakhtin's (1934) theory of *dialogic heteroglossia* in novelistic discourse, this paper illustrates how 'another's speech' is infused into the speech of the main characters in Pamuk's novel. Stylistic hybrids involving a coalescence of the speech patterns implicating opposing ideologies let Pamuk challenge the boundary between the Eastern and the Western patterns of thinking personified by the main characters in his novel, the Ottoman 'master' and the Italian 'slave'. The *hybrid constructions* in the novel help create an intended effect of mixed identity between the two main characters on the plot level by creating fluid stylistic boundaries within their speech types. Rather than focusing on the stylistic hybrids in *The White Castle* as pure linguistic phenomena, this study will illustrate how they interact with various narrative elements in the novel.

Key words: novel style; stylistic hybrid; intentional hybrid; dialogism; dialogised heteroglossia.

Orhan Pamuk (2000: 20) sees the tension arising out of a clash between the traditions of the West and the modernity of the East as a driving force in his own fiction in general:

> I think I get my energy from this traditional wall that still exists in Turkey between East and West, between modernity and tradition. All the artists and intellectuals of previous generations have had an idea of a Turkey, which would be either totally Eastern, or totally Western, totally traditional or modern. My little trick is to see these two spirits of Turkey as one and see this eternal fight between East and West, that takes place in Turkey's spirit, not as a weakness but as a strength, and to try to dramatize that force by making something literary out of it.

Pamuk's *The White Castle* delineates the 'eternal fight' between the East and the West as an internal struggle within the minds of his main characters, Ottoman Hoja, and his Italian slave. The stylistic hybrids in the speech patterns of the narrator, the 23-year-old Italian slave,

expose this struggle in the form of a dialogic interaction of the Eastern and the Western selves intermixing in his persona. A *stylistic hybrid*, according to Mikhail Bakhtin (1934: 304), is of enormous significance in novel style, and it can be defined as

> an utterance that belongs, by its grammatical (syntactic) and compositional markers, to a single speaker, but actually contains mixed within it two utterances, two speech manners, two styles, two 'languages', two semantic and axiological belief systems.

Stylistic hybrids belong to the essential makeup of the dialogic nature of novelistic language, which Bakhtin views as an environment where mutually alien words and accents struggle and harmonise with one another. On a more limited scale, stylistic hybrids display Bakhtin's idea of *dialogised heteroglossia*, a deepened form of the dialogic essence of language itself that is best represented by the language in a novel. *Dialogised heteroglossia* or the dialogic essence of language manifests itself on the intersubjective level:

> Language, for the individual consciousness, lies on the borderline between oneself and the other. The word in language is half someone else's. It becomes 'one's own' only when the speaker populates it with his own intention, his own accent, when he appropriates the word, adapting it to his own semantic and expressive intention. (Bakhtin 1934: 293)

This intersubjectivity operates on different levels in novelistic language. Naturally, the author or any character assuming the position of a narrator distances himself/herself from the language of the text by adopting the voice of a teller of tales. The relationship between author and characters, and the relationship between the characters themselves are distanced from the narrative voice in the novel through hybrid constructions themselves, which involve others' words, sentences, styles, manners etc. The two distinct components of a stylistic hybrid, Bakhtin (1934) explains, are not formally separated from one another through compositional markers such as quotation marks, italics, hyphens, etc. Among several different types of the stylistic hybrids in novelistic language Bakhtin (1934) analyses, we shall focus in this study on those that reflect another character's speech style and point of view within a character's own speech patterns. We shall demonstrate how the question of mixed identity that we find woven in the overall structure of the novel appears in linguistic manifestations on the sentence level in *The White Castle*. Bakhtin's theory itself is like a hybrid construction – a cross between literary and linguistic approaches to literature. However, by 'linguistic approach' we should

not understand counting of certain words or phrases in a novel or drawing a 'structural' map of the carcass of a novel. Dialogism in the novel penetrates into the smallest 'molecular' levels of discourse, and is populated with the author's own socio-ideological intention. So-called 'dialogised heteroglossia' involves

> the quoted verbal speech of characters … the relationship between the characters' discourses and the author's discourse (if represented in the text) and between all these discourses and other discourses outside the text, which are imitated or evoked or alluded to by means of doubly-oriented speech. (Lodge 1988: 136)

In the beginning of *The White Castle* the hybrid constructions in the Italian narrator's speech reveal his contempt for the Eastern ideas and lifestyle embodied in the persona of his captor, Hoja (meaning 'master' in Turkish, as the slave is told when they first meet). However, as the slave finds himself more and more immersed in the Ottoman lifestyle against his will during his long years of captivity, the hybrid patterns in his speech start to reflect an essential change in his conceptions of his captor, and of Ottoman culture. His voice loses the ironic tone of the novel's beginning, and he starts to narrate the story not as a distant observer of a culture but as an active participant in it. The enduring love-hate relationship between the two main characters makes them more and more alike until they literally fuse on both the story and the discourse levels in the novel.

In his postscript to the Turkish edition of *The White Castle* in 1986, Pamuk ironically claims that he himself does not know whether the Italian slave or the Ottoman master is the actual writer of the 'manuscript' of the novel (this postscript is not included in the English translation of the novel). The Cervantine 'found manuscript' motif enhances the enigma surrounding the identity of the master and the slave from the very start. The narrator introduces himself to us as a Westerner who has studied science and art in Florence and Venice; however, he also emphasises that only 'a few people' who patiently read the whole book will understand that *he is not the person* that he will tell us about. These words imply that the speaking voice is not the Italian slave. Who is it then? It is either an Easternised Westerner that we find at the end of the novel or the Ottoman Hoja himself, acting the part of his alter ego, or 'the boozy historian, who had quite enough troubles in *The House of Silence*' (Berman 1991: 47). It could as well be the obscure left-handed copyist mentioned in the later part of the

novel. These *personae* are different faces of the same implied author Pamuk wants us to imagine. Is not the free-spirited Hoja of the novel taken captive, in a sense, by the stagnant notions, dysfunctional institutions, and narrow-minded people of his own culture? However, most readers with modernist expectations suppose that the novel is written by the Venetian slave, and the two main characters exchange their identity at the end. Either way, the fusion of the two main characters takes place so smoothly on the discourse level that we cannot easily find out how it happens. This is how Pamuk actually challenges the usual patterns of thinking based on East-West dualism. Can an Easterner portray the mindset of a Westerner if he is the supposed writer of the manuscript, for example? On the other hand, can a Westerner actually learn to adapt himself to the Eastern lifestyle that he loves to hate passionately (if we are to believe the narrator's story)?

The East-West conflict that permeates the whole novel starts out as a religious one in the opening scene. An Italian galley vs. Turkish galleys quickly becomes Christians vs. Muslims after the Turks attack Italian ships. The narrator barely escapes being taken captive as a galley slave by entering into Turkish service as a mock doctor. Pamuk's portrayal of Turks as master torturers here parallels that of Cervantes in his 'Captive's Tale' in *Don Quixote*. The Turks impale the cowardly captain (in the English version of the novel he dies 'at the stake'), and they cut off the noses and ears of the Christian soldiers before setting them adrift on a raft. The Italian slave, on the other hand, is characterised as a would-be martyr who refuses to convert to Islam even when his head is laid on a stump to be cut off. He does not change this stance during his 20 years of stay in Istanbul despite Hoja's warning that 'a man must be a Muslim to be happy here' (71). Despite this, the irresolvable religious difference between the master and the slave does not seem to be an essential issue in the rest of the novel.

In the beginning, the traits the two main characters of the novel have in common are their physical likeness and their scorn for each other's beliefs and ideas. They still seem to have found a common ground in their inexhaustible lust for knowledge and scientific inventions. Hoja likes to have this Westerner as a slave, because he wants to be taught 'everything' about the Western lifestyle, which, in the slave's opinion,

means 'all that I'd learned in primary and secondary school; all the astronomy, medicine, engineering, everything that was taught in my country' (32). Here is the slave's description of how Hoja accomplishes this ambitious task:

> (1) *Olağanüstü çalışkanlığı ve zekasıyla, sonraları daha da ilerleteceği İtalyanca'yı söküp, altı ay içinde bütün hatırladıklarımı bana tekrarlattığı zaman hiçbir üstünlüğüm kalmamıştı benim.* (34)
>
> With his phenomenal diligence and quickness of mind, he'd acquired a basic grasp of Italian which he'd improve upon later, read all of my books, and by the time he'd made me repeat to him everything I remembered, *there was no longer any way in which I was superior to him.* (33, emphasis added)

These words do not imply a change in the slave's viewpoint towards Hoja yet. He actually thinks that Hoja is acting like 'a clever boy who tries to prove that the things his big brother knows are really not all that much' (33). The part written in italics in (1) is a stylistic hybrid rendered in Hoja's tone. Hoja is the one who is trying to prove that his slave is not superior to him in any respect, especially in science. The slave does not debate his ideas at this point, because he still harbors hopes for a possible escape, and he does not want to provoke his anger, either. Instead, the slave compensates for his inferior position with the air of superiority implied in the ironic undertone that permeates his whole narration in the beginning. The hybrid construction in (1) has two 'accents' to use Bakhtin's word: the slave's ironic characterisation of the master, and the master's scornful attitude towards the slave. As Bakhtin (1940: 75) elaborates, every word 'with irony, enclosed in intonational quotation marks' is in a broad sense an 'intentional hybrid'. In (1) we have both Hoja's speech type and the narrator's ironic intention mixed in one stylistic hybrid.

In Hoja's view, the 'everything' that he learns from his slave does not amount to much. He acts as if 'he had access to a knowledge that transcended what was in books – he himself agreed most of them were worthless – a knowledge more natural and more profound than things that could be learned' (33). Although the master and the slave join in their tireless effort to impress the seven-year-old sultan with new 'scientific' projects for a while, this does not build a true communication between them. The slave takes the never-acknowledged pain of his imprisonment out on his master by passive aggression. He totally ignores Hoja's intermittent philosophical questions. Hoja's question 'Why am I what I am?' starts a long series

of plays on self and identity between the two that signal a change in their attitude towards one another. Here is the slave's narration of his own response to Hoja's question:

> (2) *Niye kendisi olduğunu bilmediğimi söyledikten sonra, bu sorunun, orada, onlar arasında, çok sorulduğunu, her gün daha çok sorulduğunu ekleyiverdim* (63)
>
> I replied that I didn't know why he was what he was, adding that this question was often asked by *'them'* and asked more and more everyday (58)

As in (1), the slave seems to adopt Hoja's speech style in the hybrid construction in (2). Hoja uses the words 'they' and 'there' to refer to 'Westerners' and 'the West' respectively, without a need to specify characteristics of this reference group. Note that in the English translation the word 'them' is put in quotation marks to mark it off as a foreign word in the slave's speech style, and the word 'there' (*orada*) is omitted. To Hoja, his slave embodies all there is to know about 'them'. Although the slave is talking about his own country and his own people in (2), he uses the same pronouns Hoja would use to refer to the West and the Westerners. The word 'there' is also worth attention in (2), because at the very end of the novel not only the main characters but also the two fictional backgrounds to the story, Turkey and Italy, conflate on the plot level, as we shall see below.

The slave's ironic and scornful tone changes after he finds himself truly involved in Hoja's thoughts. The main reason for this magical transformation seems to be fiction itself. After living together for 11 years, Hoja and the slave one day look into a mirror together, watch the resemblance of their faces, and then they start to act like a mirror image of one another. They sit at the same table, and start probing into each others' selves through writing for days on end to find the answer to the question 'Why am I what I am?' Their childhood memories, fears, and dreams become an abject for ruthless scrutiny. 'Thus in the space of two months', says the slave, 'I learned more about his life then I'd been able to learn in eleven years' (63). However, the writing game turns sour when the slave manipulates Hoja into writing about his imaginary or real evil deeds with the pretext of getting to know one another thoroughly. He thinks he can still stage an escape by making Hoja realise his own inferiority.

When a plague breaks out in the city, it joins these irreconcilable foes in their fear against a common, natural enemy: death. It is Hoja who

first confesses that 'Now I am like you'; 'I know your fear, I have become you' (83). The slave's escape from home for fear of being infected by Hoja only makes him realise that he truly loves and misses his partner. Surprisingly, he starts to play the lover's part himself: 'I should be by his side, I was Hoja's very self. I had become separated from my real self and was seeing myself from the outside, just as in the nightmares I often had' (98). Meanwhile, Hoja becomes the imperial astrologer, which makes him neglect his relationship with his slave. Like an obsessive lover, the slave follows Hoja around. He even justifies his wish to stay in Istanbul by imagining that his mother is probably dead by now, and his fiancé is married to someone else.

This change in the slave's mind is also reflected in the change in his speech style. Instead of using the Eastern point of view for parodic purposes as he usually does in the first seven chapters, in Chapter 8 he finds himself planning to prevent defeat by 'them':

> (3) *Yıkımdan imparatorluğun elindeki ülkeleri bir bir kaybetmesini mi anlıyorduk? Haritalarımızı masanın üstüne yayar, önce hangi ülkelerin, sonra hangi dağlarla hangi nehirlerin elden çıkacağını hüzünle saptardık. Yoksa yıkım, insanların ve inançların farkına varmadan değişmesi anlamına mı geliyordu? Bütün İstanbulluların bir sabah sıcak yataklarından başka birer insan olarak kalktıklarını düşlerdik; elbiselerini nasıl giyeceklerini bilemiyorlar, minarelerin neye yaradığını hatırlamıyorlardı. Belki de yıkım, ötekilerin üstünlüğünü görerek onlara benzemeye çalışmakti ...* . (122)
>
> Did we understand 'defeat' to mean that the empire would lose all of its territories one by one? We'd lay out our maps on the table and *mournfully* determine first which territories, then which mountains or rivers would be lost. Or did defeat mean that people would change and alter their beliefs without noticing it? We imagined how everyone in Istanbul might rise from their warm beds one morning as changed people, they wouldn't know how to wear their clothes, *wouldn't be able to remember what minarets were for*. Or perhaps defeat meant to accept the superiority of *others* and try to emulate them … . (109)

In (3) the italicised parts show that the Western slave mourns for the loss of territories of the empire along with his Eastern master. He even does not seem to rejoice in the fact that there might arise a possibility for the West of defeating Islam altogether with the fall of the Ottoman Empire. The word 'others' here means Westerners from the viewpoint of Easterners (the act of not knowing how to wear their clothes implies Easterners' adopting of the Western dress code, as the passage further explains). As in example (2) the slave uses the pronouns Hoja would use to refer to the Westerners here. The difference is that the

ironic 'intonational quotation marks' do not exist here. However, it would be impossible to see this stylistic change in the slave's narrative without a due appreciation of content in the novel.

From this point on in the book the slave starts to adopt his master's personality and lifestyle alongside his speech patterns as his love and admiration for him increases. He joins Hoja in an effort to create a weapon of mass destruction that would exterminate the 'enemy'. When they are ushered into the sultan's presence to discuss this weapon, here is how the slave describes the sultan's reaction to the physical likeness between him and the master:

> (4) *yanyana dikilen bize, ikimize döndü ve Allah'ın insan soyunun gururunu kırmak, saçmalığını duyurmak için yarattığı o eşsiz harikalardan birini, kusursuz bir cüceyi, ya da tıpatıp benzeşen ikiz kardeşleri görmüş gibi gülümseyiverdi* (126)
>
> [The sultan] turned towards the two of us just then standing side by side, and smiled all at once as if he'd seen one of those *matchless wonders God created to break the pride of mankind, to make them sense their absurdity* – a perfect dwarf or twin brothers alike as peas in a pod (113)

Here the slave does not incorporate Hoja's speech style into his own, but he speaks as Hoja himself or as any Easterner with deep popular religious convictions would speak under such circumstances. The irony here is that in the English translation the word 'Allah' becomes 'God' as if the translator were trying to correct a logical error made on the author's part. The English translation thus erases the mark of one stylistic hybrid that merges Eastern attitudes in the speech of the Western narrator. The gradual change in the slave's character becomes so obvious that he even starts to look down on Western culture. After listening to musicians from Venice, he calls their music 'pretentious nonsense' (118), while he adores the obscenities in the Turkish shadow plays *Karagöz* and *Hadjivat*.

The line between cultural and personal borders seems to have been erased through the love these two characters learn to feel for one another after a gruelling process of trial and error. Hoja goes away to Florence to escape persecution after his massive weapon fails miserably in a battle, and the slave takes his place in the Ottoman court as the imperial astrologer, gets married, and has four children. But the story does not end there; the narrator says 'I believed in my story' (157). Towards the end of the book we no longer have a

Westerner talking through an Easterner's point of view, but we have the voice of Hoja himself talking through his slave.

The narrator (I will not call him the master or the slave at this point) decides to quit his job and flee Istanbul when the Sultan asks him to write a story of his slave including details like 'the view overlooking the garden at the back of His house that He recalled when he was about to be beheaded for his refusal to convert to Islam' (152). He moves into a different house 'so as to forget Him'. In his new home he also landscapes his 'back garden' 'as he wants.' There he spends time advising visitors who want to consult him because they discover that he is a former astrologer. When he refers to this period in his life, he calls Turkey 'my country' for the first time and starts speaking in a voice which seems to belong to an Easterner: 'It was perhaps from them [his visitors] that I learned most about my country where I have lived from childhood' (152). He listens to all kinds of people's stories and incorporates them into 'this book' that we are reading at the moment. Here we have a truly Easternised voice speaking in the persona of the narrator. However, the sentences in the final paragraph which describe the view of the back yard through the window of his home are exact copies of the descriptions of the Italian slave's back yard, which he remembers when he is about to be beheaded by the Turks because of his refusal to convert to Islam.

As we have seen in the examples above, stylistic hybrids involve linguistic constructions that have a 'double accent' with overt references or subtle undertones that refer to different, at times conflicting, characters or ideologies in a novel. Bakhtin's idea of polyphony (heteroglossia) is often mistaken for a dramatic dialogue of different voices in a novel. Rather, it is a mixture, as our analysis shows, of various stylistic components within the speech that 'belongs' to a certain persona. In *The White Castle*, the polyphony of the stylistic hybrids plays upon our stereotypical images of the West and the East. The analysis of the hybrid constructions in novelistic language reveals the interplay of dialogic elements in the language of a novel, and their study is essential if we are to understand a writer like Orhan Pamuk, whose work bears the multicolored imprints of his multicultural background.

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Logical/Textual Space vs. Physical Space: Same or Different?

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Abstract

This paper's subject is a link between two seemingly unrelated fields: language on the one hand and architecture and visual arts (especially sculpture) on the other. The conception of linguistic space can be viewed from two different perspectives, *viz.* as logical space and as textual space. The former goes back to the Wittgensteinian idea of *logischer Raum* and lies at the foundation of possible-worlds semantics, as the repository of whatever is possible or imaginable owing to the capacities of human cognition and language. The latter notion in one of its aspects, developed both in traditional literary semantics (Nils Erik Enkvist) and in the cognitive framework (Text Worlds and Discourse Worlds of Paul Werth, partly also mental spaces of Gilles Fauconnier), becomes the space of the reader/interpreter. The question arises whether textual/discourse space and the physical space of architecture and visual arts rely on the same interpretative technique of gap-filling (concretisation) in their shared function of the space of social communication. The author argues that despite several similarities (perspectivisation and interconnection with time being most prominent convergences), logical/textual space appears to be more powerful and capacious than ordinary space.

Key words: logical space; textual /discourse space; ordinary space; gappiness; infinity.

One of the universal features of human culture, possibly connected with the anthropological peculiarity of human cognition, is the fact that the map of the world contains, of necessity, the features of spatial characteristics. The very construction of the order of the world is always conceived in terms of spatial structure, which organises its other orders.

In this succinct way Yuri Lotman (1969, qtd. in Rosner 1981: 222) captured the nature of this basic aspect of human cognition, which may be called 'spatial'. Space is, then, together with time, a primitive, even cosmic dimension of our experience. We cannot freely step out of either of them and usually we do not even intend to, feeling cosy in

our own space and time. Yet from the philosophical viewpoint we may always raise the disturbing query whether space is real, i. e., physically existent, or whether it is merely a mental form beyond which we cannot escape, a construct of our brain that has been automatically superimposed upon the originally aspatial and atemporal matter of the world.

Suppose we put this embarrassing Kantian qualm aside and assume, for simplicity's sake, that ordinary, physical space does exist and that we are safely located in it. We can still wonder whether space is *substantial* by nature (i. e., an objective entity composed of points or areas in which objects are situated) or, rather, *relational* (composed exclusively of temporary-spatial relations among objects). It seems that in our commonsensical appraisal of space we draw on the combination of these notions, rather than opt exclusively for one of them.

Yet philosophers and logicians have long since brought to our attention the fact that, apart from 'normal' space, there exists also a phenomenon, the experience of which is shared by all human beings, called *logical/semantic space*: the space of all possibilities the human mind can conceive of, thus the space of the *imaginarium*. Hegel referred to it as the 'productive imagination', while the very term *logischer Raum* comes from Wittgenstein (1922). Let us consider for a moment Wittgenstein's conception of logical space. 'Logical space is a metaphorical device indicative of the totality of possible structural combinations of objects by which propositions map out reality', Sefler explains (1974: 67), expounding on Wittgenstein's claim that every proposition points to a certain location in logical space. Wittgenstein is truly metaphorical while claiming that *logischer Raum* is the 'infinite ocean of all possibilities', a repository for all that is imaginary, fictitious, virtual. The reader will have recognised that what we are discussing right now is the background for the possible-worlds theory of logicians and formal semanticists. Assuming that we believe in the presence of possible worlds (as I do) somewhere out there, the question which immediately arises is: Where can we find them? Leibniz, in whose *Discourse on Metaphysics* the theory of possible worlds has its roots, claimed that they exist in God's thought. If this statement sounds unpalatable to some, the option provided by the modern theoreticians of possible-worlds semantics says 'in

logical/semantic space'. This is the answer given, most notably, by Saul Kripke, who criticised the naïve or too realistic (as in David Lewis's theorising) 'telescopic' theory of possible worlds. Possible worlds do not exist on some distant planet, but as mental entities, artefacts of our creative imagination. Logical (semantic) space can thus be also called conceptual.[1] Possible worlds are located, then, in different regions of logical space and their distance (proximity, remoteness) from reality (the actual world) is measured by the so-called accessibility relation.

It is of utmost importance to realise that although logical space is a product of human intellect, it rarely becomes enclosed in the privacy of one specific mind. Logical space finds its expression and embodiment in language. If we did not have language at our disposal, logical space would remain hidden 'in one particular head' and its import for the mankind would be close to null. And so, despite the fact that logical space is fabricated conceptually, its basic medium is linguistic. Not without reason has it been also dubbed *linguistic space*. Consequently, we can describe it as a supra-individual, socially accessible semantic space, shared potentially by all users of a given natural language. The idea that interpersonal linguistic communication is possible only on condition we postulate such a non-private space has had a long tradition in philosophical semantics: it was already the *lecta* of the Stoics and – many centuries later – the *senses* of Gottlob Frege that were claimed to exist in such a shared space, which makes them direct ancestors of the denizens of the Wittgensteinian *logischer Raum*.

Lambert & van Fraassen (1970) created the semantics for modal logic, borrowing Wittgenstein's idea. The role of language is crucial again: a sentence points to a certain place in logical space; facts in logical space build worlds. What can be described as merely possible just now may become real one day. It is in this sense that we can treat logical space as highly promising in nature – though its tissue is probability, nothing hinders its sub-regions from crossing the border and one day becoming a part of our actual world.

The inhabitants of possible worlds are possible individuals, who can be arranged along the scale of accessibility (=imaginability, conceivability): from proximately (genuinely) possible, through merely possible to impossible ones in the most remote, non-normal

worlds, termed also, seemingly paradoxically, 'impossible possible worlds'. Lambert & van Fraassen's description (1970: 2) takes care of possible individuals (*entia imaginationis*): 'Associated with the language is a *logical space* in which each individual in the domain of discourse has a location. Each predicate is assigned a region of logical space …'. Lewis (1979) points out that modal operators transform this space. It is through the expression of modalities that we can affect the structure of logical space. Lewis includes propositional attitudes within the space-transforming modal operations. Whenever we cherish a specific propositional attitude, say a belief, doubt, wish, hope, etc., we locate ourselves in a specific region of logical space.[2]

Since, practically, throughout our entire lives we are bound to step in and out of our actual world (the 'distinguished' centre of the possible-worlds model according to Kripke, and the best among possible worlds in Leibniz's opinion) into the logical space of fictitiousness, hypotheticality, counterfactuality, non-factuality, etc., this crossing of the boundaries between the actual and the fictional puts a certain stress on us. Amnesiacs, the mentally disturbed, or notorious liars may fail to be fully aware in which region of logical space they actually remain. All of us have certainly experienced the dubious state of finding ourselves in the border zone that divides the dreaming and waking states (the 'crack in the universe', the area in between different worlds, exciting but potentially dangerous to our psychological well-being). Children up to the age of seven or eight are extremely prone to the danger of excessive travelling across logical space, across the space of their make-believe and fancy. M. A. K. Halliday (1973), who described the related function of child language under the label 'imaginative' ('let's pretend'), pointed out both to the educational dimension of this capacity and to its traps – pretence and deception, which may ultimately deteriorate into lying. It requires a lot of good will and tact on the part of the adults to distinguish children's fantasy and wishful imaginings from deliberate and mischievous lies, and to punish for the latter, but not the former. Halliday was right in stressing that this particular function detectable in the child's model of language does not disappear in later life: our ability to journey through logical space becomes, perhaps, more disciplined and controlled, but is never lost. If it were, we would never be able to indulge in practising literature, art and science.

The prototypical instance of a possible world is its realisation in imaginative literature, called also a fictional or represented world by theoreticians of literature. Novels are the most elaborate among such linguistically created worlds when seen as coherent sets of sentences that delineate a written space of text or discourse. The terminological confusion in the literature on the subject is considerable – thus *textual* or *discourse space* may mean different things for different authors and different approaches (cf. Enkvist 1989, Werth 1999). The very notion of *textual/discourse world* (or *space*) can be seen as a tamed, domesticated version of logicians' possible worlds. From the theoretical point of view adopted here, however, textual or discourse spaces (usually *written spaces*, but also *read* and *interpreted*) refer basically to the same chunks of logical space as possible worlds do.

No matter whether we dub a certain sub-region of logical space a possible world or a textual world, the most striking characteristic of such a construct is its *incompleteness* or *gappiness*, as compared with the reality in which we act. Whereas the actual world and actual individuals that people it are always complete, even *overdetermined* (the exhaustive set of features of even one individual is impossible to specify), the creations of our imagination in logical space suffer from *underdetermination*. It is in this sense that the well-known Polish phenomenologist Roman Ingarden ([1931] 1973) referred to works of literary fiction as to a certain degree 'empty' (he called this phenomenon 'image emptiness', as if anticipating the present-day cognitive approach to the imagistic properties of language).

The fact that logical space in its textual, fictional dimension is gappy when compared with ordinary space (which is always filled and which abhors a vacuum[3]) does not mean that the space of the imaginary is in any way handicapped. To the contrary, its incompleteness, which calls for a constant effort of *interpretation*, that is *gap-filling*, should be considered as its most exciting feature. The fact that we as interpreters are forced to exert conceptual effort in order to fill out the *lacunae* of indeterminacy in such a space combats boredom and makes *the game of gap-filling* in the space of the text well worth pursuing.

In Ingarden's theory the schematism of a literary work implies that gaps and underdefined regions of the textual space have to be completed by *concretisation* performed by every interpreter. In this way the so-called *paraspace of the reader/interpreter* is called to life,

which can be perceived as a complement to the *authorial space*. The *space of interpretation* is where the communication between the author/creator and the recipient of a given work occurs. The same procedure seems operative in the interpretation of fine arts and architecture. Faced with a sculpture, painting or an architectural construction, in spite of the fact that the degree of determination is much higher here than in the case of figments of imagination, we still have to rely on our subjective way of 'reading' works of art within an ordinary but particular space. And although the gappiness present in works of art located in physical space is much more limited when compared with the emptiness of fiction, we basically have recourse to the same gap-filling mechanism of interpretation, which is an important aspect of *social and cultural communication* among people. It is also in this sense that a painting, sculpture or a building (or their complex) can be viewed as a broadly understood text.

The belief in the gappiness (partial emptiness) of works of fiction reverberates in the writings of several authors. The theory of *opus apertum* of Umberto Eco (1990, 1992) includes the assumption that although in literature we have a possibility of several interpretations, some of them have to be rejected as false or mistaken. The danger of *overinterpretation* (of making incorrect moves in the game of gap-filling) is always with us. Eco's ideas agree with Ingarden's theory but go against certain vulgar versions of deconstruction, in which an infinite number of interpretations is argued for, and where all such interpretations are treated as equally plausible or correct (or else equally wrong, if we consider the slogan 'Every reading is misreading'). It seems reasonable to assume, then, that the process of gap-filling cannot proceed wildly but has to obey certain rules. Even Stanley Fish (1980, 1989), in whose opinion interpretation is an all-pervasive phenomenon ('the only game in town'), maintains that the space of interpretation must be constrained by means of appropriate rules.

A similar note resounds in Paul de Man's treatise on what I call *the game of critics* (cf. Chrzanowska-Kluczewska [2004]). De Man invokes here a kindred metaphor – every literary text possesses its *areas of blindness*: the reader and the critic coincide in their attempts to make the unseen visible. De Man warns us, however, that 'interpretation is nothing but the possibility of error'. No such trace of

pessimism can be found in Paul Werth's theory of Text Worlds. Werth defines a Text World as the space jointly built up by the author and the reader (or the speaker and the hearer in a spoken version of the same event). In my terminology this would amount to saying that the Text World is a region of logical space with its 'areas of emptiness' already filled in by the interpreter. Hence, it is the logical space completed, no longer 'cheese-like' in character. Werth claims that his Text Worlds are *ontologically rich* (unlike possible worlds of model-theoretic semantics, which he treats as austere). The entities in the Text World are not 'mere logical variables or even constants', but reflect human experience and boast several properties (they, for instance, cherish the same propositional attitudes as we, the actual individuals, do). I must add at this point a cautionary word: despite Werth's wish that his possible individuals be rich, they will never attain the complexity of actual individuals; likewise no possible/textual world can ever achieve the richness of the actual universe. Apart from the notion of Text World, Werth introduced also the concept of a *sub-world* (of an author, narrator, character, and of every propositional attitude as well, such as belief-worlds, wish-worlds, knowledge-worlds, etc.). The same idea appears in Eco's writings under the name of *small world*, pointing to the fact that we do not always need to deal with an entire universe, but may require smaller models as handier tools of our analysis. Werth's highest level of description, namely Discourse World, lies – for a change – outside the Text World: it is a real-life situation in which the text is being processed. Though a prototypical Discourse World is a face-to-face conversational exchange between the physically present participants, in the literary situation the participants very infrequently appear in a shared situation (Werth refers to it as a 'projected' Discourse World, targeted at a generalised, non-specific readership). It should be realised that the Discourse World is, in fact, the immersion of a chunk of logical space within ordinary social and cultural space of both the author and his interpreters.

The idea of the Discourse World as a combination of imaginary and real space comes close to Fish's concept of the *cosmos of literature.* This spatial metaphor includes, actually, the spaces of: (1) the text itself; (2) the author; (3) the reader(s); and (4) all genres, periods, styles, canons, etc. that stand in some relation to the text in question. We might add to this list the so-called *tropological space*, postulated

by Hayden White (1978), for whom all figures of speech (we might add: a reflection of the figures of thought), especially the major tropes, create also their own visionary and imaginative space.[4]

The same idea of gaps, *lacunae*, blind spots, lacks and cuts in the empty space of discourse, which gradually becomes completed can be traced in Michel Foucault's *Archéologie du savoir* (1969). The author refers to this feature of human discourse as the *principle of dilution*, where the field of possible formulations has not yet been made complete.

Not all theoreticians of literature have shared the belief (to which I also personally subscribe) in the inherent gappiness of texts/discourses. Suffice it to mention Maurice Blanchot (1955), who maintained that the act of reading neither changes nor adds anything to what is already there. This amounts to saying that the reader merely 'listens' to the work and that there is no dialogue between the author and the interpreter. If this were true and the space of fiction were never empty, the role of the reader would have to be reduced to that of a passive recipient. If, by extension, we applied the same theory to works of art in physical space, the viewer would have to become a dispassionate onlooker and the game of interpretation would come to a standstill, a highly unsatisfactory and frustrating situation. That's why I strongly support the idea of gaps in space and of the urge to fill these gaps in a reasonable way during the process of creative interpretation.

An important concept connected with both ordinary and logical/textual space is that of *perspective*. Actually, all our dealings with space are conducted from a particular vantage point. Yet, if in the case of physical space the perspective in question is basically of the same nature (physical), the situation grows in complexity while we move to the consideration of perspective in fictional space. Roger Fowler (1986) postulated a triple taxonomy of literary perspective: (1) physical (spatial and temporal); (2) ideological, connected with the author's/narrator's/character's system of beliefs, which can be either subconsciously or purposefully forced onto the reader; and (3) psychological, based mostly on the dichotomy of familiarity and strangeness.[5] The last type of perspective, highly subjective, can become – for instance – the perspective of estrangement, in which grotesque, hallucinatory, visionary, mystical, mythological, etc. elements will appear. The phenomenon of perspectivisation and of a

point of view has captured the attention of several philosophers (Ortega y Gasset [1923] 1931, Ingarden [1931] 1973), and linguists (especially within the cognitive framework). In this respect Ingarden rightly points out to the fact that in the course of every concretisation of an artistic literary work we have to remain aware of foreshortenings. Ingarden's warning holds, indeed, for any type of perspectivisation, be it within logical or physical space. The selection of a given perspective means always the omission of certain elements, a manipulation with data. It is well worth realising that even a most congenial point of view at a given situation conceals in itself a potential drawback of a slanted, skewed, oblique vision. Even the all-encompassing perspective of the Divine Eye is marred with the same disadvantage of assuming a specific stance on the matter.

The discussion of psychological/emotional/subjective perspective takes us beyond the framework of logical modelling. Logical space, with an infinite number of possible worlds hovering in it, has never been discussed in this personalised, subjective aspect. Not so with text and discourse worlds of literary semantics, where the human, hence often highly emotive, ingredient is naturally taken into account. Once the allowance has been made for this kind of approach to logical space, we can speak, after Gaston Bachelard (1957), of the *poetics of space*. Consequently, depending on the personal attitude of the creator and/or interpreter of literary space, we can distinguish the friendly space of positive emotions as opposed to the hostile space of hate, envy, etc. Bachelard lists also the space of conflict (the idea reappears in Foucault 1969) and fight, the space defended, cherished, extolled, owned, and, finally, the private (intimate) space, which we only very unwillingly share with other individuals.

Like perspective, which can hardly be separated from space, to which it inherently belongs, time – the second primordial experience of man – remains intertwined with space by means of ties which are not that easily broken. Similarly to physical space, textual space can only with difficulty be severed from time: repetitions of motifs, deviations from chronology (flashbacks and flashforwards) all create the spatial arrangement of time in fiction. Partly after the model utilised by relativity theory, where time becomes the fourth dimension, thus enriching a three-dimensional space, Jacques Derrida (1977) talks about 'time-oriented space' and 'space-oriented time' as nothing else

but *différance*, the crack, the fissure in every sign. This split and delay (thus, simultaneously, a spatial and a temporal notion) present in every linguistic sign, open up the game of senses, as well as the related space of *unlimited semiosis* (seen as an unconstrained play/game of signification and which I treat as a pathological game, see Chrzanowska-Kluczewska [2004]). Derrida has partially incorporated here the Heideggerian conception of *Zeit-Spielraum*, that is a unity of time and the space of the play of language, in which every sign can refer to an infinite, endlessly repeatable sequence of past, present and future signs.

Are space and time really inseparable? The findings of comparative linguistics seem to suggest that all languages possess verbal means of effectively describing space, which they use abundantly. Space appears to be a universally accepted medium of cognition, which is expressed across various families of languages in a fairly uniform way (the differences are not very striking). However, when it comes to a cross-linguistic analysis of temporal expressions, it soon turns out that natural languages do not accept a similar homogeneity in their treatment of temporal concepts. Thus space and time, though related, need not be treated as unconditionally inseparable, since languages do have a choice of a differential treatment of one or the other, with space being, apparently, a more stable element of linguistic expression.

Returning to the initial issue of potential differences in our dealings with conceptual/linguistic space as contrasted with physical space, let us ponder the way in which we interpret a three-dimensional piece of architecture or sculpture. The space submitted to our interpretation, like logical space, is always perspectivised. It seems to me that, despite its high level of determination (think about the number of details showered on us in a Gothic cathedral), a piece of art also possesses its ‘areas of blindness’. Each one of us has to contribute a certain amount of background knowledge, mainly cultural, in order to understand the spatial construct with which we are faced. *Contextualisation* and, if a monument of art is venerable in age, a *re-contextualisation* has to take place. The Hagia Sophia is an excellent example in this respect: if treated as an ‘architectural text’, it has to be given at least three distinct interpretations, all dependent on a historical and religious setting. It has to be ‘read’ as a Christian

basilica, a mosque, and, finally, a museum, open to interpretation to visitors coming not only from the Christian and Islamic traditions.

Thus, no matter whether we deal with a work of fiction or an object of visual arts, the same mechanism of gap-filling in the artistic space seems to be in operation, with the same traps of under- and overinterpretation lurking behind. The escape from a particular vantage point seems also impossible to achieve, for even if we consider an architectural work or a sculpture from different angles, we still are ensnared in a personal, subjective approach to this broadly understood 'text'.

It cannot be denied, however, that both conceptual/linguistic and 'normal' space, despite idiosyncrasies in interpretation, are spaces of social, interpersonal and intercultural communication. The fiction writer, the architect and the sculptor strive, ultimately, after some kind of negotiable understanding shared with their 'generalised readers' or 'generalised viewers', respectively. And although we have mentioned before the existence of *intimate/private space*, we cannot dwell too long within it. The child grows out of his/her *egocentric space* in the process of socialisation, while our idiosyncratic interpretations have to be checked against 'readings' provided by other addressees.

There is one respect, however, in which logical space – conceptual and linguistic at the same time – differs from the surrounding ordinary space: it is genuinely *infinite*. The space of all possible states of affairs/worlds has no limits: even if certain possible worlds become actualised, with the progress of science and technology, the pool of probabilities never dries up and is forever expanded by every consecutive individual, who enriches it with his/her imagination. Ordinary space, on the other hand, is usually closed. Cognitive linguistics, in which the radial model of prototypes is based on a spatial configuration (centre – periphery),[6] emphasises also the principle of closure. This is a reflection of the fact that human perception relies on closed, rather than open figures. The property of boundedness comes to the fore, e. g., in the definition of states as 'bounded regions in space'.[7] And although human language possesses several expressions (many of them metaphorical) that describe 'open spaces', 'vast horizons', 'infinite areas', these refer to creations of our imagination rather than an actual physical experience. Our universe, in all probability, is finite and our space is claimed to fold up at its

utmost fringes, yet logical space, with its prime exponent – the linguistic space of the imaginary and hypothetical – is never bounded. We should, then, feel proud that our conceptual apparatus and the supporting linguistic mechanism are endowed with a creative power far exceeding even the vastest stretches of the physical cosmos. Lotman ([1968] 1975: 249), while describing the artistic space of fictional literature, said that the function of fictional characters is to 'cross the boundaries which are impassable for others'. Logical and textual space manifestly enable us to challenge the boundaries of natural space.

Endnotes

[1]A terminological word of caution: logical space is much more powerful and inclusive than the 'mental spaces' of Fauconnier and Langacker, which are usually sentence-bound.

[2]Trans-world lines, which connect various possible worlds in logical space, indicate also that this space can be expanded or narrowed by movements of individuals – their departures and returns across the boundaries of alternative worlds or states of affairs.

[3]This finds corroboration in modern research in the field of physics, which inclines towards the claim that no vacuum can really exist and what seems empty to us is actually filled out with a slightly mysterious Higgs field.

[4]Richard Rorty said once that metaphors expand logical space towards new, as yet not described possibilities.

[5]An additional type of perspective has been postulated by White: the *figurative* or *tropological perspective* created by stylistic devices.

[6]Notice that it is also the model of possible worlds, with the actual world being the focal point, the point of departure to alternative universes.

[7]One caveat: the so-called mental spaces of cognitive linguistics should not be identified with possible worlds or even sub-worlds. Though a certain similarity exists between the two, mental spaces should, rather, be conceived as mediators between discourse (language) and reality, even the fictitious. Thus, mental spaces seem to stand halfway between logical space and language (cf. Fauconnier [1985] 1994).

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Winding Through Lynchville Highway: Challenging the Curves of David Lynch's *Mulholland Drive*

Ayşegül Gündoğdu

Abstract

In Kristevan terminology, *abject* is where meaning collapses, where a *non-I* threatens one's sense of self and sense of borders. Against this threat, abjection becomes a process through which the subject identity is constituted by excluding that which haunts borders. In this process, language and rationality are the basic protective shields against this horrifying void, but ironically, *abject* also has the potential for various new *creations* by challenging those shields. David Lynch's film, *Mulholland Drive*, also appears as a kind of abject potential with its nightmarish dream atmosphere of fractured narrative and elusive identities. In this way, it challenges ways of seeing and understanding that are traditionally taken for granted, and offers at the same time to the audience a chance to challenge its curves to go beyond them.

Key words: abject; absence; tension; horror; identity; meaning-making.

The Kristevan notion of abjection is the process of recognising and defining one's sense of who and where one is by setting certain boundaries between what can and cannot be one's self and life. However, 'abject' is neither an object nor a subject to be confronted against one's self and life; it cannot be formulated or differentiated as the *other*. This causes 'abject' to seem as a threat to borders, even to the idea of a border, because its *undifferentiatedness* resists systematisation, categorisation or naming. It therefore appears like an ambiguous, horrifying void that will swallow any existing border or identity and will haunt and *devour* the individual from then on. Against this dangerous 'vortex' (Kristeva 1982: 1), from infancy onward the individual uses language to establish his/her borders that define and determine who s/he is and what makes her/his life. In Kristevan terms, this substitution of language is primarily related to a sense of loss the infant experiences when expelled from maternal entity in the first place, and language becomes a means of substituting for that primal loss.[1] It is this loss that appears as the formless

ambiguity. Accordingly, in the face of this ambiguity, which is ironically at the very core of her/his existence, the individual tries to control the abyss by verbalising himself, his life, and his world. Thus, by expressing, naming and symbolising, one can feel secure because in this way one can establish, differentiate and define one's borders against the ambiguity that cannot be *me*, *him*, or *her*.

Kristeva, however, sees this effort as double-sided. While it is made to systematise and categorise in order not to fall into the void, the discourse of such an effort is also made up of 'breaks' (Kristeva 1982: 30) and fragments. Kristeva (1982: 38) writes of this discourse as that which we meet 'in our dreams, or when death brushes us by, depriving us of the assurance that mechanical use of speech ordinarily gives us, the assurance of being ourselves'. In a way, in those fractures and fragments lurking beneath our everyday language, which secures our sense of selves, resides the 'outburst of abjection' (Kristeva 1982: 47) waiting for deciphering and analysis if one can dare to confront the splits of one's discourse as well as of one's attempts to cover them up.

Thus it can be said that these splits, *fissures* in language, in discourse have the potential for opening a new path, a new composition, because they are like dark voids maintaining within themselves an unformulated and always elusive meaning. This elusive meaning keeps us from perceiving and understanding the world in the way we are accustomed to understand it because, instead of having reliable and fixed references, words may refer to and connote many different references. Thus, the events or the reality presented with these words cannot be easily taken for granted; rather, in this way the reality rests on an unstable ground. It is this instability that makes the formless form a potential of language. This potential does not necessarily offer unity and stability, but rather creates a tension – a tension that is not necessarily connected to opposing or being collapsed into what one *abjects*. This tension, instead of determining the borders, places the efforts and expectations to differentiate one's self in an unstable border zone or in a nightmarish dream discourse deprived of all secure borders where it is difficult to decide what is what. This border zone significantly blurs distinctions and its very instability is what may push the subject towards a more flexible attitude toward experiencing the splits as splits without immersing her/himself in them or obscuring

their surface so that they no longer seem *dangerous*. Similarly it might again be this instability that will drive the subject to see what is presented with many different perspectives.

Following this concept of the Kristevan abject, which oscillates between being a horrifying absence and a potential one, I will examine David Lynch's film, *Mulholland Drive* (2001), as a *border zone* offering a potential dark void. Similarly, I will argue that this potential is primarily related to a state of absence the film creates.[2] Absence is primarily in the form of the absence of presences, mainly in the loss of and search for identity. This absence on the one hand triggers the desire to construct a meaning that will at best have an always-ambiguous clarity in the film; on the other hand, however, this absence keeps *absenting* the possible existences of words or selves, frustrating that desire. This oscillating movement thus keeps the tension, the potential to challenge accepted notions and realities, and opens the way for possible new visions and interpretations. Tense, threatening and horrifying most of the time, this absence is where the film has that potential at its highest and is mainly provided in the film by the 'waking dream' state described by Lynch as the 'subjective thing … [where] [t]he essential ingredient is completely unable to be communicated' (Rodley 1997: 15). In the film, this situation is achieved by creating a state of drowsiness and not being able to wake up completely. Two essentials contribute most to creation of this state: the theme of identity confusion and search for lost identity, and the film's fractured and double structure itself. With these essentials this waking dream-state, too, is a border area between sleeping and awakening. Such an area blurs the line between where the real experience begins and where the experience is only a dreamed one and offers a *nightmarish* dream reality making the border between the real and the dreamed experience all the more vague, confusing and horrifying. The more confusing and vague the state gets, the more the reality of that state is blurred, making it seem as if there is nothing present and existing but just void and absence.

Early in the film, in Winkie's café, one of two men in the scene tells about his nightmare, describing it with the words 'it is not day or night, it is kind of half night'. His words almost define the mood of the film: it is not day or night; it is like a twilight zone or a borderline. Lynch uses this mood to suspend the film at a level where it seems

easy to analyse, but this kind of twilight state is where the film resists most strongly any coherent narrative analysis and logical interpretation. In providing this resistance, Lynch is able to create that threatening mood challenging definition by ordinary language and logic. In this way the film speaks *the abject discourse* and it becomes a *split* in the conventional narrative film tradition with a coherent linear narrative, clearly defined characters and development of story. Once *Mulholland Drive* departs from this style and is instead situated in this border state, what we have is not a single but a fractured double narrative, both parts almost exchangeable with each other. In addition to nightmarish waking state and fractured structure, Lynch, by shifting points of view in the film and by creating a temporal and spatial absence through the dream atmosphere, presents an absent yet a potentially unstable discourse that deprives the audience of reassuringly safe meaning and easily graspable identities. This deprivation provides the insecure ground where things presented and said are not what they seem and claim to be but where our assumed realities and ways of seeing things are challenged.

Absence begins at the very beginning of the film, with a scene of couples jitterbugging against an empty and unrecognisable background as if suspended in emptiness while their shadows move among them. This image makes these couples look as if they were emptied of themselves. Then, what gradually comes to be recognised as a smiling blonde with two other, still unrecognised, persons is superimposed on these jitterbugging couples. The scene does not provide any full-length bodies but just hollow, cartoon-like figures. Thus the existence of only traces of bodies is immediately implied in the film's opening scenes. In addition to these figures, a car crash shortly after the start of the film leaves some traces of possible existents as well. After rather a calm and silent view of the Los Angeles night skyline, this serenity is destroyed by violent, excited cries of some drunken teens who hit a limousine slowly moving on Mulholland Drive. A few seconds after the crash, a brunette woman gets out of the car; staggering towards the bushes near the highway she vanishes in darkness. The detectives, when they arrive at the crash scene, find no one in the limousine but only a pearl earring, which only suggests that there was possibly a woman in the car. In this manner, with the very beginning of the film, at least, two women's existence is only implied instead of being defined clearly. Such an

opening is already disorienting for an audience who expects some plot outline, hints about the characters, and an order in the development of events.

While ambiguity, mostly dark colors and evasive images/clues dominate these opening scenes highlighting the development of the Kristevan abject-like tense mood, *the story* proceeds in a fractured way, splitting the narrative. What follows the Winkie's café scene is one where a man, a Mr. Roque, sits in an armchair resembling a wheelchair in an empty room. He is informed that 'the girl is still missing' and the scene, taken together with the previous scenes, gives the impression that the missing woman is probably that brunette woman and some men are looking for her. However, this does not surpass being only an assumption because nothing specific or definitive is said about this missing woman. *The girl* as the absent abject center keeps being a primary issue when a film director, Adam Kesher, is forced to change his leading actress. He is shown a picture of an actress named Camilla Rhodes and is told 'this is the girl'. Actually, the whole film plays with the question of which character is which woman, but incessantly evades this question in effacing and rewriting their identities. This missing woman, on the one hand, and the amnesiac woman on the other become two ambiguous and shaky grounds upon which the story is built. In addition, this shaky ground is also the real provider of the film's abject language and potential.

Within this shaky ground of *Mulholland Drive* four significant events establish and intensify the film's abject potential. The first instance involves that brunette woman, who tries to find a shelter for herself and who tries to keep herself awake; in the second, the blonde woman and the brunette woman find a corpse; the third takes place in an empty theatre and it is there that the film finally takes its radical turn; it *splits* and starts almost all over again.

In the first scene, the brunette woman, after vanishing in darkness, reaches the city centre, hides in the courtyard of an apartment, and falls asleep. Then it is morning and a woman is seen moving from this apartment. The brunette takes shelter inside it and this time hides in the kitchen, again falling asleep. Actually she hardly manages to keep herself awake even for a few minutes. Even though she is not a reliable witness at such a condition to interpret or evaluate what goes on around her, the scene of Los Angeles after the crash, her walking

towards the bushes, her seeing the apartment and the woman who is moving are all presented from her point of view making the truth of these scenes questionable. In addition to this questionable ground, it is as if this lost woman has suddenly become invisible too. For example, when she is about to cross the street, a police car's lights brighten her face for a few seconds but no one in the car notices her. Similarly, the woman who is moving turns and looks back just at the moment the brunette is running up the stairs to the apartment, but she does not notice her either. This effect of invisibility increases the level of uncertainty in the scenes since it is not clear whether all she (the brunette) sees and does is in a dream from which she cannot wake up, or is in her awakened state. When she does finally manages to wake up she is an amnesiac, remembers nothing, not even who she is, and has only her purse with a blue key and large amount of money in it. An already lost and absent woman, she picks up the name Rita for herself from a photograph of the 1940's film star Rita Hayworth in the bedroom mirror and in this way creates an identity out of nothingness for herself.

From this moment on, the film appears to take the form of a mystery story, and identity confusion begins to develop with these women's search as it focuses more and more on the question of which one is which woman. The apartment where Rita hides is also where the blonde, Betty, will stay because Betty's aunt who is currently out of town lives in that apartment. Betty comes to Los Angeles to be a great actress, but when she discovers frightened and desperate Rita she decides to help Rita find who she really is. Their efforts to create something meaningful out of ambiguous and/or absent presences (an *identity-less* woman, a dead actress's picture and name, a pearl earring) continue in the same café, Winkie's, when Rita sees the name Diane on the name card of the waitress, she remembers a name, Diane Selwyn. Thinking that Rita might be this Diane Selwyn, or at least someone who knows her, Betty and Diane first phone Diane Selwyn's number. While calling Diane Selwyn Betty says 'it's strange to be calling yourself' and as she says this, ironically, it sounds as if she is referring back to herself, not to Rita. Another significant point is that the name is listed in the directory as *D.* Selwyn. The letter *D.* makes both the women and audience think that this is the first name of someone, but it is only a letter and its reference point is totally unknown. It gives the impression that it possibly refers to someone,

but it is not clear who that someone is, or even whether someone as the reference point of *D.* really exists. It is as if *D.* were a possible clue or a signifier to lead these women to some conclusion(s) /signified(s). However, there is no certain conclusion; the two women are dragged along to this ride along with the ride itself. This pattern is ironically similar to what the film does to its audience. The film seems as though it will lead the audience to a single decisive ending with these clues, as in a detective story, but it drags them along the ride during the following hours to show that the clues can be really risky. When the two women phone *D.* Selwyn, strangely, the answering voice says only, 'it's me', but it is not clear who that *me* is, the amnesiac Rita, or someone else. When Rita says that this is not her voice but of someone she knows, they go to the address of D. Selwyn. What is seen in the apartment is from the women's point of view and it is understood from the expression on their faces that there is an unbearable smell dominating the air. Then, still with the women's point of view, the audience is slowly led through the halls and barely lit corridor to a room where there is a woman's corpse on a bed half-covered with a reddish blanket that first appeared with accompanying sounds of heavy breathing at the beginning of the film, just before the car crash scene.

With this sight of the corpse, the point of view is no longer that of the women. It is as if when they were walking through the corridor, both of them were walking through the barely lit corridors of their minds, but now the audience is no longer in their minds' space. Rita is now almost paralysed and screaming, because, having thought that D. Selwyn could be herself, she seems to be confronting her own dead body, her ultimate decomposition. However, not only Rita but also Betty is also shocked at this sight in front of her. Both women try to exclude themselves from this scene in D. Selwyn's apartment, since that corpse is 'the utmost abjection' and the disorienting factor all by itself (Kristeva 1982: 4) to their living bodies and their existence. For both of them, as well as for the audience, this becomes the exact moment when, in Kristevan terms, death, both literally and metaphorically, brushes both the girls and the audience in the form of the corpse. Death, in Kristevan terms, is what 'infect[s] life', the utmost threat to borders since '[i]t is something rejected from which one does not part, from which one does not protect oneself as from an object. Imaginary uncanniness and real threat, it beckons to us and

ends up engulfing us'. (Kristeva 1982: 4) In their terrorised and perplexed state in front of this imaginary uncanniness and the real threat, all the women can do is to run from this encounter and leave the house immediately. In leaving the house, they dissolve into multiple images of themselves as if they are being peeled off and hollowed out, implying that it is not easy neither to part from nor protect themselves against the infecting discourse of death. Now they, too, look like those jitterbugging couples on a blank background. The letter *D.* now seems to represent something more than just a name; it is as if it has been signaling what awaits these women: the confrontation with *d*eath/*d*issolution.

Confronted with this discourse at the point of a brush with death, the audience is also stripped of its defence mechanisms, such as interpreting this scene in the usual mystery or crime-story format. For example, the interpretation that these women find a corpse and that they keep on trying to solve this murder mystery does not quite work: the corpse's identity and that of one of the women is not clear, and Betty's identity as she introduces herself are not clear either. To increase this ambiguity, it is not known from whose point of view the corpse is seen, Rita's or Betty's, or even whether this corpse can still be in the nightmare or imagination of Rita, who is still amnesiac. Such shifts in points of view in the corridor and room, and the dissolving image of the women, make what is presented all the more unreliable. The corpse is the disorienting factor all by itself. It is the body of a no longer existing person but it is a trace of *prior existence*. When Betty creates a whole passionate scene out of nothing at her audition, it makes everyone admire her acting skills, but the effort to create something out of this '*prior existence's* nothing' becomes the threat and the insecurity. Yet this 'almost-nothing-ness' and/or what seems like culminating in nothingness is what sustains any possible potential for any effort to make something. These presentations resist defining identities as well as what are being presented as clearly categorised secure entities. Instead, layers of identities and these presentations are peeled off to emphasise their elusiveness, their almost-nothingness and their resistance to being reliable references. Thus, the women's discovery of the corpse becomes another significant event enhancing the film's threatening absence and waking dream state.

This absence and the half-night state driving the film culminate in the *silent* performance of El Club Silencio where real and dreamy, fullness and void are completely incorporated into each other. That same night, when Rita starts murmuring *silencio* in her sleep several times in a mechanical voice with her eyes wide open, they go to this place. This is a theatre-like place of lip-syncing performance with a red stage. As the bearded illusionist of the Club says, 'there's no band' on stage but we still hear the clarinet, trombone and the orchestra play. At the same time, he keeps saying, 'it is an illusion. It is all recorded. This is a tape-recording. And yet we hear them'. As he says this, blue fog and stunning noises of a thunderstorm fill this *empty* place where the only performance is the performance of non-existence or the performance of voice only. It is as if the whole stage is a deep red void threatening to swallow up not only Rita and Betty but also the audience watching the film. In addition, the lip-sync performance of Rebecca Del Rio, in singing Roy Orbison's song *Crying* (*Llorando* in Spanish), which tells about crying over the loved one, becomes the most striking performance of all, emphasising the deep void ready to absorb everything in itself since she faints on the stage but her voice still continues filling the whole empty stage. When Betty starts shivering heavily as if she is about to fall to pieces and both of them seem very scared, it appears that the feeling of terror spreading from this theatre also arises from the possibility that both Rita and Betty might be from this great void or might be its representatives with their identities created out of nothingness.

Similarly, when they return home from D. Selwyn's house, Rita tries to cut her hair as if, in Kristevan terms, to 'eject' herself from the corpse who is supposed to be Diane (herself?). On the other hand, Betty's helping Rita cut her hair and giving her a blonde wig looks like her effort to absorb Rita. In both Diane's and Rita's actions, absorption seems like an effort to make interior what is outside or external (both Diane and Rita trying to devour each other), and the ejection is like an effort to externalise what seem to be the dangers within. It is as if in this way, both the externalised and the internalised layers of selves keep oscillating between incorporation into each other and exclusion from the other, challenging a clear border between the two. This leads to the frightening result that both their own and the audience's efforts to define and differentiate their borders will be in

vain, since void and fullness, and the movement between the two, keep lurking behind their terror and their efforts to stay stable.

Finally, the women's return home from El Club Silencio makes the fourth significant event one of looming absence. Their return from the club hints at the significant split that the film is about to undergo in the immediately following minutes; it is from this moment on that the film splits and makes a loop and, in addition to identity-confusion, the full implications of fractured and double structure enhancing the waking dream state are best seen with this loop. Before leaving the club, Betty finds a blue box in her purse. When they are back home Betty suddenly disappears altogether and Rita opens the blue box with the blue key found in her purse at the beginning of the film. The key picks the lock of the blue box and with the turn of the key, we are zoomed into the darkness of the blue box to find nothing as before when the box falls on the floor. It is as if the audience and Rita are literally sucked into a dark void and the blue key drags everyone to darkness. Also, the blue key found in the brunette Rita's purse meets the blonde Betty's blue box to create the devouring void, as if to prove that both can really be a part of that void from which they try to escape. After being lost in darkness, with a fadeout suggesting a possible lapse in time and/or in the characters' minds, we see the wall of the room and the same woman who was leaving the apartment when Rita was hiding in the courtyard. The woman looks around as if she heard a voice of something that has just dropped, but there is nothing on the floor where a few seconds ago the blue box has fallen. It is as if the blue box becomes the ultimate dark hole/dark void to absorb everything and it literally absorbs both girls because there is not the blonde Betty and the brunette Rita, as we know of them until now, anymore.

Suddenly, with this loop, it is as if all that was happening was an *illusion* or a *recorded reality* but it is not clear whose record or reality was this version. Following that, with a fadeout the same image of the reddish blanket re-emerges, along with accompanying sounds of heavy breath and heavy noises of knocking on a door. As the camera pans the bed and blanket, a woman lying there becomes clearer for the first time. A woman is lying on the bed in the exact position of the corpse that was in the apartment and apparently she has difficulty in waking up and pulling herself together despite knocks on her door.

This time, however, the one who cannot wake up is not Rita. She looks like Betty but she is not; as the neighbour knocking addresses her, she is Diane Selwyn in the exact appearance and figure of Betty. However, unlike the confident and energetic Betty who was in control of events, the same woman now appears as Diane looking very pale, tired, and desperate. Diane contrasts strongly with the first part's nicely dressed and lovely Betty. Also, Diane's almost empty apartment consisting only of basic furniture like a couch, a coffee machine, and a bed is in sharp contrast with the very nicely decorated, luxurious apartment in which she/Betty stays with Rita in the first part. On the other hand, the amnesiac Rita now appears as the sexy and *femme fatale*-like actress Camilla, who helps Diane get little roles in her films. In this way, characters and places are completely turned upside down, making all the more ambiguous the task of defining and framing what is being presented in a certain way. It is as if with that suggested lapse of time and mind the key made everything start again but whose mind experienced that lapse seems rather vague.

This abrupt change is like the spine of the film's fractured structure. Now, there is a film within the film, doubling *Mulholland Drive*. When Camilla asks Diane to go to a party on Mulholland Drive, the film almost restarts. As in the beginning of the film, the highway sign of Mulholland Drive flashes by in the dark again. A limousine is slowly driving on Mulholland Drive. The insecure, restless and timid Diane is now inside the limousine. This time there is not a car crash but instead the car stops, and Camilla leads her to a party. Making a double of the film in this way makes it feel as if after two-thirds of the road taken the audience goes all the way back to drive the entire road again by a circuitous and different route. It is as if the film closes in upon itself, which makes it seem both recursive and also ironically regressive. It looks as though *the real* story is lost among these contradictory or different versions of the story. It is not that the real story is lost or unavailable, however, but that there is no one *single real* story; rather, there are stories embedded within each other, resisting and challenging a strict division between them. As a result of the plot doublings and the sustained tension in a border zone, while the film on the one hand seems to peel off its layers and decompose itself, on the other hand these layers seem to be piled upon themselves for *recomposition*. In this way, the film's loop seems to bring, at least, two different versions of possible dream/reality stories, but actually

through this slight slip avoids completing either part and keeps the possibilities open.

Throughout the film, in addition to fractures in the story, jump-cutting between scenes also contributes to that dark absent state and the feeling of terror it spreads. There is a strong clash between the scene of the women's love-making, its lushness and thrilling thunderstorm noises, devouring blue fog and voices of clarinets and trombones out of nowhere on the empty blood-red stage of El Club Silencio. The bright, shiny and smiling face of the blonde woman at the beginning sharply contrasts with the following scene's darkness. The flashing sign of Mulholland Drive in darkness makes a contrast with the previous scene's hazy atmosphere where an unclear image of the reddish blanket is followed by a fade out. In all these scenes the nervous and tense expectation that any minute something is going to happen is intensified by Angelo Badalamenti's music. This tense expectation is also literally expressed in the film when Betty meets Louise, another resident looking more like a fortune teller who is somewhat out of her mind, in her aunt's apartment complex. Louise comes, knocking on the door in darkness, and asks Betty who she is. When she says that she is Betty, Louise replies anxiously, 'No, no it's not. Someone is in trouble. Something bad is happening'. Louise's words indicate the irony; Rita's identity is not clear, Betty's identity totally changes in the following hours, and something *bad* happens to both women when they find the corpse.

In addition to clues like D. and Louise's words that deceive rather than lead, violent scenes, which usually contribute to states of horror and tension, are mostly in an absurd form in *Mulholland Drive*. This makes explicit violence all the more non-violent, seemingly non-threatening and therefore quite uncertain and misleading. The best example of such violence occurs when Adam Kesher starts hitting (with a golf club) the car of the men who force him to choose their actress. The absurdity is heightened when Adam finds his wife with another man in their home. The first thing he does to punish his wife is to pour pink paint all over her jewellery and then end up in pink himself, in his car, broke and beaten by the other man. Similarly, his wife tries to defeat a fat and huge man who is looking for Adam by jumping on his back making him lose his balance. Instead of this absurd violence, it is often the sense of insecurity and uncertainty that

gives the film its disorienting substance. This uncertainty meets Adam the director, too, in the form of a man named The Cowboy. He appears out of nowhere in a barn-like place with the skull of an ox and a classical Lynch prop, the flickering light. The Cowboy comes from darkness, speaks to Adam about the choices Adam can make, and disappears with the fading light leaving him sort of confused.

Uncertainty continues in the fractured structure of the *post-split* section of the film. The characters from the first part, like Adam and Coco, appear again, but they are in different positions now just like Betty/Diane and Rita/Camilla. Coco is the owner of the apartment complex where Betty stays, but again, at Camilla's party she is introduced as Adam's mother. During this party Diane tells her life story to Coco, a very different and desperate story than that of the aspiring Betty's. Her story is presented in flashbacks and there are abrupt transitions among these scenes. Adam's position is also changed; he is first introduced in the film as the director who must choose the leading actress according to the wishes of some thugs in the industry. At Camilla's party he is her fiancé and they are possibly about to announce their marriage decision. Then, immediately after this scene where Diane sees Camilla whispering with Adam, Diane is in a café, same as Winkie's, paying a man a large amount of money to kill an actress called Camilla Rhodes. The man shows her a blue key to be left at her home to indicate that the deed is done. In a final scene, we see Betty/Diane staring at a blue key on the table. As the zoom on her one eye gets closer, in frenzy, she sees the elderly couple, whom we see arriving at Hollywood with her and wishing her good luck, coming under the door as tiny little creatures. Gradually, they become human size and continue attacking her. Under the influence of this delirium she lies on the bed and shoots herself. For the last time we have the same image of the bed with the reddish blanket and the same image of woman lying dead on the bed. There is the blue fog again and it dissolves into darkness to be replaced by the blue light. On the view of Los Angeles are superimposed the faces of blonde Diane/Betty and Camilla/Rita in her blonde wig and the blue-haired and grotesque-looking woman sitting at the balcony of El Club Silencio closes the film, whispering 'silencio', leaving more questions unanswered in the end than there were in the beginning.

In the end, it seems that each woman is writing about herself and reading into the other woman, but each woman's version of herself is interrupted/*split* by each one's seeing herself in her representation, which is not the best possibility imagined. The part before the split is like a nightmare for Rita and in this part Rita sees and reads into both herself and Betty. What she sees and reads into is like a nightmare for herself but a happy dream for Betty, i. e., in the best case Betty would possibly want to see herself and to be seen. In the post-split section, on the other hand, the audience sees and learns what is happening from Diane's point of view; Diane watches Camilla, and now Camilla's position as the successful actress giving small roles and letting Diane come to the sets with her is superior to Diane's timid and insecure attitude.

Through such a twist in the film, the sense of daily and temporal reality is suspended and correspondingly these images sustain the film's stay in the border zone. This border zone affirms neither us nor our expectations for clarity of meaning; instead it locates both the self and its *secure* language and the means of communication in *absence* to *(dis)order* meaning and our meaningful selves and expectations. The film gives the impression that it invites its audience to challenge its twists and turns by managing to be open to this state of absence and instability. Furthermore, when *the woman* until then known as Betty suddenly gets up as Diane it becomes more ambiguous which dream and/or heavy sleep belongs to which woman and which *dream* is *real*. This play of identity-confusion, acted out in this heavy waking dream state, is disorienting and unstable because it *includes* and/or it *is* something that is not *that something*. Finally, the blue-haired woman's whisper 'silencio' as the closing remark of the film can be taken in two ways. Such an ambiguous closure can be interpreted, firstly, as a call to participate in the film's potentially abject *horror*. Secondly, and also ironically, it perhaps functions as a soothing sign comforting the audience: 'the tension is over. You can go back to your safe places, you are safe and secure now'. The audience must choose.

If limits of absence and presence, reality and illusion, help one to define one's sense of who one is, winding through the serpentine Mulholland Drive may bring one not only to his/her deepest fear of losing control of borders and meanings but also to overcoming the fear of confronting and challenging these same borders and meanings.

On an empty stage the possibilities of getting lost and of also getting started all over again play concurrently. Maintaining the tension that emerges from this possibility might be threatening and horrifying, but it might also be the way to confront and challenge this film without falling into the trap of reducing it to a mystery or horror story. Through fracturing us, creating an ever-elusive meaning and decomposing the unified sense of ourselves, *Mulholland Drive*, instead of clinging to one solid texture, might force us towards a new place where *meaning* might collapse in the creation of new vision(s) if we are open to them.

Endnotes

[1]The Kristevan *abject* and *abjection* are highly related to the maternal and mother but, for the purposes of my paper, I will limit my discussion of *abject*. My discussion, as I relate 'abject' to *Mulholland Drive*, primarily focuses on its equally important place in the construction of one's sense of who one is and construction of meaning in the language one uses. In this way, I try to concentrate more on the definitive workings of abject as a process in human lives rather than concentrating on femininity and the abject relation, and then relating this to the film's focus on two female characters.

[2]Nochimson (2004) offers illuminating ideas on *Mulholland Drive*. She explains that in this film *the woman* or *the female* becomes a locus of disintegration because the possible energy that could have emanated from *the woman* yielding creativity and positive transformation is destroyed by sinister unknown powers. These unknown powers confront both Betty and Adam in the Hollywood cinema industry, which gives precedence not to creativity but sheer power. The thugs who force Adam to choose their *woman* as the lead and Mr. Roque's giving orders and waiting for news about *the woman* in his empty room represent destructive powers killing the chance for positive transformation in these people's lives. Nochimson adds, however, that the ending in 'silencio' keeps many questions alive, and it is for the audience to deal with these questions, perhaps the most important of which is this very complex ending in El Club Silencio with its blue-haired woman.

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The Boundaries of Narrative: The Problems, Possibilities, and Politics of Accommodating the Lyric Mode in Narrative Fiction

Nil Korkut

Abstract

Lyric and narrative are two distinct literary modes that are often hard to reconcile. They were, however, brought together especially in the kind of fiction that was widely produced in the early 20th century by writers like Virginia Woolf, who were highly interested in recording the elaborate thought processes and feelings of characters in an almost 'poetic' style. Works produced in this fashion are called 'lyrical novels' or 'lyrical short stories', suggesting that in such cases the boundaries of narrative fiction are extended to include and accommodate the lyric mode. This kind of labelling, however, is not without its problems. It is often possible to come across works of fiction whose lyrical aspects are so dominant that it is no longer possible to reconcile them with the basic defining characteristics of narrative. Such works may be said to challenge the boundaries of narrative fiction by *appearing* to be primarily narrative in mode but refusing at the same time to be categorised and subsumed under the title 'narrative'.

This paper focuses on those boundary cases in which the lyric mode refuses to be dominated by and subsumed under the narrative mode. Taking as an example Virginia Woolf's short story, 'The Mark on the Wall', the paper looks into how far the boundaries of narrative can be extended to accommodate the lyric mode. In addition to demarcating the boundaries of narrative fiction, such an analysis, it is hoped, will shed light on the politics of resisting narrative as the only dominant mode in a work of fiction.

Key words: lyric, narrative, literary mode, boundary, Virginia Woolf, 'The Mark on the Wall'.

In 'The Margins of Narrative: The Very Short Story, the Prose Poem, and the Lyric', Gerlach (1989) draws attention to significant problems concerning the nature and definition of narrative. He starts by explaining that 'demarcations between modes of narrative, and between genres themselves, are not firm' and then goes on to ask the following questions:

> When do we finally reach the minimum unit of story, that is, a free-standing, complete, and satisfying prose fiction? Might a story even become something else – a poem, for instance? If that is possible, do such discriminations ultimately matter? Are we likely to look at a work differently if it is, or is not, a story? (Gerlach 1989: 74)

Such questions may be asked for almost all literary works that we categorise as 'narrative', but they become even more relevant and significant when we encounter '... samples of narrative in borderline cases' (Lohafer 1989: 58) – that is, when we encounter works that we still label as 'narrative', but not without a certain sense of discomfort. Typical examples for such works are 'novels' and 'short stories' teeming with lyrical qualities, such as those commonly produced in the early 20th century by writers like Virginia Woolf, who aimed at presenting the elaborate thought-processes and personal feelings of characters in a style that could almost be called 'poetic'. The easiest way to categorise these works is to call them 'lyrical novels' and 'lyrical short stories', but such labelling may not always prove accurate. Calling a work a 'lyrical short story' implies that the work in question is primarily a 'short story', which in turn implies that it is primarily narrative in mode. The assumption, then, is that the lyrical aspects of this work have been subsumed by the narrative and that they can only be approached as secondary features 'colouring' the work. Such an assumption, however, prompts a significant question: What if the lyrical 'qualities' of this short story are so strong and pervasive that it becomes impossible for the narrative mode to accommodate and subsume them? In other words, what happens if the lyrical mode in this work resists being dominated by the narrative mode?

This paper aims to look into such questions by analysing a quite typical example of what is usually called a 'lyrical short story' – 'The Mark on the Wall', written in 1917. This is one of Virginia Woolf's first experimental short stories, and it is a good example of a 'borderline case' in which the lyric and narrative modes come together.[1] The story begins with the first-person narrator noticing a mark on the wall. As she asks herself what the mark might be and whether she should get up and see what it is, a sequence of thoughts is triggered in her mind. In a way, the mark serves as a tool to prompt other thoughts, which stray in various different directions as a result of free association. Moreover, during her contemplation, the narrator

keeps returning to the mark from time to time, only to stray from it again. In the end, the thought-process of the narrator is interrupted by the appearance of another character who addresses the narrator by saying, 'All the same, I don't see why we should have a snail on our wall'. The narrator now knows that the mark on the wall is actually a snail, and the story ends.

As the foregoing summary also suggests, this story is almost entirely made up of the description of the highly personal and subjective feelings of the first-person narrator. The story begins with an 'event' (noticing the mark and wondering what it may be) and ends with an 'event' (learning what the mark is with the help of another character's words), but the space in between these two 'events' is entirely filled in with the narrator's contemplation amounting to a sort of reverie. It is quite apparent that this story employs both the narrative and the lyric modes. The question, however, is this: does the narrative mode in this story accommodate and subsume the lyric mode, or does the story instead present an example of a hybrid made up of two modes, neither of which completely dominates the other? In other words, is it possible to treat this 'short story' as a primarily narrative work? Trying to answer such questions will probably yield a better understanding of the modal status of this short story. More importantly, however, this attempt will provide an insight into the boundaries between narrative and lyric by considering the theoretical as well as the practical problems and possibilities of accommodating the lyric mode in narrative fiction. Such a discussion, it is hoped, will also provide some food for thought as to the politics of resisting narrative as the only dominant mode in a work of fiction.

The basic Aristotelian division between drama, epic, and lyric appears to inform our understanding of literary modes; and these in turn help us to form our ideas about the characteristics of literary genres. The more modern approach, of course, is to replace the term 'epic' with 'narrative', hence drawing attention to the fact that 'narrative' is the basic mode of representation of epic as well as of other forms like the novel, which are generally believed to have evolved out of the epic form.

Within this division, what initially comes to mind as a major problem between narrative and lyric is the argument that the former is a representational while the latter is a non-representational mode. In

other words, like drama, narrative may also be said to involve the imitation of action; however, this is not the case for lyric because normally the lyric involves the *true* expression of a poet's feelings. This has two implications. First, through the lyric mode, the poet is providing a true and sincere account of his own feelings, and therefore is imitating nothing; and second, there is, after all, no action to imitate because all the lyric mode describes is a state (of feelings, emotions, etc.). It is often the case that this discrepancy between narrative and lyric creates important problems of reconciliation, especially when the two modes come together in a single literary work.

'The Mark on the Wall' exhibits some of these problems of reconciliation. There is, of course, not much of a problem in calling the 'events' in 'The Mark on the Wall' representational. The story introduces a fictitious narrator who notices a mark on the wall, wonders what it is, talks to another character and, through the information he gives, finds out that it is actually a snail. So far, all this can be regarded as an accurate imitation or representation of a real-life incident.

A problem gradually emerges, however, when we begin to consider the constitutive aspect of this story, namely the fictitious narrator's expression of her personal thoughts and feelings. In the case of thoughts and emotions, there appears to be no action to imitate; therefore, such descriptions cannot be called 'imitative' or 'representational'. Of course, a theoretical solution to this problem would be to argue that this time, what is being imitated is a state of mind rather than events and actions. Gérard Genette's discussion of the views of the 18th-century critic, Abbé Batteux, on the problem of mimesis in lyric poetry is rather illuminating in this respect. Batteux's argument consists in the possibility of referring to lyric poetry as an imitative art:

> '... lyric poetry enters naturally and even necessarily into imitation, with but one difference to characterize and distinguish it: its particular object. The main object of the other species of poetry is actions; lyric poetry focuses completely on feelings: they are its theme, its chief object'. (Qtd. in Genette 1992: 32)

Batteux, then, believes that lyric can also be considered an imitative mode, but that it differs from drama and narrative only in the object it imitates: the lyric poet imitates feelings rather than actions. According to this argument, it is possible to reconcile narrative and lyric with

respect to the problem of mimesis. Any piece of narrative includes a narrator and characters, and these are all fictitious – i. e., they are examples of imitation. If the narrator and characters are fictitious, their feelings and emotions are also fictitious – i. e., their feelings and emotions are also examples of imitation. Within the context of this fictional world they have nothing to do with the author's true feelings. Here, then, we have an example of how the narrative mode can accommodate the lyric mode as regards the problem of mimesis. Within this model, a narrative that puts a great deal of emphasis either on its narrator's or on its characters' thoughts and emotions (i. e., a narrative work that makes ample use of the lyric mode) can still be said to engage primarily in imitation, this time more of feelings than of actions.

This appears as a rather useful model, but still it may not always serve to reconcile narrative and lyric. Here is another dimension of the problem: what is usually meant by the representational quality of narrative is its tendency to imitate reality – i. e., its tendency to provide an *accurate* representation or imitation of real-life incidents and characters. Such accuracy is almost impossible to attain in the lyric mode. A character's highly personal expression of his feelings can hardly be referred to as the 'accurate' representation of reality. Similarly, it is hard to equate feelings and emotions with external events, regarding them, too, as 'realities' to be imitated.

The same problem applies to 'The Mark on the Wall'. The bulk of the story is made up of the highly personal and subjective contemplation of the main character. Amid such subjectivity, it is almost impossible to talk about qualities such as mimesis and realism. Virginia Woolf's aims as a writer are also quite indicative of this. Broughton (1993: 44) explains how Virginia Woolf was influenced by Roger Fry's ideas on art and representation:

> Since 1911 Roger had been telling Virginia that art should be ... judged by criteria other than correspondence or fidelity to life. In 'Art and Life' (1917), he clarified this notion of art's autonomy: 'if we consider this special spiritual activity of art we find it no doubt open at times to influences from life, but in the main self-contained' ... . During this same period Virginia Woolf at last seriously took up Roger's 1911 challenge to 'fling representation to the winds' ... . Her problem was discovering how prose fiction could become non-representational ... . She began by writing 'The Mark on the Wall' ... .

Woolf herself, then, intentionally tried to produce works whose representational status would be questionable. This, of course, inevitably led her to employ in her writings the lyrical mode, which as we have seen is rather hard to think of as 'representational'. The few external events of the story can be considered representational, but the rest of the story is characterised by being non-representational. The narrative mode in this story, then, cannot very well accommodate and subsume the lyric mode in this respect.

In *Narrative Fiction: Contemporary Poetics*, Shlomith Rimmon-Kenan ([1983] 2002) defines narrative fiction as '… the narration of a succession of fictional events' and explains that it is precisely this quality of narrative that differentiates it '… from other literary texts, such as lyrical poetry or expository prose' (Rimmon-Kenan [1983] 2002: 2). This points to another major discrepancy between the narrative and lyric modes. By definition, narrative requires some action and events to narrate; in other words, it requires a plot. The idea of plot, however, is alien to lyric, which is mainly concerned with the description of a state of mind. In 'Thoughts on Poetry and its Varieties', John Stuart Mill also hints at this distinction between the narrative and lyric modes: '... [the novel] is derived from incident, ... [poetry] from the representation of feeling' (Mill 1973: 65). Theoretically, it may be possible to reconcile this aspect of lyric with narrative by arguing that the thought-processes of a character can also be narrativised, or treated as 'event'. Consider, for example, a character who is able to reach some sort of conclusion as a result of his contemplation. If, in Bal's terms, 'An event is the transition from one state to another state', (Bal 1992: 5) such a character may also be said to have experienced an 'event' because he has passed from the state of being confused about a problem to that of having found some sort of solution to it.[2]

It should not be forgotten, however, that such reconciliation can work only to a certain extent. For one thing, the contemplation of a character does not necessarily entail the 'transition' from one state of mind to another. Often the thought-processes of a character may appear in such a chaotic and mixed-up form that it may become impossible to treat them as 'events' that can be narrated. Furthermore, when a work contains a very small proportion of 'events' compared to the thoughts and emotions described, it becomes very difficult to

engage in a meaningful discussion of plot as a significant narrative element in that work. In such cases, then, narrative and lyric emerge as two modes that are very hard to reconcile.

'The Mark on the Wall' exhibits the conflict between narrative and lyric in this respect, too. The 'plot' of this story can be summarised as follows: the first person narrator sees a mark on the wall, wonders what it is, experiences a small internal conflict between whether to go on contemplating or to get up and see what the mark is, and eventually learns – through another character's remark – that the mark is a snail. At first glance, this plot appears to surround and subsume the individual contemplation of the narrator. In that sense one may at first be led into thinking that here the narrative mode (characterised by the plot) dominates the lyric mode (characterised by the narrator's reverie).

A more careful analysis of the story, however, reveals that this is probably not the case. In 'The Mark on the Wall', the 'events' summarised above assume a very insignificant role when compared to the narrator's reverie, which makes up the bulk of the story. The 'event' of noticing the mark and wondering what it is serves simply as a tool to prompt various thoughts and ideas in the narrator's mind. During her contemplation, the narrator occasionally returns to the mark, but she never dwells on this issue persistently enough to find out what the mark may actually be. In fact, the narrator does not even appear to be genuinely interested in finding out about the mark.

In a similar vein, the reader, too, gradually loses interest in the mark as he/she is carried away by the narrator's train of thought. The 'event' of noticing the mark, therefore, does not even lead the reader to ask what will happen next. In a way, this 'event' is pushed into the background to be replaced by the much more important thought processes of the narrator. In other words, the 'event' in this story does not present a 'thematic magnitude' (Gerlach 1989: 79). At the end, the narrator is engrossed in her reverie to such an extent that it is quite a surprise to her to be reminded of the mark on the wall by another character.

The reader's situation is not much different. He, too, is surprised to return to the issue of the mark right at the moment when he is about to forget all about it. Broughton, then, is right in arguing that this story

denies us '... plot, characters, complications; it thereby forces us, with the narrator, into detached contemplation' (Broughton 1993: 45). The theme of this story has almost nothing to do with the mark on the wall. Understanding the theme can only be possible through an analysis of the narrator's train of thought and the nature of the issues she dwells on. Probably that is why Christopher Reed argues that, in this story, '... the focus is far more on the narrator ... than on the snail' (Reed 1993: 26).

All of this indicates that, especially with respect to the problem of plot and action, the lyric mode seems to prevail over the narrative in this story. It is even possible to regard the narrator's stubborn refusal to get up and see what the mark is as an epitome of the conflict between the lyric and narrative modes in the story. On first noticing the mark, she considers getting up to find out what it is, but she quickly dismisses the thought:

> But for that mark, I'm not sure about it; I don't believe it was made by a nail after all; it's too big, too round, for that. I might get up, but if I got up and looked at it, ten to one I shouldn't be able to say for certain; because once a thing's done, no one ever knows how it happened. Oh! dear me, the mystery of life; the inaccuracy of thought! (Woolf 1944: 36)

Later on, she provides even further justification for her unwillingness to find out about the mark:

> No, no, nothing is proved, nothing is known. And if I were to get up at this very moment and ascertain that the mark on the wall is really – what shall we say? – the head of a gigantic old nail, driven in two hundred years ago, which has now ... revealed its head above the coat of paint ... what should I gain? – Knowledge? Matter for further speculation? I can think sitting still as well as standing up (40-1)

It is clear that the narrator of 'The Mark on the Wall' prefers contemplation to action. And it seems to be this preference of hers that allows the lyric mode in this story to gain ascendancy over the narrative mode. This should not be very surprising, of course, given the fact that Virginia Woolf's aim as a writer has always been to record the intricate and elaborate thought-processes of characters rather than external actions.

'Time' is another element that draws attention to an important distinction between the narrative and lyric modes. Most often, narrative implies the existence of some temporal distance between the act of narration and the narrated events: 'Common sense tells us that

events may be narrated only after they happen ("ulterior narration") ...' (Rimmon-Kenan [1983] 2002: 90).[3] The lyric mode, on the other hand, often implies no such temporal distance. The lyric persona is usually situated in the present and creates the impression that he is speaking or singing at the same time as he is 'feeling'. In other words, the experiencing of emotion and talking about that experience coincide. Moreover, it is hard to think of either the lyric persona or the various characters he introduces in his contemplation '... as people in a narrative, people to whom things happen under the pressure of time' (Gerlach 1989: 83).

It is again possible for narrative to accommodate this aspect of the lyric mode to a certain extent. An important indication of this is the fact that 'ulterior narration' is not the only possible form and that there also exists a kind of narration that is 'simultaneous with the action' (Rimmon-Kenan [1983] 2002: 91). In his study of the modern psychological novel, Leon Edel discusses 'time' in the following way: 'We are no longer in time past, in that "once upon a time" which most story-tellers use. It is nearly always here and now in subjective fiction. The reader reads the thoughts and the senses at whatever moment they are thought and sensed' (Edel 1964: 200). All this appears indicative of the possibility of reconciling lyric to narrative in this respect, but still it is always safer to assume a more sceptical stance. Narrative may tolerate the 'here-and-now' aspect of the lyric mode to a certain extent, but a work that puts too much emphasis on this aspect of lyric would still pose significant problems regarding its generic status.

In 'The Mark on the Wall' Virginia Woolf employs 'time' in such a masterly way that the work exhibits both a narrative and a lyrical time pattern. The story starts off looking like a rather conventional narrative that is going to be told in the past tense. The narrator describes when and how she first saw the mark on the wall:

> Perhaps it was the middle of January in the present year that I first looked up and saw the mark on the wall. In order to fix a date it is necessary to remember what one saw. So now I think of the fire; the steady film of yellow light upon the page of my book; the three chrysanthemums in the round glass bowl on the mantelpiece. Yes, it must have been the winter time, and we had just finished our tea, for I remember that I was smoking a cigarette when I looked up and saw the mark on the wall for the first time... . The mark was a small round mark, black upon the white wall, about six or seven inches above the mantelpiece (Woolf 1944: 35-6).

The way the story begins, then, creates the impression that there is a temporal distance between the narrator and what she is narrating. Her use of the past tense to refer to the time when she first saw the mark and of the present tense to refer to her present attempt to remember that past event are indicative of this. As the story proceeds, however, there occurs a gradual change in this tense pattern. This is so subtle that only a close reading of the text reveals it. I quote below the section that immediately follows the section quoted above:

> How readily our thoughts swarm upon a new object, lifting it a little way, as ants carry a blade of straw so feverishly, and then leave it ... . If that mark was made by a nail, it can't have been for a picture, it must have been for a miniature – the miniature of a lady with white powdered curls, powder-dusted cheeks. ... A fraud of course, for the people who had this house before us would have chosen pictures in that way – an old picture for an old room. ... But for that mark, I'*m not* sure about it; I *don't believe* it was made by a nail after all, it'*s* too big, too round for that. I *might* get up, but *if I got up and looked* at it, ten to one I *shouldn't be able to say* for certain; because once a thing's done, no one ever knows how it happened (Woolf 1944: 36, emphasis added).

The italicised sections above mark the gradual shift in the story's tense pattern. The use of the past and present tenses to refer to the mark on the wall are subtly intermingled, and from this point on the narrator fully employs the present tense, creating the impression that she is relating her thoughts at the same time as she is thinking them. The temporal distance created at the beginning of the story no longer exists. From this point to the end of the story, the narrator's references to the mark on the wall as well as to other issues are all in the present tense: 'And yet that mark on the wall is not a hole at all. It may even be caused by some round black substance, such as a small rose leaf, left over from the summer ...' (37). Similarly: 'I must jump up and see for myself what that mark on the wall really is – a nail, a rose leaf, a crack in the wood?' (41). All this indicates that the story begins with the usual time pattern of narrative, but this is gradually replaced by the time pattern of the lyric mode. It should also be mentioned that the use of the time pattern of lyric is much more pervasive in the story when compared to that of narrative.

Still another important difference between the narrative and lyric modes is their conception and treatment of the 'addressee'. Rimmon-Kenan's statement about narrative is very revealing: '… the term *narration* suggests ... a *communication* process in which the narrative

as message is transmitted by addresser to addressee …' (Rimmon-Kennan [1983] 2002: 2). One of the fundamental features of narrative, then, is the emphasis it puts on the narrator's role as a communicator: narration is carried out with the concept of a narratee or addressee in mind. In other words, by its very nature, the narrative mode takes account of an addressee who is listening to or reading what is being narrated.[4] Northrop Frye's classification of literary forms according to their 'radicals of presentation' also points to this aspect of narrative. Two of the four forms he introduces are 'epos' and 'fiction',[5] which both have 'narrative' as their mode of representation. The definition he provides for each of these indicates how both forms take account of the addressee: '… I use the word "epos" to describe works in which the radical of presentation is oral address ... . Epos thus takes in all literature, in verse or prose, which makes some attempt to preserve the convention of recitation and a listening audience'. Similarly, Frye uses the word 'fiction' to refer to '… the genre that addresses a reader through a book … [i. e., through] the printed page' (Frye 1957: 248). Narration, then, has the aim of communicating a narrative to a reader/listener. This aspect of narrative is not shared by lyric, however. Here is how John Stuart Mill explains the position of lyric in relation to the addressee:

> … the peculiarity of poetry[6] appears to us to lie in the poet's utter unconsciousness of a listener. Poetry is feeling confessing itself to itself, in moments of solitude, and embodying itself in symbols which are the nearest possible representations of the feeling in the exact shape in which it exists in the poet's mind. (Mill 1973: 71)

Frye's remarks about lyric are similar. To him, the radical of presentation of lyric is characterised by '… the concealment of the poet's audience from the poet'. Frye goes on:

> The lyric poet normally pretends to be talking to himself or to someone else: a spirit of nature, a Muse, … a personal friend, a lover, a god, a personified abstraction or a natural object. The lyric is, as Stephen Dedalus says in Joyce's *Portrait*, the poet presenting the image in relation to himself ... . The poet, so to speak, turns his back on his listeners ... . (Frye 1957: 249-50)

The above discussion makes it rather clear that 'indifference towards the listener' is one of the fundamental characteristics of the lyric mode. Unlike narrative, lyric does not take the addressee into account: the lyric persona has no listener in mind while he is expressing his innermost feelings. Here, too, the contradiction between narrative and lyric is apparent, and it seems rather hard to reconcile the two modes

in this respect. Of course, one may argue that the narrative mode's inevitable dependence on the narrator largely does away with this problem of reconciliation. That is, even if the text puts a great deal of emphasis on the description of the personal and subjective feelings of the characters, it still does so through the medium of a narrator, who by definition is a figure that has a narratee in mind.

Similarly, even if it is the narrator himself who is engaged in a highly subjective expression of his own state of mind, he is still in the position of a narrator who is trying to *communicate* his feelings to an addressee. Such an argument may look plausible, but only to some extent. When the narrative and lyric modes come together in a literary work, it may well turn out that the above-discussed aspect of lyric is so dominant as to change – at least to a certain degree – the narrator's position with regard to the narratee. In other words, the 'narrator' in a text like this may engage in the expression of either his own or the characters' minds in such a way that it may soon become impossible to define him as a figure whose major aim is to communicate a feeling, an action, an incident, etc., to a narratee. In the case of first-person narration, the narrator may appear in a state of individual contemplation without any interest in communicating with an addressee. In the case of third-person narration, he may hand the task of focalisation almost entirely to the characters – hence minimising his role of addressing a narratee. A debatable question, of course, is whether it is still possible to call such a figure a 'narrator' and hence to attribute to him the role of taking the addressee into account.

In 'The Mark on the Wall' it is again possible to observe this contradiction between narrative and lyric. The story starts off creating the impression that it has a proper 'narrator' who is interested in communicating an event, an idea, etc., to a narratee. As the story proceeds, however, the narrator gradually abandons this characteristic of hers, becoming instead more like a lyric persona who is engaged in the expression of her personal thoughts and emotions without the concept of an addressee in mind. It is interesting to observe that at the beginning of the story the narrator uses language in a rather coherent and intelligible way, explaining when and how she first saw the mark on the wall.[7] Here, then, the narrator seems to take account of the reader's[8] ability to understand her well enough. However, as the story proceeds and the narrator delves further into her own feelings, her

language loses most of its lucidity. It is as though the reader's ability to follow her thoughts no longer interests her. Her 'narration', if it can still be called one, becomes fraught with ambiguities and abrupt shifts from one train of thought to another. The following quotation is one such example out of many:

> And yet that mark on the wall is not a hole at all. It may even be caused by some round black substance, such as a small rose leaf, left over from the summer, and I, not being a very vigilant housekeeper – look at the dust on the mantelpiece, for example, the dust which, so they say, buried Troy three times over, only fragments of pots utterly refusing annihilation, as one can believe. (Woolf 1944: 37)

It is interesting to observe how the narrator crams into this short paragraph so many ideas, neither of which is directly relevant to the others. Since the 'narrator' no longer has an addressee in mind, she does not take the trouble to relate her thoughts in an organised manner. Instead, she presents them in the disorganised and even chaotic way they occur to her. Most of the story, of course, is made up of this kind of 'narration'. This discussion again makes it clear that in 'The Mark on the Wall' the narrative mode is not always dominant and pervasive enough to subsume the lyric mode. On the contrary, it is sometimes the case that the lyric mode gains ascendancy over the narrative mode. All this, of course, points to the impossibility of labelling 'The Mark on the Wall' as a primarily narrative work. The more proper approach, instead, seems to be to regard this work as a hybrid made up of two equally dominant modes.

In *Virginia Woolf and the Problem of the Subject*, Minow-Pinkney explains that Woolf was dissatisfied '... with the very principle of narrative fiction' (Minow-Pinkney 1987: 49). 'The Mark on the Wall' clearly reflects this sense of dissatisfaction. Woolf's use in this story of the lyric mode as pervasively as (and sometimes even more pervasively than) the narrative mode is an indication of her attempt to come up with new and more effective ways of expression in fiction. This, actually, is a concern shared by many modernist writers, who, like Virginia Woolf, believed that fiction should primarily aim at recording the thought-processes of characters rather than external events. As Woolf herself argues in 'Modern Fiction', 'Life is not a series of gig lamps symmetrically arranged; but a luminous halo, a semi-transparent envelope surrounding us from the beginning of consciousness to the end' (Woolf 1953: 154). And this 'luminous

halo', which is outside the boundaries of representation, external action, and clock time, can only be expressed through the lyric mode. Pure narrative would definitely remain inadequate for such a purpose.

Modernist ideas about the aim of fiction, then, can account to some extent for resisting narrative as the only dominant mode in a work of fiction. In the case of a woman writer like Virginia Woolf, however, the issue has even further dimensions. As Susan Stanford Friedman explains, 'Woolf's attacks on plot and plotting in her essays and novels imply that opposition to narrative is a cornerstone not only of modernist method, but also of the new women's writing she envisioned' (Friedman 1989: 162). Especially in *A Room of One's Own*, Woolf expresses her belief that the female writer should definitely develop her own style if she wants to prove her creative potential. And the feminine style she has in mind again has close affinities with the lyric mode. It is as though Woolf expects women writers to create their own style by simultaneously employing and resisting the narrative mode. The inclusion of the lyric mode within narrative, of course, serves this purpose very well, and it not only helps to create a feminine style of writing but also exposes the shortcomings of narrative as the only dominant mode in a work of fiction.

Endnotes

[1]The following discussion questions the generic status of 'The Mark on the Wall'. It should therefore be remembered that throughout this paper the use of the term 'short story' to refer to 'The Mark on the Wall' is for the sake of convenience only. In other words, within the context of this paper, referring to 'The Mark on the Wall' as a 'short story' does not necessarily mean that the work is considered to be primarily narrative in mode.

[2]Mr. Ramsay in Virginia Woolf's *To The Lighthouse* may provide a relevant example. In his famous contemplation about reaching the letter R, he is initially quite put out and even enraged by his inability to reach R. Towards the end of his contemplation, however, we see him gradually coming to terms with the fact that he will never be able to reach this letter after all – hence the transition from one state (of mind) to another (Woolf 1927: 53-7).

[3]Ulterior narration is not the only possible form of narration, however. 'Anterior narration' ('narration which precedes the events'), narration which is 'simultaneous with the action', and 'intercalated' narration ('when telling and acting ... follow each other in alternation') are other possible forms. These are, however, employed much less frequently when compared to 'ulterior narration' (Rimmon-Kenan [1983] 2002: 90-1).

[4]This of course does not mean that there are always 'personified narratees' in narrative works. It simply means that narratees are '... as indispensable to narrative fiction as narrators ...' (Rimmon-Kenan [1983] 2002: 104).

[5]The other two are 'drama' and 'lyric'.

[6]Mill's use of the word 'poetry' is equivalent to what is commonly called 'lyric poetry'. In that sense, what he says may be applied to the lyric mode as well.

[7]The section from the story quoted on p. 173 is an example of such coherent use of language.

[8]The distinction narrative theory makes between 'narratee', 'implied reader', and 'real reader' does not seem relevant within the context of this study. That is why the terms 'narratee' and 'reader' are used interchangeably here.

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Engaging the Other in the Self: The Bodily Experience of Virtual Imagery

Binnie Brook Martin

Abstract

This essay examines the western viewer's philosophical transformation into visionary and participatory spectatorship. This transformation occurs from the viewer's apprehension of pluralistic image possibilities by the convergence of virtual and actual expressions.

Contemporary literary paradigms must interact in equity with other cultural and intercultural images. In analysing approaches to multicultural expression, scholars in the visual field seek to elide the hierarchising of the so-called categories of subject, object and observer to connect with diverse cultural images without the oppressive, linear and naturalised approaches of western humanism.

The coalescence of virtual and actual aspects in filmic images represents a means by which the viewer may link the essentials of his or her particular context with those of characters in different national, cultural and geographical locations. In *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil* (1999), the Senegalese film director Djibril Diop Mambéty constructs a visual doubling of virtual and actual aspects of images, suggesting new boundaries of image apprehension that extend the accessible, assimilated images of the actual to include the visionary and imaginary musings of the virtual. This convergence invites semiotic expedition and development of a participatory spectatorship. The resulting contemplations transform the western viewer from all-knowing passive observer to creator of links and mediator of signs that serve a larger human continuum.

Key words: virtual imagery; multisensorial experience; distanciation; self-actualisation; social binaries; interaction in equity.

This paper examines the western viewer's sensory experience of selected Senegalese images. I look closely at how the emphasis on sensorial filmic relations incites new contemplations of otherness between the viewer and the viewed. In Djibril Diop Mambéty's *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil* (*The Little Girl Who Sold the Sun* [Mambéty 1999]), virtual expression, generated by shots rich with sensory material, creates palpable image textures and responses. What is special about these textural, visual, and aural palpabilities is the

invitation they offer to the western viewer to participate with image otherness, located in the self. This participation is motivated by Mambéty's production of virtual imagery developed by shot compositions that draw upon the senses. The virtual aspect of an image, as Gilles Deleuze intimates, occurs when unexpected elements in shots disturb standard image templates and responses. Therefore, the emergence of virtuality in an image is an opportunity to rethink image relations and the connections that have been temporarily suspended from western humanist applications (Deleuze 1989: 54).

In *The Skin of the Film: Intercultural Cinema, Embodiment, and the Senses*, Marks (2000) presents a persuasive study of the multisensory contribution that the body makes to the visuality (and virtuality) of the filmic image. Marks foregrounds the sensorially evoked dimensions of an image, especially the sense of touch (followed by smell, taste and sound). She explains that the nonvisual faculties of sight bring forth the viewer's complete sensorium, which in turn invokes new contemplations in image relations. Thus, the bodily serves as a dominant means of creating relational tangibilities with the moving image narrative.

The importance of creating relational opportunities between the western viewer and the nonwestern subject cannot be overstated. The medium of film has so successfully washed over the mainstream viewer – countless negative associations and misconceptions of the African character – that the reductive, master/binary templates of the African subject are difficult to correct. To counter these erroneous associations, the emphasis on the senses, or rather, getting in 'contact' with the filmic image, is one means of breaking down such oppressive thought patterns. 'Touch', Marks states,

> plays a part in vision. Since memory functions multisensorially, a work of cinema, though it only directly engages two senses, activates a memory that necessarily involves all the senses. The understanding of the embodied experience of cinema is especially important for representing cultural experiences that are unavailable to vision. (Marks 2000: 22)

The 'cultural experiences unavailable to vision' of which Marks speaks concerns subjects that have been too alienated and othered in dominant modes of cinema to be encountered cinematically on equal terms. In other words, the western viewer is overly accustomed to associating, for example, the African female – as bare-breasted decoration and as secondary object – so that it is difficult to see

beyond this stigma and to consider the image as a subject. In response to these damaging associations, Mambéty designs high sensorial content and expression, which in turn produces virtual imagery situations. He achieves this agenda by using *mise en scene* designs and high distanciations, which challenge the western viewer's regular tendency to observe the African image with passive, either/or assumptions of otherness. The tactile effect created by these designs shifts the western spectator into the contemplative domain of participatory and visionary spectatorship. This transformation occurs from the viewer's apprehension of pluralistic image possibilities in the convergence of virtual and actual expressions. Emphasis on the virtual produces a viewer-image interaction that brings about multisensorial connections to the image. Consequently, the bodily connections feed the viewer-image interactions based on the heightened consciousness and contemplation of otherness located in the spectator's self.

In *La Petite*, director Mambéty tells the story of an adolescent girl from Senegal called Sili Laam. Sili embarks on a seemingly insurmountable journey, from rural to urban realities, in hopes of supporting her family. One attribute singularising Sili's journey is her severe physical handicap. With a brace on one leg and two prosthetic canes, Sili walks to the edge of her home village, Tomato Town. She pauses as though to say goodbye, then leaves for Dakar. 'So I can feed my family', she states. Sili first tries begging in the street. She sits in a row with other disadvantaged ones and asks for money. Then Sili eyes a group of boys in the streets selling newspapers to passersby. In overlapping voices, they yell, 'The Sun! The Sun! The Sun!' As scrolls of newly inked paper spin before the viewer's eyes, Sili announces in voice-over to her grandma: 'I'll go find work tomorrow and sell "The Sun" [the city newspaper.] What boys can do, girls can do too', she cries. Herein lies the central plot of the story. Sili becomes the only girl working amidst a throng of streetwise boys, and in so doing, breaks code with longstanding social, gender and class traditions. At first, Sili's social defiance appears lofty given her physical condition. The rigorous physical demands of the job look impossible. Sili's legs and small body look so fragile against the fast-paced activity in the inner city/industrial sprawl.

However, the possibility of feeling pity for Sili quickly gives way to faith, as Mambéty represents the heroine in numerous contexts of

singular power. For instance, the emphasis Mambéty places on Sili's mobile activity maintains the viewer in a constant state of confronting and processing the singular bodily articulations of her disability. The spectator's repeated confrontations with Sili's small walking body, complemented by her formidable disposition, magically transcend societal dos and don'ts. The constant processing of Sili's movements not only allays the viewer's fears of Sili's abilities, but also involves the spectator in Sili's efforts to self-actualise in a difficult, fast-moving world. In fact, the participatory perceptions of Sili also provide opportunity, in the process of looking, sensing and self-reflecting, for the western viewer to self-actualise by contemplating the embodiment of associations encountered during his or her mimetic response to the sensory image. Sili works with confident aplomb to sell 'The Sun' even though she faces seemingly impossible injustices: the newspaper boys threaten her, bully her, and make off with her canes; a policeman falsely accuses her of stealing money earned from selling 'The Sun'; even onlookers behold her and pause, completely mystified, that she, a small crippled girl, would undertake such an unusual feat of physical work. Sili journeys on, confronting such conflicts with disarming self-assertion. She stands up for her rights against unjust *de facto* rules. But Sili refuses to accept the role the world has assigned her, as 'a little crippled girl who can't do anything but beg'.

The following passage by Gilles Deleuze states the political context germane to the analysis of virtual imagery in *La Petite*:

> The death-knell for becoming conscious is precisely the consciousness that there is no people, but always several peoples, an infinity of peoples, who remain to be united ... in order for the problem to change. It is in this way that third world cinema is a cinema of minorities, because the people exist only in the condition of minority, which is why they are missing. (Deleuze 1989: 220)

In *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil*, virtual memory associations link people to people. The so-labeled minority voices of which Deleuze speaks come into view rather as vital, primary peoples of primary subjects and singular expressions. Although the main characters represent those whom Deleuze refers to as the 'missing', the corporeal memories engendered by virtual imagery sound the bell for 'becoming conscious' of unheard voices. The independent yet communal expressions in the people of *La Petite* ignite the western viewer's awareness of naturalised perceptions that assign name-tags of

inequality to the so-called minority representations. When the viewer encounters the characters in this film, the virtual memory-links associated with the images develop two kinds of spectatorial responses: (i) they suspend the social binaries grounding minority and majority power relations; and (ii) they ignite the viewer‘s consciousness of him-or-herself as an active mediator of those relations. In virtual image apprehension, the viewer creates links with peoples and contexts in the Deleuzean sense, which are founded in sensory correlations. These links force the viewer to confront the hierarchising tendered in mainstream representation of Senegalese peoples. Speaking overall, sensory relations and the bodily contact they invoke open the viewer’s pre-scripted associations and interpretations of the subject by bringing to consciousness core beliefs harbored in the self.

In examining the missing, unseen people, I want to look closely at the following footage in *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil* and the spectator‘s bodily participation with distanciated shots of virtual sensory production. One of the richest series of tactile, virtual imagery involves Sili, her grandmother, and the working children of the community. The cinematic representation of such characters, ordinarily seldom portrayed in central roles, becomes the focal point of the narrative. After a businessman buys all of Sili’s newspapers, Sili takes the money and buys thoughtful presents for those close to her. First she buys her blind grandma an umbrella to shade her from the sun. The grandma sits on the side of a street each day where she must beg for a living.

Instead of showing Sili handing the umbrella to her grandma, Mambéty composes shots of multisensory visuality to make the meaning of the gift and the social environment more physically tangible. Framed from a high angle, the scene shows the grandma sitting against a wall with the sun hitting her face. The viewer senses the radiating heat and unrelenting glare from the sun. Then slowly from the right, shade arrives; a shadow begins to emerge, dimming the right tip of the frame. Out-of-field, Sili is imagined to be placing the protective umbrella above her grandma. However, the umbrella is never seen; it is simply felt. Sili’s action and presence are not seen; they are simply felt. As the shaded area gradually grows, it gently covers the grandma’s face and body. The shadow softly touches her

face, and as it grows, the viewer responds sensorially to the arresting act of kindness, which also by mimesis touches the viewer. The spectator senses the thankful relief, the love and comfort of the gesture, and thereby the physical gift of shade, bathing the grandma. Images of multisensory complexity compel the body to inform the mind in such a way that the senses of touch, smell, and sound engage image relations more than the one-dimensional sense of sight. In doing so, the western spectator is summoned to interrelate the layered expressions and communal experience of love, hardship, family, and shelter in the spirit of momentary connectivity rather than the linear product of a Senegalese 'scene'.

At the same time as the sensorial compels participation, it also compels arrest. The emphasis placed on the senses takes away the ordinarily exclusive focus on narration and interpretation of the scene. As a result, this suspension prevents the viewer from assuming identification with or appropriation of the event, the grandma or Sili. The distanciation that also sustains these shots invites the viewer to engage in the image composition without, however, engaging in image acquisition. Instead the sensory exchange predominates over the production of signs by suspending the virtual quality of the physical expression through the tactile.

Here Mambéty relays the dearness of Sili's gift by embodying the expression of the umbrella as a gift of shade. He achieves this message through a physically tangible expression instead of a sensory motor action. Consequently, Mambéty facilitates a visuality that engenders the 'listening' sensibility of the body. Before achieving the intellectual consciousness of the image, the viewer mimetically relates the outdoor elements with their tactile associations to shade, coolness, relief, and loving gratitude. By mimesis the observer contemplates the quotidian duress exhibited in the heat, the glare, and sensation of dehydration. However, because of the virtual quality of the images, the viewer is precluded from assuming exclusive knowledge of the grandma. The narrative distanciation keeps the grandma's subjectness intact. Once again the spectator responds by physical contact with the image. This contact evokes an inner focus on the viewer's own culturally embedded memory associations. As a result, the considerable gap between the spectator's memories of master (western subject) and binary (nonwestern other) categories and the empowered

expression of the Senegalese subjects become a conscious one. In this way, a heightened awareness is achieved in that the sensorial faculties of the intellect connect more singularly the weight of the grandma's quotidian reality and its representation of communitarian ideology. These images show a communal plane, in which compassion manifests as a necessity that binds together the community. The interdependent expression of one person linked to another, of Sili linked to her grandma, of the viewer sensorially linked to this exchange, demonstrates the cohesiveness that may exist between the viewer and the viewed, as a supple cohesion of the whole.

After giving her grandmother the umbrella, Sili shares her earned money with other children of the area. She initiates a celebration in the street with dance and music. And for herself, she buys a bright yellow dress to wear for the party. Sili and other street kids dance to music from a boy's community boom box. Framed in medium-long distance, Mambéty establishes an interesting series of virtual shots in which the viewer 'dances' with the children. As the lively music plays, Sili and the others dance in a line, moving down the street. The boys and girls power-dance to a celebratory Ivoirian pop song. Sili's chin is high; her sun-yellow dress and body animate the music in energetic rhythmic step. The children dance freely in a forward motion, moving individually, collectively, and communally, as the onlookers who stand on each side watch and thereby participate in the happening. As Sili dances with the others, her body and canes carry with her the representation of the community of young and poor people who are seldom seen represented as anything but the outside.

In *mise-en-scène* style, the line formation of the children positions the spectator as another one of their viewing audience members. However, unlike those who observe the dance from the sides, the viewer actively enters the scene, face to face with the boys and girls. As the adolescences look indirectly toward the screen, they make vibrant steps, moving forward down the road, in rhythm with the music and dance. When the dancers move forward, Mambéty pulls back the frame. Again and again, the children dance, moving forward: also, the camera ever subtly shifts backward in rhythmic response to the children's movement. The movements are slight enough so that the viewer at first does not see the dance, but feels it. Thus in aural, gestural and visual syncope, Mambéty devises a dance between the

viewer and the children. The giving nature of the exchange expresses an affectionate spirit between the children and the dancing spectator that is absolutely exhilarating. The dance involuntarily incites intimacy triggered by the viewer's sense of touch from being touched. The sensorial contact with the embodied space invites a reciprocity that, like Sili and her grandma, manifests a communitarian sharing of expression, a sharing, which in the generosity of the composition, actively includes the spectator. The depiction of the grandma, Sili, and the children expresses peoples who are conventionally not given a voice in mainstream representations. The sensorial articulations that dimensionalise vision produce an interaction that illumines the giving, productive voices of the old, the poor, the disadvantaged and the young – all voices who constitute the Dakar community in the most significant of ways.

In today's complex global realities, it is vital that cinematic paradigms of thought seek ways to interact in equity with other cultural and intercultural images. Academics in the visual field must examine approaches to multicultural expressions so as to elide the hierarchising and otherising in the so-called categories of subject, object and observer. The goal in mind is that the viewer from a western-based culture may connect with diverse cultural images without exercising the linear, oppressive, and naturalised application of western humanist ideas. In *La Petite vendeuse de Soleil*, viewer-image relations are manifested from a virtual site of expression and participation. These relations evolve from an interactive looking and collaboration, incited by the audio-visual experience in the body. The caring depictions of the little heroine Sili, her bodily movements and exchanges with the community, thin out the cultural prescriptions of the African subject. Contemplations in the virtual domain invite sensory relations that above all connect the viewer to associations of otherness in the self.

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What Can Literature Do for Linguistics? Metaphorical Synonymy and Distant Cohesion in James Joyce's *Ulysses*

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Abstract

Through analyses of selected passages from James Joyce's *Ulysses*, this article demonstrates how the challenging of the boundaries between linguistics and literary studies can be more than a one-way process aimed at uncovering linguistic patterns of literary texts. The theoretical basis of the article is Halliday & Hasan's concept of cohesion as presented in *Cohesion in English* (1976). While demonstrating the usefulness of Halliday & Hasan's approach in literary analysis by uncovering aspects of Joyce's extensive use of cohesion as a meaning-making resource, the application of their approach to Joyce's novel at the same time points to useful adjustments of the concept. It is thus argued that just like more regular examples of synonymy proper, metaphorical relations between lexical items that are usually semantically far apart are cohesive, too, as are ties that stretch over considerably longer passages than those typically considered in analyses of cohesion. While arguing for certain extensions of Halliday & Hasan's cohesive categories, the article simultaneously acknowledges and discusses methodological problems involved in such extensions and furthermore considers the upper and lower limits of cohesion.

Key words: Halliday & Hasan's concept of cohesion; lexical cohesion; metaphorical synonymy; distant cohesion; upper and lower levels of cohesion.

1. Introduction

In literary stylistics, linguistic models are typically employed for the purpose of shedding light on literature. It is the aim of this article to demonstrate how the crossing of the traditional boundaries between linguistics and literary criticism that we see in literary stylistics may furthermore provide us with new insights about the linguistic model applied for analysis. I will do so by discussing Halliday & Hasan's concept of cohesion in a literary context, which leads me to suggest useful extensions of the concept.

In what follows, I will focus on two areas that are given little or no attention in *Cohesion in English* (Halliday & Hasan 1976), but which

nevertheless stand out as significant in the analysis of longer literary texts. With examples from Joyce's *Ulysses*, I will first argue for the inclusion of *metaphorical synonymy* in Halliday & Hasan's cohesive categories, since metaphorical ties clearly play a role in the creation of texture. Secondly, I will point to the need to differentiate between the type of cohesion that creates local texture by tying nearby sentences together and cohesive ties that occur across fairly long stretches of text. This finally leads me to discuss the upper and lower limits of cohesion.[1]

2. Lexical cohesion

In their groundbreaking work on cohesion, Halliday & Hasan (1976) eminently demonstrate how sentences combine into text, and hence how textness – or texture – is created by means of different linguistic resources. *Cohesion* refers to the way a text is glued together by means of the text-internal ties of conjunction, reference, ellipsis, substitution and lexical cohesion.[2] The focus of the present article will be on lexical cohesion, of which the main sub-categories are those of reiteration and collocation.

It clearly ties a text together when certain lexical items are reiterated as the text develops, whether in the form of simple repetition, synonyms, antonyms, class/sub-class or the like. Similarly, words that collocate, i. e. tend to occur together, like 'novel', 'page', 'chapter' and 'plot' also participate in the creation of texture. Like conjunction, reference, ellipsis and substitution, lexical cohesion obviously occurs in literary as well as non-literary texts, yet the analysis of the former text-type in particular indicates that it may be fruitful to operate with a somewhat broader concept of lexical cohesion than that sketched out by Halliday & Hasan.

2.1. Metaphorical synonymy

In the introductory chapter of James Joyce's *Ulysses*, for example, we see how a number of lexical items and their various referents clearly help to tie the text together and thus create texture, while at the same time they also construe a fairly complex pattern of meaning.[3] In the first page of the novel, we meet a minor character, Buck Mulligan, who is performing his morning toilette. With his shaving bowl in his hand, Mulligan makes fun of rituals belonging to Catholic mass:

> (1) Stately, plump Buck Mulligan came from the stairhead, bearing a bowl of lather on which a mirror and a razor lay crossed. A yellow dressinggown, ungirdled, was sustained gently behind him on the mild morning air. He held the bowl aloft and intoned: – *Introibo ad altare Dei*. (p. 3, ll. 1-5, emphasis added)[4]

Later in the chapter, one of the novel's two protagonists, Stephen Dedalus, looks at the shaving bowl, which makes him think of another bowl from a completely different context, namely the boat of incense from his time at the Catholic school, Clongowes, where he was an incense-bearer:

> (2) Warm sunshine merrying over the sea. The nickel shavingbowl shone, forgotten, on the parapet. Why should I bring it down? Or leave it there all day, forgotten friendship?
>
> He went over to it, held it in his hands awhile, feeling its coolness, smelling the clammy slaver of the lather in which the brush was stuck. So I carried the boat of incense then at Clongowes. I am another now and yet the same. (p. 10, ll. 306-12, emphasis added)

Between these two references to Mulligan's shaving bowl is another 'bowl'-reference, which seems related to the former. Having been informed about the religiosity of Stephen's mother, her urgent desire to have Stephen pray for her on her deathbed, and Stephen's absolute refusal to do so, the reader is presented with Stephen's dream about her:

> (3) Stephen, an elbow rested on the jagged granite, leaned his palm against his brow and gazed at the fraying edge of his shiny black coatsleeve. Pain, that was not yet the pain of love, fretted his heart. Silently, in a dream she had come to him after her death, her wasted body within its loose brown grave-clothes giving off an odour of wax and rosewood, her breath, that had bent upon him, mute, reproachful, a faint odour of wetted ashes. Across the threadbare cuffedge he saw the sea hailed as a great sweet mother by the wellfed voice beside him. The ring of bay and skyline held a dull green mass of liquid. A bowl of white china had stood beside her deathbed holding the green sluggish bile which she had torn up from her rotting liver by fits of loud groaning vomiting. (p. 5, ll. 100-10, emphasis added)

At this early point of the narrative, Mrs. Dedalus is mainly characterised in terms of her religious faith and her vomiting. Religion and bile are what come out of her and are thereby drawn together figuratively. In addition to the effect of the mere repetition of the lexical item, 'bowl', the fact that the quotation is framed by references to Mulligan's shaving furthers the establishment in the reader's mind of some sort of connection between the shaving bowl and the bowl into which Mrs. Dedalus did her vomiting. If the religious

connotations of the shaving bowl initially established are thus transferred to Mrs. Dedalus' vomiting-bowl, the negative connotations of the latter in return transfer negative meaning to the former and to the concept of religion represented by it.

Altogether, a complex pattern of meaning is established here by means of the textual resource of repetition. Of particular significance is the repetition of the lexical items 'bowl', 'mother', and 'green'. In (3), for instance, two mothers are referred to and a significant contrast established between them and the characters who perceive them. While Mulligan quotes Swinburne's praise of the sea as 'the great sweet mother' (according to Thornton 1968: 12), Stephen recalls a dream-vision of his own mother's reproachfulness, her 'wasted body', and her breath's 'faint odour of wetted ashes'. That a connection does indeed exist between the two images is strongly indicated by some of the cohesive ties in the latter part of the passage. Consider the local texture of the following three sentences:

> (4) Across the threadbare cuffedge he saw the sea hailed as a great sweet mother by the wellfed voice beside him. <u>The ring of bay and skyline</u> held a dull green mass of liquid. A <u>bowl</u> of white china had stood beside her deathbed holding the green sluggish bile which she had torn up from her rotting liver by fits of loud groaning vomiting. (p. 5, ll.106-10, emphasis added)

In the second sentence, the author's choice of Theme ('The ring of bay and skyline') immediately suggests to the reader that here we are being given more information about 'the sea' of the preceding clause. The connection between these two sentences and the third is more obscure, however. On the face of it, a 'bowl of white china' has nothing to do with the sea or the bay and may puzzle the reader, yet the tense shift from simple past to the past perfect of the succeeding Process ('had stood') indicates that we here have a shift in time and thus possibly also in setting and subject matter. When we reach 'her deathbed' of the Circumstance in our process of reading, we realise that the sea is no longer referred to and that the referent of the feminine pronouns of this sentence must be Stephen's mother instead. The motivation for this shift of focus is suggested by the repetition of the lexical item 'green', which is the strongest cohesive tie between the two sentences. The green colour of the sea simply reminds Stephen of the green bile vomited by his mother before she died. While the repetition of 'green' holds the strongest cohesive force

between the sentences in question, a certain parallel exists more generally between all the constituents of the nominal groups in which this colour occurs. Thus 'bile' is a kind of 'liquid', and 'dull' and 'sluggish' may be interpreted as partly synonymous adjectives. Both nominal groups express Stephen's perception of things and contrast sharply with Swinburne's view of the sea presented by Mulligan. The reader is thus likely to sense the possible metaphorical parallel between – and hence, I will argue, the cohesive force of – the 'ring of bay and skyline' and 'bowl'. This parallel is made explicit later in the chapter when the bay is referred to from Stephen's perspective as 'a bowl of bitter waters' (p. 8, l. 249) – an image echoing that of Mrs. Dedalus' bowl of bile and a far cry from Swinburne and Mulligan's 'great sweet mother': 'A cloud began to cover the sun slowly, wholly, shadowing the <u>bay</u> in deeper green. It lay beneath him, a <u>bowl</u> of bitter waters.' (p. 8, ll. 248-9, emphasis added).

A few lines earlier in the narrative, an explicit connection is made between the colour green and Irish poetry – and more subtly also between these elements and shaving/religion.[5] This happens when Mulligan exclaims: 'The bard's noserag! A new art colour for our Irish poets: snotgreen' (p. 4, l. 73), on returning Stephen's handkerchief with which he has just wiped his razor. Shortly after, Mulligan describes the sea as 'snotgreen' (p. 4, l. 78), too, which makes the connection between Irish poetry, the sea and (a little further on in the narrative) Mrs. Dedalus' vomit rather explicit. The introductory chapter of *Ulysses* hence holds a number of repeated lexical items that make up a fairly complex pattern of meaning by forcing together matters as diverse as bile, religion and Irish poetry. Within this pattern, meaning is transferred from one item to another with a rather repulsive image of religion and Irish poetry as a result.

It is worth noticing that even though the various occurrences of 'green', 'mother', 'bowl', and other repeated lexical items do not necessarily have the same referent, their effect is still cohesive. In Halliday & Hasan's words:

> reference is irrelevant to lexical cohesion. It is not by virtue of any referential relation that there is a cohesive force set up between two occurrences of a lexical item; rather, the cohesion exists as a direct relation between the forms themselves ... . (1976: 284)

This is to say that lexical form rather than semantic content makes lexical items cohesive. But how is it then, for example, with the

relation between 'bay' and 'bowl' and between 'sea' and 'mother'? These examples do not fit immediately into any of Halliday & Hasan's sub-categories of lexical cohesion. They most resemble synonymy, but they are clearly less cohesive than typical textbook examples of synonymy such as 'sound'/'noise' and 'cavalry'/'horses' (Halliday 1994: 331).[6] However, figuratively, the 'bay' is a 'bowl' just as, literally, 'sound' is 'noise', and the figurative ties that exist between the members of the former word pair clearly participate in the gluing together of the text and hence in the creation of texture. I will therefore argue that the possible metaphorical connection between lexical items like 'bay' and 'bowl' makes it seem reasonable to talk about *metaphorical synonymy*, which has a cohesive effect.[7] A result of including metaphorical relations in the classification of cohesive ties is the stretching to the limit of Halliday's claim (1994: 334) that a particular lexical item may be a member of very different lexical sets according to the context in which it occurs. Although this statement is made about collocational items, it appears to apply equally well to the decoding and categorisation of metaphorical cohesive ties.

An essential problem that makes itself felt if we extend Halliday & Hasan's cohesive categories as suggested above is the lack of hard-and-fast criteria as to what lexical items may and may not be categorised as metaphorical synonyms. While it is quite obvious that 'sound' and 'noise' are synonyms proper and would be cohesive in a given text, a certain element of interpretation obviously enters the otherwise relatively straightforward categorisation of cohesive ties when it comes to the occurrence of metaphorical synonymy like 'bay'/'bowl' above. It should, of course, not be an aim in itself to categorise, yet if we wish to understand and describe the texture of a given text, it would seem problematic that aspects of our methodology are based on the addressee's (subjective) interpretation of the text.

That the categorisation as metaphorical synonymy of the examples discussed above is not entirely random is supported by other cohesive elements in the passages, however. Having already given examples of this in my analysis of (3), I will just briefly add that in (2) the conjunctional tie 'so' furthers the cohesive connection between the references to Mulligan's shaving bowl and 'the boat of incense', while the connection between 'bay' and 'bowl' is supported by the grammatically parallel construction of (4) and the alliteration of 'the

bay ... a bowl of bitter waters' (p. 8, ll. 248-9). Added to this is a certain prominence in the chapter of the lexical item itself (i. e., 'bowl') that tends to arouse the reader's attention and make us look for possible patterns of meaning. It is thus not primarily the reader's subjective interpretation that makes 'bay' and 'bowl' and other metaphorical synonyms cohesive. On the contrary, various signals in the text itself indicate that ties exist between such items – ties that are not only cohesive but also significant meaning-making resources.

From this brief partial analysis of a number of cohesive ties in the first chapter of *Ulysses* it may thus be concluded that lexical sets are not necessarily relatively fixed conventional entities like the textbook examples mentioned earlier, but may be highly individual, creative and context-sensitive. Like more conventional instances of lexical cohesion, the metaphorical potential of language may hence establish cohesive ties, too, although the lexical items involved are elsewhere considered to be semantically very far apart. As a matter of fact, my examples above (and others) seem to point to a tendency within literature to employ as an important meaning-making resource the creation of new, surprising cohesive ties through the building-up of unusual lexical sets. What we see in Chapter 1 of Joyce's novel is, in fact, a rather extensive use of this particular technique, which results in a fairly intricate pattern of meanings to be decoded by the reader. This, of course, is not to say that metaphorical synonyms do not occur outside literary texts, yet their prevalence within this particular text type may open our eyes to the usefulness of extending Halliday & Hasan's concept of cohesion to include metaphorical synonymy – an extension that will also find its application outside literature.

2.2. Distant cohesion

The other aspect of lexical cohesion where the analysis of literature may throw light back on the linguistic theory employed is what I refer to as *distant cohesion*. In Halliday & Hasan (1976), as well as in most other analyses of textual cohesion,[8] attention is typically paid to what may be termed *local cohesion*. This is to say that cohesive devices are usually examined for their ability to create texture in texts or text passages of a relatively limited size; the linguistic items examined are mostly close together and their cohesive force is relatively strong. In a very illuminating way, for example, Eggins (1994: 85-95) demonstrates, by removing the cohesive ties from a number of short

texts, how texts rely on local cohesive ties for their texture. By removing these ties, Eggins also removes the texture of the texts and hence complicates their very status as text. Obviously, the texture of literary texts likewise depends on local cohesion, but the analysis of longer texts like a novel, for instance, indicates that yet another type of cohesive tie is of significance in such texts – that is, ties that have the effect of establishing patterns of meaning across fairly long stretches of text. In all fairness, it should be noted that Halliday & Hasan (1976: 294) mention in passing that 'cohesion can extend over very long sequences' and that 'writers exploit this potential by making cohesive ties across very long stretches of text', but with these brief comments they leave the subject.[9]

A very simple example of distant cohesion across long passages of text is the obvious cohesive ties that exist between references to Bloom throughout *Ulysses*. It clearly ties a literary text together that it contains one or more characters who are repeatedly referred to, and there can be no doubt that the figure referred to as 'Bloom' in Chapters 4 and 17, for instance, is one and the same character. A more complex example of distant cohesion is the description of Stephen's and Bloom's attire in Chapters 1 and 4 respectively, since these characters are both wearing mourning. In both chapters, this information is first indicated rather vaguely and is only later stated explicitly. In Chapter 1, it is mentioned in passing (yet in close proximity to the passages about Mrs. Dedalus' disease and death) that Stephen's coat-sleeve (and thus by inference also his coat) is black (p. 5, l. 101); that he will not wear grey trousers (p. 5, l. 120); and that his hat is black, too (p. 14, ll. 518-20). Only well into the chapter is it then stated explicitly that he is in mourning (p. 16, ll. 570-1). About Bloom's attire, we are first told that he believes he will be warm in the sun because of his black clothes (p. 46, ll. 78-9). Later a funeral is mentioned but no connection is made to Bloom's attire (p. 47, ll. 118-9 and 319). Not until the end of the chapter does Bloom's interior monologue reveal that he is wearing black because he is in mourning and is going to a funeral (p. 56-7, ll. 494-5 and 541-3).

What we have here is hence not verbatim repetition, but rather the building up of lexical sets having to do with the two characters' attire that may enable the reader to conclude that they are in mourning even before it is stated explicitly. In this way, a tie is made between

Stephen and Bloom that resembles the local cohesive ties examined above, although a difference clearly exists between the two kinds of relation. Where the repetition of 'green' in (4), for instance, partly functions to connect two succeeding sentences and signal to the reader what motivates Stephen's mental leap from the contemplation of the sea to the memory of his mother's violent vomiting, the distant cohesive ties between the descriptions of Stephen's and Bloom's attire are basically irrelevant to local texture but establish a pattern of meaning across several chapters. In this example, the linguistic parallel invites the reader to consider possible parallels between Stephen and Bloom and the fact that they are wearing mourning. We soon realise that Stephen is not only mourning his dead mother but also, like Hamlet, the absence of a father, while Bloom, who is wearing black because of an actual funeral, is furthermore reflecting on the near anniversary of his father's suicide and, more importantly, is mourning his dead son, Rudy. A central theme of the novel is hence introduced, namely that of a son in search of a father and a father in search of a son.

Another example of distant cohesion exists between the repeated occurrences of the lexical item 'dogsbody' (thrice accompanied by the epithet 'poor') in Chapters 1 and 3. Initially, the vocative 'poor dogsbody' is employed by Mulligan about Stephen (p. 5, l. 112), and shortly after it is repeated in Stephen's internal monologue when he is looking at himself in the mirror (p. 6, l. 137). Being thus repeated within a relatively brief sequence of text, this rather unusual expression is likely to be remembered by the reader, who may consequently recall it when encountering the dead dog in Chapter 3. In any case, the parallel is hard to miss when Stephen applies the full wording of Mulligan's vocative to the dead dog in lines 351-2 of the latter chapter, and the reader is consequently induced to consider the possible significances of the parallel.

While Halliday & Hasan (1976: e. g. 285-6) basically limit their study to the cohesive force of items occurring in strings of successive sentences, it seems obvious that a certain cohesion exists in the examples just examined, in spite of the fairly long distance between the cohesive items. In the case of Stephen's and Bloom's mourning apparel, there are cohesive ties between similar lexical sets; with 'dogsbody' we have an example of verbatim repetition. In contrast to

local cohesion, which is absolutely crucial to the textness of a text and the ease with which we may read it,[10] we do not necessarily miss distant cohesive ties that we do not notice in our reading, yet when we *do* notice them their effect is rather strong. It is, for example, quite possible to read and make sense of *Ulysses* without noticing the cohesive ties between the descriptions of Stephen's and Bloom's mourning apparel or between the occurrences of 'poor dogsbody'. But if we do not notice these ties we clearly miss out on significant meanings of the text, which indicates that these ties are, in fact, cohesive and thus play a role in gluing the text together.

Having examined the upper limit of cohesion and slightly expanded the concept by including distant cohesive ties as well as lexical sets[11] that are far more creative than those typically presented in textbooks on the subject, it would seem sensible also briefly to consider the lower limits of cohesion. A good example in this respect is the occurrences of the lexical item 'hat' in the following quotations:

> (5) – And there's your Latin quarter hat, he i.e. Buck Mulligan said. Stephen picked it up and put it on. (p. 14, ll. 519-20)
>
> (6) His i.e. Bloom's hand took his hat from the peg over his initialled heavy overcoat and his lost property office secondhand waterproof. (p. 46, ll. 66-7)

In the first example, cohesive ties obviously exist between the reference to Stephen's hat and the two instances of anaphoric pronominal reference to the same item by 'it' in the succeeding line. In the quotation from Chapter 4, expectancy relations exist between the lexical items 'hat', 'overcoat', and 'waterproof'. All these instances of cohesion consequently play a part in tying the text together and thus participate in the creation of local texture. Even though the lexical item 'hat' occurs in both chapters, however, no significant connection, and therefore no (distant) cohesive tie, exists between them. So although we encounter what may seem a pattern of repeated linguistic items, we cannot automatically infer that such patterns are cohesive. A comparison of the non-cohesive 'hat' example and the cohesion of the various occurrences of 'poor dogsbody' discussed above reveals that distant cohesion involves the same type of problem as metaphorical synonymy, namely the question of how we can know that distant lexical items are in fact cohesive. As with metaphorical synonymy, there can be no rigorous criteria as to which lexical elements are cohesive across longer stretches of text, and we cannot rule out the possibility that an element of readerly

interpretation goes into the categorisation of distant cohesive ties. The example of 'poor dogsbody' indicates that the repetition of relatively special lexical items is likely to be interpreted as a meaning-making cohesive relation, and it would seem sensible to suggest that this is also the case with other linguistic constructions of a special nature. More problematic are the references to Bloom and Stephen's mourning apparel that basically avoid drawing attention to themselves. What we see here is a stylistic backgrounding of elements that might be expected to be foregrounded because of their thematic significance. As a matter of fact, one might argue that by their conspicuous backgrounding, these details almost end up foregrounded. Stylistically, however, these and similar distant cohesive elements are not prominent and it consequently takes a very attentive reader to notice and decode them.

One of the things that make *Ulysses* so difficult is, in fact, Joyce's extensive exploitation of the meaning-potential involved in distant cohesion. Interestingly, this textual resource hence plays an important role in the construal of interpersonal meanings as regards the status of the text as a functional act of communication between the author and his readers. It is characteristic of the style of the novel that many important details avoid drawing much attention to themselves, yet participate in cohesive patterns whereby they gain significance. Thus, for instance, the fact that Stephen and Bloom are wearing mourning is only gradually revealed to the readers, who depend on their own ability to put together and decode the sparse information provided on the matter, which is spread out at long intervals in Chapters 1 and 4.

3. Conclusion

To a large extent, Joyce's use of the linguistic resource of cohesion makes his style of writing very creative and powerful. The extracts from *Ulysses* discussed here suggest that lexical cohesion is not always as straightforward as indicated by typical textbook examples. Since such examples are intended to clarify rather than confuse, it makes sense to make them simple, yet my analyses above nonetheless suggest the usefulness of operating with a slightly broader concept of cohesion than the one put forward by Halliday & Hasan (1976).

I willingly admit that the extensions proposed here make the concept of cohesion more complex and hence more difficult to handle, since both metaphorical synonymy and distant cohesion occasionally

involve a subjective element of interpretation which is generally avoided if we merely categorise as cohesive examples that fit more immediately into Halliday & Hasan's categories. I will nevertheless argue that we seriously limit our understanding and description of the texture of a given text if we do not take metaphorical and distant cohesion into consideration. Even though metaphorical synonymy and distant cohesive ties are particularly prevalent in literary texts, both types of cohesion also occur outside literature. The present article hence demonstrates how the application of Halliday & Hasan's concept of cohesion in literary analysis may reflect back on the concept itself, help us adjust it, and thus provide us with a better understanding of the ways in which texture is created in literary, as well as non-literary, texts.

Endnotes

[1]Parts of this article are based on my work on Hallidayan linguistics and literary analysis. For a more detailed exploration of the use of systemic functional linguistics for the analysis of literature, see Nørgaard (2003).

[2]Cf. e. g., Halliday & Hasan (1976) or Eggins (1994) for a detailed description of the various cohesive sub-categories.

[3]The total number of cohesive lexical items in any chapter of the novel is, of course, enormous. I shall only be dealing with a very limited selection of these items here.

[4]All references to *Ulysses* are to Joyce (1993), and have the following format: page number(s) followed by line number(s).

[5]For the connection between shaving and religion see example (1) above as well as Fowler (1986) and Nørgaard (2003).

[6]From a functional perspective it might be argued that two forms can never be strictly synonymous and that what we are dealing with here is near-synonymy rather than strict synonymy. Halliday himself gets round the problem by talking about 'a lexical item that is *in some sense* synonymous with a preceding one' (1994: 331, italics added).

[7]In a lucid study of meaning-production through lexical repetition in literary discourse, Verdonk (1995: 22-3) makes a similar analysis of a passage from *Mrs Dalloway* in which two lexical sets are established in a description of Mrs. Dalloway's home and life: one set referring to her actual physical surroundings, the other establishing the image of a convent. Since Verdonk's focus is not the specific links between the two sets and the cohesive force of those links, he simply talks about 'associative links between different semantic fields' while I will go a step further and categorise my examples above as reiteration – i. e., reiteration through metaphorical synonymy.

[8]Cf., e. g., Eggins (1994), Hasan (1984), and Hoey (1991).

[9]Verdonk (1995: 9) mentions in passing that 'when occurring over longer stretches of text, [lexical repetition] may have a ... controlling function in prose.'

[10]Cf. Eggins' experiment mentioned above (1994: 85-95).

[11]I. e., metaphorical synonymy.

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Humpty Dumpty's Fall: Failing to See the Writing on the Wall

Hande Tekdemir

Abstract

This paper discusses the potentialities in *Through The Looking-Glass* for challenging and overturning the conventional values imbedded in language. It focuses on one particular chapter from the book and studies it on a larger scale of children's literature, which is considered as a subversive strategy to redescribe and change our perception of the world through other wor[l]ds. Coming from a strictly normative society, Lewis Carroll, near the end of the 19th century, questions language through his ingenious character, Humpty Dumpty, and directs his attention to words, which for him (and his fictional character) are an inadequate means to fill the gaps in language. What happens if the efficacy of that language is called into question and is replaced by alternative semantic constructions? Exploration of this question challenges the boundaries of language and fiction, and becomes the boundary itself since the explorer is always on the run. Despite its limits, it is again language that opens up new possibilities, one of which is the unforgettable figure of Humpty Dumpty in *Through The Looking-Glass*.

Key words: dialogy; intertextuality; language; subversion; interpretation.

In her journey in *Through The Looking Glass*, one of the most prominent figures Alice meets is the egg-shaped Humpty Dumpty, a character in a nursery rhyme. As a well-educated Victorian child, Alice easily remembers the nursery rhyme that Humpty Dumpty belongs to:

> Humpty Dumpty sat on a wall:
> Humpty Dumpty had a great fall.
> All the King's horses and all the King's men
> Couldn't put Humpty Dumpty in his place again.
> (Carroll 2000: 208)

Because Alice has read him as a character in a book of nursery rhymes, she recognises Humpty Dumpty the moment she sees him on

the wall. Hence, without being introduced, Alice knows him to be an egg who falls down from the wall. She then tries to compare what she sees directly before her to what she has read:

> 'And how exactly like an egg he is!' [Alice] said aloud, standing with her hands ready to catch him, for she was every moment expecting him to fall.
>
> 'It's very provoking', Humpty Dumpty said after a long silence, looking away from Alice as he spoke, 'to be called an egg – *very*!'
>
> 'I said you *looked* like an egg, Sir', Alice gently explained. 'And some eggs are very pretty, you know', she added, hoping to turn her remark into a sort of compliment.
>
> 'Some people', said Humpty Dumpty, looking away from her as usual, 'have no more sense than a baby!' (Carroll 2000: 207-8)

The moment Alice attempts to interpret him as a reader interpreting a text, Humpty Dumpty is offended because according to himself, he exists as an independent being outside his textual identity. Jean-Jacques Lecercle (1994: 142) notes that

> … the confrontation between Alice and Humpty Dumpty throughout the chapter is one between interpretations. There are at least two views of Humpty Dumpty, both of which are entirely rational, i. e. coherent and textually founded.

In fact, Alice's interpretation refers to Humpty Dumpty's intertextual origin. Similarly, in other parts of *Through The Looking Glass*, other nursery-rhyme characters, such as Tweedledum and Tweedledee and the Lion and the Unicorn, are parodied with the purpose of indicating the fatalistic quality of their textual identity as they have to perform what is already written for them. Even Alice cannot prevent Humpty Dumpty's long expected fall despite all her warnings and pleadings. However, by coming to life in The Looking-Glass House, Humpty Dumpty and all the other nursery rhyme characters which should have been *literally* dead by now, challenge their textual identities. It is within the text in which they are reborn that they create just another interpretation of themselves.

For instance, at least temporarily in Lewis Carroll's text, Humpty Dumpty proves himself to be a thinking being who is clever at playing with words. This suggests the possibilities in fiction of making textual life persist through the intertextual exchange in Bakhtin's ([1929] 1973) use of the term. In order to grasp fully the dialogy between texts, it is crucial first of all to understand the dialogy within a single text and between two speakers. Humpty Dumpty and Alice are

engaged in a polemical dialogue concerning their different interpretations of the same situation. The fact that the conversation between Alice and Humpty Dumpty can embody or evoke different interpretations, ideas and points of view can be traced back to 'the Socratic concept of the dialogical nature of truth and of human thought about it …' as Bakhtin suggests in *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* ([1929] 1973: 90).

There is a striking similarity between the Socratic dialogues and those in the Alice books. Each of the Wonderland and Looking-Glass House inhabitants can be seen as another Socrates before Alice who stands for the 'official monologism' (Bakhtin [1929] 1973: 90). With their unexpected and to-the-point questions, these characters make Alice rethink all her previous knowledge, which represents a dogmatic worldview. In the dialogues, Socrates starts with a simple question that will trigger the discussion. He interrogates the people about their fixed assumptions and proves them to be false or misleading. He then convinces his interlocutors that *the truth* that is finally arrived at is *true*.

Similarly, Alice is interrogated by Humpty Dumpty. However, he differs from the real Socrates in that he helps Alice to find her own *truth* by awakening her to other possibilities through other wor[l]ds. For instance, Alice is brought up in a culture in which presents are given on special occasions such as birthdays. Therefore, she has difficulty in understanding the significance of an 'un-birthday present', and asks Humpty Dumpty what he means:

> 'I mean, what *is* an un-birthday present?'
>
> 'A present given when it isn't your birthday, of course'.
>
> Alice considered a little. 'I like birthday presents best', she said at last.
>
> 'You don't know what you're talking about!' cried Humpty Dumpty. 'How many days are there in a year?'
>
> 'Three hundred and sixty-five', said Alice.
>
> 'And how many birthdays have you?'
>
> 'One'.
>
> 'And if you take one from three hundred and sixty five, what remains?'
>
> 'Three hundred and sixty-four, of course'.
>
> Humpty Dumpty looked doubtful. 'I'd rather see that done on paper', he said.
>
> Alice couldn't help smiling as she took out her memorandum-book, and worked the sum for him:

> '… that shows that there are three hundred and sixty-four days when you might get un-birthday presents – '
>
> 'Certainly', said Alice.
>
> 'And only *one* for birthday presents, you know. There's glory for you!'
>
> (Carroll: 2000: 212-3)

Here is the Socrates in Humpty Dumpty, who proceeds step by step by asking properly ordered questions that lead the speaker herself to understand that there cannot be one ultimate 'truth'. This is also a parody of the Socratic method, and aims to prove the impossibility of a transcendental truth.

Although Humpty Dumpty plays a vital role in directing the conversation, his manipulative role grows excessive, to the point of violating one of the main principles of the Socratic dialogues and of communication in general. The problem with Humpty Dumpty is that he never condescends to take into consideration the other's responses to his utterances. He does not care to ascertain whether Alice is able to follow what he is saying and if she is interested or bored, awake or asleep. From the very beginning Alice is left out of the dialogue, which should be more properly called a monologue.

Humpty Dumpty is not the only character who behaves in a patronising manner towards Alice. She soon realises much to her chagrin that almost all Wonderland and Looking-Glass House inhabitants are reluctant to wait to receive feedback from her before going on with their 'unilateral attacks', which can hardly be called a conversation. Conversely, Alice seems to be aware of the responsive quality of the utterance. She checks the reactions of her 'opponents' before making a move, just like in a game of chess. She is zealous to understand the inhabitants of the other world, though she fails to do so. One of the reasons for this is Alice's 'rationality', which is irreconcilable with the disorder she encounters. However, the main reason is that Alice's addressees refuse to comply with their role as an addressee. Therefore, it is only to be expected that a mutual understanding in an uninterrupted dialogue is absent in the Alice books. This state of affairs is the exact opposite of what Bakhtin suggests in *Speech Genres and Other Essays:*

> Thus, all real and integral understanding is actively responsive, and constitutes nothing other than the initial preparatory stage of a response …. And the speaker himself is oriented precisely toward such an actively responsive understanding. He does not expect passive understanding that, so

> to speak, only duplicates his own idea in someone else's mind. Rather, he expects response, agreement, sympathy, objection, execution, and so forth ….
>
> And he presupposes not only the existence of the language system he is using, but also the existence of preceding utterances – his own and others' – with which his given utterance enters into one kind of relation or another. (1986: 69)

This is how we connect the dialogy between two speakers and two texts. A speaker or a text cannot be considered in isolation, as there is a continuous dialogue between past, present, and future, every time language is consumed in one way or another. Reference to other texts then becomes unavoidable, for every text has a memory of its own and considers itself situated within a historical disjunctive. This helps us realise the abundance of intertextual elements in the Alice books and to understand the logic behind Alice's frantic search for a normal being who can respond to her properly. Among all the inhabitants of Wonderland and the Looking-Glass House, Humpty Dumpty appears to be the most difficult one for Alice to communicate with because he has a totally unaccustomed and unsociable philosophy of language.

The most clearly unconventional point about Humpty Dumpty is his approach to words. Lecercle (1994: 143) posits that for Humpty Dumpty, a name is 'not a mark but a cluster of descriptions'. Obviously, definitions are abundant in Humpty Dumpty's philosophy. When Alice tells Humpty Dumpty her name, he responds as follows:

> 'It's a stupid name enough!' Humpty Dumpty interrupted impatiently.
>
> 'What does it mean?'
>
> '*Must* a name mean something?' Alice asked doubtfully.
>
> 'Of course it must', Humpty Dumpty said with a short laugh: '*my* name means the shape I am – and a good handsome shape it is, too. With a name like yours, you might be any shape, almost'. (Carroll 2000: 208)

The name Humpty Dumpty phonetically evokes plumpness, roundness. As Lecercle (1994: 145) notes, 'If a name is determined by sounds or by a text, we cannot be assured of a true or even a firm interpretation. All we can obtain is a multiplicity of interpretations … multiplicity of potential meanings'. It is therefore fitting that Humpty Dumpty's intertextual origin is a riddle, and perhaps this is why Humpty Dumpty considers every question Alice asks as a riddle.

In contrast to the descriptive quality of proper names, Humpty Dumpty dwells on the arbitrariness of common nouns. As Martin Gardner notes in his annotated edition (Carroll 2000), Humpty

Dumpty overturns the common way (208). Instead of proper names, Humpty Dumpty develops an extremely personal approach concerning common nouns. He ignores the socially interactive nature of language and naming. As a result, he has to define each word he utters in order to communicate with Alice because she is unable to understand his idiosyncratic use of nouns.

> 'I don't know what you mean by "glory"', Alice said.
>
> Humpty Dumpty smiled contemptuously. 'Of course you don't – till I tell you. I meant "there's a nice knock-down argument for you!"'
>
> 'But "glory" doesn't mean "a nice knock-down argument"', Alice objected.
>
> 'When *I* use a word', Humpty Dumpty said, in rather a scornful tone, 'it means just what I choose it to mean – neither more nor less'.
>
> 'The question is', said Alice, 'whether you *can* make words mean so many different things'.
>
> 'The question is', said Humpty Dumpty, 'which is to be master – that's all'.
>
> (Carroll 2000: 213)

This becomes at the same time a question of empowerment. Power goes to the one who dictates the meaning of the word, with total disregard for the communally shared meaning of that word. This is ironic because though Humpty Dumpty assumes the role of Adamic naming, he is unable to employ the same strategy for himself. His philosophy of naming seems to be contradicting his fatalistic name.

Yet, though Humpty Dumpty cannot change his own fate, he can write it anew. It should be noted in passing that Humpty Dumpty can violate his textual existence within the boundaries of another text, which is the book written by Lewis Carroll. It is thanks to the iterability of language that Humpty Dumpty comes alive in *Through the Looking-Glass*, though it is again because of the 'prison-house of language' into which he is born that he has to die. Humpty Dumpty's fall, which 'shakes the forest from end to end', contradictorily announces his death as a speaking subject in one text and his birth as a written subject in another.

This is how Humpty Dumpty's naming conforms to the way he was named. Just as he creates a new identity for himself, Humpty Dumpty is confident that he can give existing words a totally new semantic content and act as if they belong solely to him. Moreover, he wants Alice to accept his meanings. For instance, while conversing with Alice, Humpty Dumpty claims that the word 'impenetrability' means 'we've had enough of that subject, and it would be just as well if

you'd mention what you mean to do next, as I suppose you don't mean to stop here all the rest of your life' (213). Alice's reaction is: 'That's a great deal to make one word mean …' (Carroll 2000: 213).

Bakhtin reflects on the theory of language and indicates the concurrence of the social and personal use:

> Therefore, one can say that any word exists for the speaker in three aspects: as a neutral word of a language, belonging to nobody; as an *other's* word, which belongs to another person and is filled with echoes of the other's utterance; and, finally, as *my* word, for, since I am dealing with it in a particular situation, with a particular speech plan, it is already imbued with my expression. (1986: 88)

Humpty Dumpty defies the first two aspects that Bakhtin is talking about, by insisting on being an 'Adam'. He rejects the model of linguistic communication in which a speech community agrees that a certain sound or combination of sounds refers to a certain thing. He refuses the fact that communication is grounded in such agreement, and associates idiosyncratic, personal meanings with traditional words, consciously disregarding their shared meaning. Without such agreed-upon and shared meanings, language and communication – dialogue – would be impossible.

Lewis Carroll exaggerates in Humpty Dumpty the idiosyncratic use of language to such a degree that he succeeds in drawing the reader's attention to certain aspects of discourse, of communication, to which we pay hardly any heed in our normal everyday lives. Through the comic figure of Humpty Dumpty, we are awakened to the problems inherent in language and communication. Humpty Dumpty's 'impenetrability' may also suggest that he is in fact facing the problem of every speaker each time he or she attempts to talk and to be understood. His loneliness indicates how individuals paradoxically become both the victims and the survivors of language because of its social aspect and idiosyncratic use. Language bears in itself both enslaving and liberating tendencies. It emerges as all-powerful and omniscient, not only in the other realms but also in our own. Each one of us is another Humpty Dumpty who creates language practically anew every day, without seeing the writing on the wall.

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Crossing the Boundaries of Flesh and Narrative

Fiona Tomkinson

Abstract

This article deals with the boundary between language and the pre-reflective, taking as point(s) of departure Hélène Cixous' concept (and project) of *writing the body* – a project that also crosses the boundaries of theoretical and poetic discourse. It argues that a more rigorous theoretical formulation of the relation between flesh and narrative can be found in the hermeneutic and phenomenological writings of Paul Ricoeur and Maurice Merleau-Ponty. Ricoeur has created an over-arching theory covering metaphor, narrative and judgement, all of which he asserts to exist in a dialectical relationship with the pre-reflective. Starting with his account of metaphor and the pre-reflective, I show how it can be extended to cover narrative and judgement. However, I also take this theory a step further with the aid of some concepts taken from Merleau-Ponty – *chiasm* and *dialectic without synthesis* – in order to show that the boundary between the pre-reflective and language is a frontier that can be crossed, but where something is always lost in the crossing. In order to continue the project of interweaving the literary and poetic with the theoretical, the theories in question are interlaced with extracts from John Keats and D. H. Lawrence that act as their illustrations and concretisations.

Key words: phenomenology; Romanticism; metaphor; narrativity; Cixous; Ricoeur; Merleau-Ponty.

What I shall attempt in this paper is a (partial) exploration of the relationship between *flesh* and *narrative*, of the boundaries between them, and the ways in which these boundaries can be crossed. *Flesh* I would like to use as an enveloping term which covers both the *body* and the *concrete* and *contingent*, as well as what in phenomenological terms would be called the *pre-reflective*, and what in Frege's ([1892] 1952) terminology would stand on the side of *reference* rather than *sense*, that is, the side of the actual object referred to by language rather than its meaning in the human mind. Narrative, for reasons that should later become clear, I shall also take in a very wide sense, which encompasses not only story-telling, but also *the question of metaphor* and *the question of judgement*.

My starting point is the concept of *writing the body* as it occurs in French feminist theory, in particular in the work of Hélène Cixous. What impresses me most in the writings of Cixous is not the aspect which can be interpreted in terms of the demarcation of boundaries, that is, the theorisation of sexual difference with its identification of – or indeed enforcement of – gender-based binary oppositions, but rather that which tends towards the dissolution of the boundaries between the physical and the spiritual, the poetic and the theoretical, and her way of reminding us of the sheer untidiness of the flesh. This tendency is especially marked in *Rootprints*, where, insisting that 'first of all we are sentient beings', she makes an analogy between writing and the emotions: in the same way that it can be said of love that 'it begins with a burning in the chest, and after it is called love', so 'writing deploys itself before it is called'. (Cixous 1997: 18) She also reminds us that 'Writing is a physical effort, this is not said often enough', and adds, 'As for reading: reading feels to me like a making love'. (Cixous 1997: 18)

For Cixous, the beginning of writing is situated in a grandeur of the pre-reflective: 'What sets me writing is that lava, that flesh, that blood, those tears ... . They are worked on in all the great tragic texts; it was their flesh, it was their body'. (Cixous 1997: 12) Yet she also reminds us that, suddenly, at a climactic tragic moment you have a handkerchief problem and you think, 'what's more tomorrow I'm going to have puffy eyes' as well (Cixous 1997: 20). Yet, of course, the lost handkerchief and the snuffly nose not only disrupt a narrative but are also caught up in one. Indeed, sometimes a handkerchief problem may take centre-stage in tragic narrative – as a certain Shakespearean play demonstrates. How can this problematic relationship between the pre-reflective and narrative be theorised?

I shall try to answer this question with the help of some concepts taken from Maurice Merleau-Ponty and Paul Ricoeur, who, I believe, give us a more rigorous theoretical discussion of issues that Cixous tends to assert poetically. However, I also wish to ask what the relationship would be between such a theorisation and poetic language itself. When Cixous asserts that 'The truth sings true' because 'It engages a discourse that goes through the belly, through the entrails, through the chest' (Cixous 1997: 46), or that 'The process of writing is to circulate, to caress, to paint all the phenomena before they are

precipitated, assembled, crystallized in a word' (Cixous 1997: 18), there is a striking resemblance between her thought and that of Romantic and post-Romantic writers who insisted that 'axioms in philosophy are not axioms until they are proved upon our pulses' (Keats 1970b: 93), or warned: 'He that sings a lasting song/Thinks in a marrow bone' (Yeats 1995: 326). This leads us to the question of whether writing in this tradition, as much as contemporary hermeneutics or phenomenology, may give us some answers to questions concerning flesh and narration.

I shall therefore attempt to cross the boundaries between poetic and theoretical discourse by interlacing the theoretical approaches of Ricoeur and Merleau-Ponty on this question with three extracts from the poetry and letters of Keats, and also two extracts from the prose of D. H. Lawrence, with the aim of theorising the concrete and concretising the theoretical (perhaps I should say theorising the flesh and fleshing out theory).[1]

To begin with the theoretical: I would like to take up Ricoeur's way of bringing together metaphor, narrative and judgement, which can all be taken as what he calls a 'synthesis of the heterogeneous'. Ricoeur makes this connection explicit in the case of metaphor and narrative, showing the resemblance between the predicative assimilation in the semantic innovation of metaphor and the 'grasping together' of multiple and scattered events in a plot (Ricoeur 1984: x). Elsewhere he makes it clear that the process of selection involved in emplotment is tantamount to the exercise of judgement, and that a 'narrative that fails to explain is less than a narrative' (Ricoeur 1984: 148). Metaphor, narrative and judgement are all instruments for structuring, shattering and enriching our sense of reality. All are intimately related to action, as Ricoeur makes clear in *Oneself as Another* when he speaks of the 'polysemy of action' in terms of the triad of description, narration and prescription (Ricoeur 1994: 125), which can be understood as the exercise of our capacity to create, respectively, metaphor, narrative and judgement. Indeed, there is a sense in which it can be said that metaphor is almost already narrative, and narrative is always already judgement. For Ricoeur all these are in a dialectical relationship with flesh, which, in the closing words of *The Rule of Metaphor*, he calls 'the dialectic that reigns between the experience of belonging as a whole and the power of distanciation that opens up the space of speculative thought' (Ricoeur 1977: 313).

The relationship between language and the pre-reflective is affirmed in Ricoeur's theory of metaphor through the rejection of the idea that metaphor, at least live metaphor, is merely the substitution of a figurative term for a literal one. Instead, he gives us an interaction theory of metaphor, in which both terms undergo an alteration of meaning according to their place in the entire statement. This is related to the pre-reflective in the sense that it deals not only with metaphor as a 'seeing-as', but also as the revealer of a 'being-as' on the deepest ontological level, with metaphorical reference as well as metaphorical sense, and with the true locus of metaphor being situated in the copula 'to be' (Ricoeur 1977: 247-255). In other words, metaphor is a feeling for the object of reference, which illustrates Ricoeur's conviction that there is nothing more ontological than feeling.

I would like to take Ricoeur's theory of metaphor one stage further, through the application of some concepts taken from Merleau-Ponty, a thinker with whom Ricoeur has acknowledged a great deal of affinity. I shall then try to show how this interpretation of metaphor can be extended to other types of description and to the other types of semantic innovation: narrative and judgement.

The Merleau-Pontian concepts are those of *chiasm* or *reversibility* and of *dialectic without synthesis* – a two-way crossing of the boundaries, where at the same time what is carried over is never complete – where there is always something left behind, like a lost handkerchief.

Merleau-Ponty's concept of *reversibility* arises from his interpretation of flesh as something neither subject nor object: *perception* as *reversibility* shows that the relationship between the self and the world is neither one of separation (as in idealism) nor of coincidence (as in materialism), but of interchange. But at the same time reversibility is an asymmetrical movement in which the two terms involved can never pass over into each other entirely. As such it may be seen in terms of the dialectic without synthesis – a progression that distinguishes itself from Hegelian dialectic by the fact that *something*, but not *everything* is carried forward.[2]

Reversibility, which is applied by Merleau-Ponty to the operation of perception at a number of different levels, may also be applied to give us a good account of what happens between the two terms of a

metaphor, where our understanding of each is modified by that of the other, but where a complete identification does not take place, since we are aware that they are connected to us not only by the copula *is* but also by the *is not*. Sometimes in poetic expression this chiasmatic process of metaphor is intensified to the extent that the crossing or transformation and also the residue of *what is not carried over* become clearer than is normally the case. This by analogy with Merleau-Ponty's concepts of *hyper-reflection* (the self-conscious and self-critical use of Cartesian or reflective thought) and *hyper-dialectic* (the self-conscious and self-critical use of Hegelian or dialectical thought) I shall call *hypermetaphor* – let us say a self-conscious metaphor seemingly aware of its incomplete powers of transformation, of the accidents of transubstantiation. To give an example of this I should like to turn to my first extract from Keats, famous lines from the 'Ode to a Nightingale':

> Oh, for a beaker full of the warm South
> Full of the true, the blushful Hippocrene,
> With beaded bubbles winking at the brim
> And purple-stainèd mouth
> That I might drink and leave the world unseen ...
> (Keats 1970a: 526)

When I was at secondary school I had a copy of this poem in which a previous student had added to this stanza the marginal gloss 'wants wine' (two stanzas later, of course, 'not charioted by Bacchus and his pards' was glossed as 'no longer wants wine'). At the time I thought this comical because obvious. After all these years, I wonder if the case is so simple. Is it exactly wine that is being spoken of here, since the Hippocrene is actually a spring of *water*?

Everything hinges on the value of the word *true* in the phrase 'the true, the blushful Hippocrene': is it merely an assertion that wine rather than any sacred spring is the true source of inspiration? Or, more subtly, that the true water of the Hippocrene remains within the wine? As Miriam Allott points out in her edition of Keats, the trope of 'blushful water' was common in 17th-century references to the miracle at Cana: water is a nymph who is transformed into wine when she blushes at the presence of the Lord God (Keats 1970a: 526). What I think we actually have, is a description of wine metaphorically represented as water, yet as water that is in the process of metamorphosis, assuming the characteristics of wine.

A little later in the poem the reverse process takes place with the phrase 'The coming musk-rose full of *dewy wine*'. (Keats 1970a: 528) Here water is metaphorically described as wine, which is then adjectively described as water once again. We have a miracle at Cana that works in two directions, and leaves traces of wine in water, traces of water in wine.

This reversibility goes beyond the level of individual metaphors in the poem. When I first read 'Ode to a Nightingale', I asked myself which way the *magic casements* opened: were they magic windows in the sea or the windows of faery palaces on the strand? Perhaps the answer is that they also open both ways into 'mytho-poetic depths' (Ricoeur 1985: 67) which are both inside and outside: like the casement that stands open at the end of the 'Ode to Psyche' celebrating the opening of the mind on the universe, and of the universe to the mind.[3] To quote a thought of Hegel taken up by Merleau-Ponty: the leaving oneself is a retiring into oneself and *vice versa*.[4] The reversibility of the metaphoric process mirrors that of the relationship between the mind and that which is outside it.

Descriptive reversibility does not, however, only take place in moments of high seriousness, or only through metaphor. As an example of this, my second extract from Keats is a bawdy passage from a letter to his brothers, showing the kind of conversation that gentlemen indulged in when the ladies had retired:

> ... a younger brother of the Squibs made himself very conspicuous ... by giving Mater Omnium—Mr Redhall said he did not understand anything but plain english—where at Rice egged the young fool on to say the World [sic] plainly out. After which there was an enquirey [sic] about the derivation of the Word C—t when while two parsons and Grammarians were setting together and settling the matter Wm Squibs interrupting them said a very good thing—"Gentleman says he I have always understood it to be a Root and not a Derivitive. [sic]"
>
> (Keats 1970b: 47)

The comedy here comes from the collision between signifier and flesh, between 'C—t' as taboo word and as fleshly object – a collision made all the more telling by the slip which gives us 'world' for 'word'. We have here a salutary warning against linguistic idealism, a true return to the mother of all things in plain English (It is also interesting that Keats spells the word derivative with *i* instead of an *a*. Although on one level there is no need to read anything more into this

than the fact that he was a poor speller, the variant nevertheless makes it seem as if the word *derivation* might be derived from *vita* – is perhaps a *vitiation* of *vita* ...).

The letter then immediately moves from the female to the male organ of generation in an almost Joycean passage where the word-play depends on a chiasmatic reversal of terms. The gentlemen have by now drunk quite a lot of wine and need to relieve themselves:

> On proceeding to the Pot in the Cupboard it soon became full on which the Court door was opened Frank Floodgate bawls out, Hoollo! Here's an opposition pot— Ay, says Rice in one you have a Yard for your pot, and in the other a pot for your Yard—
>
> (Keats 1970b: 47)

Here, in punning as in metaphor, we have a displacement and substitution of terms – but *not only that* – I would like to suggest that the joke would not be funny if we could not speak of a chiasmatic reversal of reference (between *yard* as 'area outside a house' and *yard* as 'penis') as well as of a reversal of sense – in Ricoeur's terms a feeling of 'being as' as well as 'seeing-as'.

Ricoeur extends his conception of the ontological nature of metaphor to narrative, seeing our understanding of the importance of narrativity to identity to reside in the pre-reflective, in 'an intuitive precomprehension of this state of affairs' (Ricoeur 1991: 188). I would contend that the boundary-crossing of *chiasm* also takes place in narrative on a number of levels from the turning point or *peripeteia* of classical tragedy, to the relationship between the various forms of representation or *mimesis* distinguished by Ricoeur: the mimesis which already takes place at the level of the pre-reflective, the mimesis of emplotment, and finally that which is created in the act of reading. Likewise, if metaphor has something in it of an incomplete transition, the same can be said of narrative, in that its progress always involves partial synthesis, the dropping of certain threads as well as the continuation of others. There is always something inert that is not taken up by the forward movement of even the tautest plot, a loose end that has to be left dangling.

The same can be said of *judgement* as an act of the semantic imagination. On the one hand, all the available information cannot be gathered – something always escapes our finitude – on the other, even within that which is gathered, something always escapes the synthesis

of judgement. And although judgement may seem to be something that is above and imposed upon the flesh, judgements are also of the flesh and fleshly. This is expressed in Ricoeur's theory of judgement with its insistence on difficult, specific cases that can only be left to the application of *phronesis* or practical wisdom. Judgement in this sense becomes flesh – yet this is a disturbing position to defend, since there is a danger that judgement can thus be reduced to the arbitrary. To illustrate this danger I would like to quote a passage on judgement and flesh from another writer in the (post)-Romantic tradition, D. H. Lawrence. The extract is from *Sea and Sardinia*:

> No, but convicts are horrible creatures: at least, the old one is, with his long, nasty face: his long, clean-shaven, horrible face, without emotions, or with emotions that one cannot follow .... It is a great mistake to abolish the death penalty. If I were dictator I should order the old one to be hung at once. I should have judges with sensitive, living hearts: not abstract intellects. And because the instinctive heart recognised a man as evil, I would have that man destroyed. Quickly. Because good warm life is now in danger. (Lawrence 1999: 15-6)

Lawrence also lives out this fantasy of summary justice based on appearances in the person of Cipriano in *The Plumed Serpent*. Cipriano's method of dealing with captured bandits is as follows:

> He stripped his captives and tied them up. But if it seemed a brave man, he would swear him in. If it seemed to him a knave, a treacherous cur, he stabbed him to the heart .... (Lawrence 1926: 365)

Perhaps Lawrence himself would not have ever acted on this fantasy, and certainly Ricoeur would not use the concept of practical wisdom to justify killing someone because you don't like their face. A 'Romantic' approach to the emotions is not incompatible with the ability to resist them to some degree in making moral judgements: Keats was capable of distinguishing between the fact that 'a quarrel in the street is a thing to be hated' and the fact that 'the energies displayed in it are fine' (Keats 1970b: 230). Nevertheless, I think these passages from Lawrence bring to light a troubling arbitrariness inextricable from the flesh and the semantic imagination whose boundaries it crosses.

It is on this note that I would like to close, with another passage which concretises the relationship between flesh, narrative and judgement – a tale from another of Keats's letters: a fleshly narrative which has for me something of the quality of Kafka's philosophical fables. The story, narrated at the end of a letter to Rice, also begins with the crossing of a boundary: a man has to carry his wife across a ford:

> ... and his Wife being pregnant and troubled, as in such cases is very common with strange longings, took the strangest that ever was heard of— Seeing her Husband's foot, a hansome on [*for* one] enough looking very clean and tempting in the clear water, on their arrival at [the] other bank she earnestly demand[ed] a bit of it; he being an affectionate fellow and fearing for the comliness of his child gave her a bit which he cut off with his Clasp knife—Not satisfied she asked another morsel—supposing there might be twins he gave her a slice more. Not yet contented she craved another Piece. (Keats 1970b: 342)

Now comes the moment of judgement! How much flesh can be sacrificed for the sake of flesh, and how do we respond to the possibility that the other's demands on us may be infinite?

> "You Wretch cries the Man, would you wish me to kill myself? take that!" Upon which he stabb'd her with the knife, cut her open and found three Children in her Belly two of them very comfortable with their mouth's shut, the third with its eyes and mouth stark staring open "Who would have thought it" cried the Wid[ow]er, and pursued his journey—, Brown has a little rumbling in his Stomach this morning—
>
> Ever yours sincerely
> John Keats—
> (Keats 1970b: 342)

This terrible story can be taken as an allegory of the workings of the semantic imagination and its rootedness in the flesh – there is a relationship of reversibility between the man and his unseen children as he trades flesh in exchange for flesh, wishful suppositions against desire, but what is carried over is inevitably insufficient on both sides – yet the journey nevertheless continues and the flesh continues to rumble and to disrupt.

Endnotes

[1]This is not, of course, to assert that there is nothing theoretical in Romantic writing: Keats himself frequently expressed concern with the passage from the pre-reflective to the reflective, explicitly dealt with in many passages in his work, such as the description of the 'pleasure thermometer' in *Endymion*, Book I, ll. 777-842 (Keats 1970a: 154-7) – which bears some resemblance to Ricoeur's analysis of *eros* in *Fallible Man* (Ricoeur 1986: 139-150) – and perhaps most memorably in his metaphor of the passage into the chamber of Maiden Thought in the letter to J. H. Reynolds of 3 May 1818 (Keats 1970b: 95-6).

[2]The *locus classicus* for an account of the hyperdialectic is Merleau-Ponty (1968: 126-9). For a fuller account of the relationship between chiasm and dialectic in Merleau-Ponty see Tomkinson (2000).

[3]'And there shall be for thee all soft delight/That shadowy thought can win,/ A bright torch, and a casement ope at night,/To let the warm Love in!' (Keats 1970a: 521).

[4]'I was able to appeal from the others to myself and take the route of reflection only because first I was outside of myself, in the world, among the others, and constantly this experience feeds my reflection. Such is the total situation that a philosophy must account for. It will do so only by admitting the double polarity of reflection, and by admitting that, as Hegel said, to retire into oneself is also to leave oneself' (Merleau-Ponty 1968: 49).

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